A DISSERTATION IN FIVE PARTS

THE CHOICE IN THE MACHINE

Prohairetic Realism and the Thermodynamics of Assent in the Wachowskis' Matrix Cycle



THE REAL IS NOT WHAT THE RED PILL DISCLOSES. IT IS THE SWALLOWING.

¿Qué es la vida? Una ilusión, / una sombra, una ficción … / que toda la vida es sueño, / y los sueños, sueños son.
— *Pedro Calderón de la Barca,* La vida es sueño *(1635), Jornada II*

Of things some are in our power, and others are not.
— *Epictetus,* Enchiridion *1, trans. Elizabeth Carter (1758)*

// SUMMARY

Abstract

This dissertation offers a comprehensive philosophical reconstruction of the Matrix cycle: *The Matrix* (1999); *The Animatrix*, *The Matrix Reloaded*, and *The Matrix Revolutions* (2003); and *The Matrix Resurrections* (2021). It advances an original ontological position, prohairetic realism, which it argues the cycle develops serially across its installments.

The first movement situates the films within the traditions they draw on. These include Platonic anabasis and the pedagogy of the cave; Cartesian hyperbolic doubt and Putnam's semantic rebuttal of it; Nozick's experience machine and Chalmers's virtual realism; Baudrillard's precession of simulacra and Žižek's Lacanian counter-reading; Sethian and Valentinian Gnosticism, the Hymn of the Pearl, and the late theology of Philip K. Dick; Madhyamaka and Advaita soteriology; Christological typology and the history of theodicy; Stoic, Humean, and Frankfurtian accounts of freedom; the philosophy of mind from Turing to Searle, together with the cybernetic theory of emergence; Heidegger's critique of technology, the posthumanisms of Haraway and Hayles, and trans theory; and the critique of political economy from Marx through Debord, Althusser, and Zuboff. A comparative chapter reads the cycle against Forster, Butler, Čapek, Galouye, Lem, Dick, Gibson, Stephenson, Egan, Le Guin, Chiang, Oshii, Proyas, Cronenberg, and Weir.

The second movement argues that these inheritances do not sit side by side eclectically. The cycle stages them as a sequence of exhausted frameworks. The epistemic question of whether a world is real gives way to the metaphysical question of what it is made of, and that in turn gives way to the practical question of what an agent does within it. Three demonstrations anchor the argument:

1. The thermodynamic impossibility of the human battery is read as a confession rather than a narrative defect: what the machines harvest is not heat but assent.
2. The Architect's account of the Matrix's successive versions recapitulates the history of Western theodicy, from Leibnizian perfection through Irenaean soul-making to the free-will defense. It concludes, as that history did, that no stable order can dispense with the choice to refuse it.

3 Zion is the Disneyland of the Real: a reservation of authenticity whose existence certifies the system it opposes.

From these demonstrations the dissertation derives prohairetic realism. On this thesis, a world's reality for an agent is conferred neither by its substrate nor by its correspondence to a transcendent original. It is conferred by the world's capacity to host choices that are constitutive rather than merely registered, the paradigm being the performative act of naming oneself. The cycle's final movement, from the solitary One to the reciprocal Two of *Resurrections*, extends this ontology from a single agent to a pair. The real, on this account, is not what the red pill discloses. It is the swallowing.

Contents

Abstract 3

Part I Doubt and Simulation 7

1 Introduction: A Splinter in the Mind of Philosophy 8

2 Cave, Demon, Vat: The Epistemological Inheritance and Its Exhaustion 16

3 The Hollowed Book: Baudrillard, Žižek, and the Desert of the Real 25

Part II The Soteriologies 34

4 The Demiurge's Machine: Gnostic Cosmology, the Hymn of the Pearl, and the Twin 35

5 Maya, Emptiness, and the Spoon: Buddhist and Vedantic Soteriologies 47

6 The Messiah Algorithm: Christological Typology and the Architect's Theodicy 56

Part III Choice, Mind, and Body 66

7 The Merovingian's Clockwork: Causality, Prophecy, and the Stoic Remainder 67

8 Programs That Love: Machine Minds, Emergence, and the Evolutionary Psyche 77

9 Residual Self-Image: Embodiment, Standing-Reserve, and the Trans Ontology of the Pod 85

Part IV The Engine and the Constellation 94

10 The Plantation of Attention: Political Economy, Spectacle, and the Consent Engine 95

11 A Constellation of Simulated Worlds: The Matrix among Speculative Fictions 106

Part V The Choice in the Machine 118

12 The Choice in the Machine: Toward a Prohairetic Realism 119

13 Conclusion: After the Desert 131

Works Cited 134

Keywords 142

PART

I

Doubt and Simulation

CHAPTERS 1–3



CHAPTER

01

Introduction: A Splinter in the Mind of Philosophy

> 1.1 The Blockbuster as Treatise
> 1.2 Corpus, Periodization, and Method
> 1.3 Genealogy of Sources: The Assigned and the Unassigned Archive
> 1.4 The Argument in Brief
> 1.5 Chapter Architecture

1.1 The Blockbuster as Treatise

Few commercial films have been absorbed into academic philosophy as quickly as *The Matrix*. Within four years of its release it had a dedicated secondary literature: William Irwin's *The Matrix and Philosophy* (2002), Glenn Yeffeth's *Taking the Red Pill* (2003), and Christopher Grau's *Philosophers Explore The Matrix* (2005). The franchise's official website commissioned philosophical essays, among them David Chalmers's "The Matrix as Metaphysics." The 2004 *Ultimate Matrix Collection* added a "philosopher commentary" track by Cornel West and Ken Wilber; West had by then been written into the sequels as a councillor of Zion. The film entered introductory epistemology syllabi as the standard vehicle for the problem of the external world, re-costuming the brain in a vat.

This absorption was a kind of domestication. Philosophers mostly treated the film as illustration: an expensive thought experiment that made vivid positions already stated more precisely elsewhere, whether Platonic, Cartesian, or Putnamian. On that view the film philosophizes only in the weak sense that a diagram proves a theorem. It occasions the argument without conducting it.

This dissertation contests that view. The claim is not merely that the Matrix cycle *contains* philosophy, which could be said of any narrative dense with allusion. The claim is that the cycle, taken as a serial and self-revising whole, *advances an argument*. That argument ends in an ontological position that cannot be reduced to its sources and was not anticipated by them in combination. I call that position prohairetic realism.

The claim must be placed within the "film as philosophy" debate that took shape just after the trilogy was completed. Stephen Mulhall's *On Film* (2002) proposed that certain films do more than illustrate: they are "philosophy in action," reflecting on and evaluating views in a way continuous with philosophical practice. Thomas Wartenberg (2007) offered a more modest account in which films screen thought experiments, supply counterexamples, and dramatize arguments. Paisley Livingston (2006) answered with a dilemma aimed at what he called the "bold thesis." If a film's philosophical contribution can be paraphrased in propositions, the contribution is not exclusively cinematic. If it cannot, its status as philosophy becomes obscure.

This dissertation accepts the first horn but not its implication. The propositional content of the cycle's argument can be paraphrased, and Chapter 12 paraphrases it. Its demonstrative force, however, depends on a formal feature that no single film or treatise possesses: seriality. Each installment retroactively reclassifies the metaphysics of the one before it:

- The Gnostic ascent of 1999 turns out, in 2003, to be a subroutine of the system it thought it had escaped.
- The systemic determinism of 2003 turns out, in that same year's conclusion, to be exceeded by an act it could predict but not absorb.
- The whole trilogy turns out, in 2021, to have been digested by the very apparatus of cultural production it had allegorized.

The cycle therefore argues by something like the Greek geometers' method of exhaustion. Eudoxus approximated a curve by inscribing polygons with ever more sides. The cycle approximates the real by inscribing and discarding one ontology after another, until what remains is the single element none of them could contain.

1.2 Corpus, Periodization, and Method

The corpus comprises the four feature films and the canonical ancillary texts the Wachowskis wrote or supervised. These include *The Animatrix* (2003), especially the two-part "Second Renaissance," which supplies the history of machine emancipation. They also include the game *Enter the Matrix* (2003), whose live-action material was written and directed as a bridge between the sequels, and, more peripherally, *The Matrix Online* and *The Matrix: Path of Neo* (both 2005). Henry Jenkins (2006) made this ensemble the paradigm case of "transmedia storytelling," a narrative spread across platforms so that no single text contains the whole. As Chapter 3 argues, that dispersal is philosophically significant. It makes the franchise a system of copies without a master text, which is precisely the condition Baudrillard called simulation.

The dissertation distinguishes three moments:

- **The Gnostic moment (1999)** stages liberation as knowledge. The world is a prison of appearances, and salvation consists in waking.
- **The Systemic moment (2003)** retracts that promise. The Architect reveals that Zion has been destroyed five times and that the One is a recurring function of the system. Knowledge becomes a mechanism of control, and the cycle must look for freedom somewhere other than in knowing.
- **The Reflexive moment (2021)** turns the apparatus on itself. In *Resurrections* the trilogy exists inside the story as a celebrated video game. Its sequel is commissioned by the same corporation that produced the actual film. The question of freedom moves from the solitary exception to the relation between two people.

The method has four parts. The first is philosophical close reading attentive to set design and naming, on the premise, amply warranted by the films' density, that props, numbers, and names function as argument. Neo's apartment is number 101, the number of Orwell's chamber of the worst fear. He dies and revives in room 303 of a hotel called the Heart O' the City. The Oracle's kitchen bears the Latin *temet nosce*, a rendering of the Delphic "know thyself." The hovercraft's plaque identifies it as Mark III No. 11. Its name recalls the Babylonian king who demanded that his dream be interpreted before he had told it (Daniel 2).

The second part is genealogical reconstruction. It separates documented influence (texts the directors assigned, cited, or reproduced) from structural affinity, where the resemblance can be shown but the lineage is speculative. The third is comparative reading within the archive of speculative fiction. The cycle is treated as one node in a network of simulated-world narratives running from E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) to *Severance* (2022). The fourth is speculative ontology in Donna Haraway's sense of "speculative fabulation" (Haraway 2016): the use of fictional worlds to think what the actual world's categories make unthinkable.

A word on intention. The Wachowskis' published statements count here as evidence, never as authority, and the dissertation observes the discipline of Wimsatt and Beardsley's "intentional fallacy" (1946). In one domain, however, authorial testimony carries distinct ethical weight. In 2020 Lilly Wachowski confirmed that the trans reading of the first film reflected its original intention. Chapter 9 treats this not as a key that forecloses other readings but as a fact about how the work was produced: a studio apparatus disciplined a meaning that the text nonetheless preserved in displaced form.

1.3 Genealogy of Sources: The Assigned and the Unassigned Archive

Before Keanu Reeves was allowed to read the screenplay, he was reportedly required to read three books:

- Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981; English translation 1994)
- Kevin Kelly's *Out of Control: The New Biology of Machines, Social Systems, and the Economic World* (1994)
- Dylan Evans's *Introducing Evolutionary Psychology*

The syllabus is more precise than it first appears, because each book corre-

sponds to one layer of the fictional cosmos. Baudrillard supplies an ontology of the world: a regime in which models come before, and generate, the reality they claim to represent. Kelly supplies an ontology of the machines. His thesis that the born and the made are converging, and that intelligence emerges from the bottom up in swarms rather than from the top down by design, anticipates the swarming Sentinels, the hive-like Machine City, and the Deus Ex Machina's face assembled from countless smaller units. Evans supplies an ontology of the humans. Their minds were shaped by an ancestral environment in which scarcity and conflict were constant, so they might reject a frictionless world as alien. That is exactly the diagnosis Agent Smith offers, and the Architect later elaborates, for the failure of the first, paradise-like Matrix. World, machine, human; simulation, emergence, adaptation: the assigned readings are a cosmology in three volumes.

The visual and generic archive is equally legible. By producer Joel Silver's widely repeated account, the directors pitched the project by screening Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) and saying they wanted to make it for real, an ironic phrase given the film's subject. Yuen Woo-ping's choreography brought in the grammar of Hong Kong wuxia and kung fu cinema, where the body's mastery over physics is already a metaphysical claim. Geof Darrow's concept art and Steve Skroce's storyboards carried the density of comics into the production design.

Literary sources are just as visible. Lewis Carroll's Alice books supply the white rabbit, the rabbit hole, and the looking glass. L. Frank Baum's Oz supplies Cypher's parting joke about Kansas. Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949) supplies the mythic skeleton that the Wachowskis, like George Lucas before them, fleshed out. The cyberpunk lineage supplies the very word: William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) had already called cyberspace "the matrix." A decade before Gibson, the *Doctor Who* serial "The Deadly Assassin" (1976) showed a Time Lord "Matrix" into which the Doctor projects his mind to fight a battle that can kill him. Grant Morrison has alleged substantial borrowing from *The Invisibles* (1994–2000); that claim belongs to the history of reception rather than to this argument.

Beyond this documented archive lies what might be called the unassigned archive. These are the traditions the cycle activates whether or not its authors consulted them, and it activates them precisely enough that the question of documented reading becomes secondary. Plato's cave, Descartes's deceiving demon, Zhuangzi's butterfly, the Gnostic demiurge and his archons, the Buddhist and Vedantic doctrines of illusion, the Christian passion narrative, and the Stoic theory of what is "up to us" are not sources in the philological sense.

They are coordinates in a conceptual space the film occupies. The comparative method is designed to locate the cycle within that space and, crucially, to trace its movement through it.

1.4 The Argument in Brief

In its most compressed form, the thesis is this: the Matrix cycle exhausts both the epistemological and the metaphysical ways of posing the problem of the real, and relocates the real in the act of choice. It follows that "Is this world real?" is a malformed question when asked of substrates such as vats, pods, bits, or atoms. It is well formed only when asked of the relation between a world and the choices it can host.

The term *prohairesis* comes from two sources, and their conjunction is part of the argument. For Aristotle, *prohairesis* is deliberate choice, "deliberate desire of things in our own power" (*Nicomachean Ethics* III.3, 1113a10–11), the point where reason and desire fuse into action. For Epictetus, a former slave who located all human freedom in the faculty of choice, the one possession no master could take, *prohairesis* is the self. Everything else, the body included, belongs to what is "not up to us." The cycle's central image is a humanity enslaved in its bodies, whose only remaining possession is the capacity to accept or reject the world presented to it. That makes the Epictetan inheritance less an analogy than a diagnosis.

Prohairetic realism holds that a world is real for an agent to the degree that the agent's choices within it are *constitutive* rather than merely *registered*:

- A choice is **registered** when a governing system records it and absorbs it without leaving any structural trace. The choice has been anticipated and channelled, so its being made changes nothing about the system that could not have been specified in advance.
- A choice is **constitutive** when making it brings about what it chooses, as a performative utterance does in J. L. Austin's sense (Austin 1962), and binds the world's subsequent structure to that fact.

The paradigm of constitutive choice is self-designation: naming oneself against an assigned name. This is why the first film's pivotal assertion is a sentence rather than a blow. In the subway, Neo refuses the name the system insists on using for him and states his own. The Real, on this view, is not what the red pill reveals. It is the swallowing.

The argument proceeds through five sub-theses, each defended in the chapters indicated:

1. **The exhaustion thesis.** The cycle begins inside the epistemic frame of Plato, Descartes, and Putnam and systematically depletes it, along with the metaphysical frame Chalmers substitutes for it (Chapters 2–3).
2. **The battery confession.** The human battery, thermodynamically impossible on its own terms, is an admission that what the machines harvest is not heat but assent. This radicalizes Slavoj Žižek's reading of the harvested energy as *jouissance* by moving it from enjoyment to choice (Chapters 3, 10, 12).
3. **The theodicy thesis.** The Architect's account of the Matrix's successive versions compresses the history of Western theodicy, from Leibnizian perfection through Irenaean soul-making to the free-will defense, and concludes, as that history did, that no stable order can dispense with the choice to refuse it (Chapters 6–7).
4. **The Consent Engine thesis.** A system that must include the choice to refuse it will tend to manufacture that choice. Zion functions as the Disneyland of the Real, a reservation of authenticity whose existence certifies the system it opposes (Chapters 3, 10, 12).
5. **The dyadic thesis.** *Resurrections* moves constitutive choice from the solitary exception to the reciprocal relation, from the One to the Two, completing an ontology the trilogy had left centred on a single agent (Chapters 9, 12).

1.5 Chapter Architecture

Chapter 2 reconstructs the epistemological inheritance: the cave, the deceiving demon, the vat, and the experience machine. It argues that the first film both restages and quietly inverts this inheritance, culminating in Chalmers's reclassification of the matrix hypothesis as metaphysics rather than skepticism.

Chapter 3 turns to the book the film physically incorporates, Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation*. It reconstructs Baudrillard's disavowal of the film and Žižek's Lacanian counter-reading, and offers a preliminary formulation of Zion as the Disneyland of the Real.

Chapter 4 reads the cycle's cosmology through Sethian and Valentinian Gnosticism, the Hymn of the Pearl, Hans Jonas's existentialist interpretation of Gnosis, and Philip K. Dick's late theology.

Chapter 5 examines the Madhyamaka doctrine of the two truths, the Advaita doctrine of *māyā*, the bodhisattva structure of Neo's return, and the Sanskrit liturgy with which *Revolutions* closes.

Chapter 6 analyses the cycle's Christological typology and advances the

theodicy thesis.

Chapter 7 treats the trilogy's explicit debate on freedom: the Merovingian's causal determinism, the Architect's probabilistic management, and the Oracle's foreknowledge. It reads that debate through Stoic compatibilism, Frankfurt cases, and Newcomb's problem.

Chapter 8 addresses machine minds and program personhood, from Samuel Butler and Karel Čapek through Turing, Searle, and the cybernetic tradition, to the program Rama-Kandra's love for his daughter.

Chapter 9 develops the concept of the residual self-image through Heidegger's standing-reserve, Merleau-Ponty's body schema, Haraway, Hayles, and trans theory.

Chapter 10 examines the political economy of the pod through Marx, Debord, Althusser, Foucault, Agamben, and Zuboff, and develops the Consent Engine thesis.

Chapter 11 situates the cycle within a constellation of speculative fictions.

Chapter 12 assembles prohairetic realism as a systematic position, defends it against objections, and draws out its implications for simulation theory, the ethics of artificial minds, trans ontology, and the critique of platform capitalism.

Chapter 13 concludes.

CHAPTER

02

Cave, Demon, Vat: The Epistemological Inheritance and Its Exhaustion

> 2.1 The Cave Restaged
> 2.2 The Demon Mechanized
> 2.3 The Vat and the Word
> 2.4 The Steak and the Contract
> 2.5 Chalmers's Inversion
> 2.6 The Exhaustion of the Epistemic Frame

2.1 The Cave Restaged

The allegory of the cave (*Republic* VII, 514a–520a) is the first film's master template, and the correspondence is too detailed to be accidental. Plato's prisoners have been chained since childhood, heads fixed so they can see only the wall in front of them. On it fall shadows cast by objects carried behind a parapet in the light of a fire, and the prisoners take the shadows for everything there is. One prisoner is released and compelled to turn around, and the turning is agony. The firelight hurts his eyes. He is dragged up a rough, steep ascent. In the sunlight he is dazzled and at first can make out only shadows and reflections, then objects, and at last the sun itself.

The film reproduces this sequence with almost scholastic fidelity. Neo's awakening in the pod is a birth into pain. His muscles have atrophied from disuse, and Morpheus tells him his eyes hurt for the same reason. When the truth is delivered to him in the Construct, he first refuses it and then vomits. Plato insists that the ascent must be compelled: the prisoner is dragged. He adds that a liberated philosopher who returns to the cave will be mocked and, if possible, killed by those he tries to free (517a). This allusion to the death of Socrates reappears as Morpheus's warning that most people still plugged in are so dependent on the system that they will fight to protect it.

The film also preserves the pedagogy Plato draws from the allegory. Education, Socrates insists, is not putting sight into blind eyes. It is the turning around (*periagōgē*) of the whole soul toward what is (518b–d). Morpheus's line that he can show Neo the door but cannot walk through it for him is the midwife principle of the *Theaetetus* (149a–151d). There Socrates, son of a midwife, disclaims wisdom and claims only the art of helping others deliver what they already carry.

The film's most comic scene is its most Platonic in structure. Combat systems are uploaded directly into Neo's nervous system, and he opens his eyes to announce that he now knows kung fu. This restages the *Meno*'s demonstration (82b–85b) that learning is recollection (*anamnēsis*): the slave boy, under questioning, "recollects" geometry he was never taught. The film's version is recollection mechanized, with knowledge as installation.

But the upload marks a limit as well as a capacity, and that limit is the film's first original philosophical move. Skills can be installed. The belief that one is the One cannot. Neo fails the jump program despite possessing every installable competence. He fails not for lack of information but for lack of a certain relation to himself. When he consults the Oracle, she compares being the One to being in love: no one can tell you, you simply know it, through and through.

At this point the film quietly moves from the *Republic* to the *Symposium*. Its Oracle is a woman who teaches the hero that the highest knowledge is erotic in structure. She occupies the position of Diotima of Mantinea, the priestess who teaches Socrates that love is the ladder of ascent (*Symposium* 201d–212a). The cycle will vindicate this move: the Architect identifies Neo's love for Trinity as the variable that separates him from his five predecessors.

From the outset, then, the film establishes a division between two kinds of knowing, the installable and the uninstallable, and this division organizes the whole argument. What can be downloaded belongs to the system. What must be enacted, because it consists in a relation of the self to itself or to another, is the first hint of *prohairesis*.

The most consequential inversion concerns the sun. In Plato the ascent ends in the vision of the sun, the image of the Form of the Good, which causes both the being and the intelligibility of everything (508e–509b). For Plato the real is brighter, more ordered, and more beautiful than the shadow-world it grounds. The film's real is a scorched ruin under a permanently blackened sky. *The Animatrix* explains why: in the war's final phase, humanity itself darkened the heavens to cut off the solar-powered machines. Those who most needed the Platonic sun extinguished it; the Good was sacrificed to strategy.

The trilogy returns to the image twice, and the two returns form a diptych:

- In *Revolutions*, Trinity pilots the *Logos* (the ship's name is not incidental) above the storm clouds over the Machine City. For a few seconds she sees the sun and a blue sky, and she is mortally wounded on the descent. The Platonic vision survives, but only as ecstasy just before death: a *Liebestod* rather than a *paideia*.
- The trilogy's final image of the sun is a sunrise inside the Matrix, composed by the program-child Sati as a gift to the absent Neo. The last Good the trilogy shows us is simulated, made, and given.

The movement from Trinity's sun to Sati's is a compressed argument. The Good no longer sits at the summit of a hierarchy of being, waiting to be found by ascent. It is produced, and producing it is an act of care.

2.2 The Demon Mechanized

If Plato supplies the narrative template, Descartes supplies the logical one. The First Meditation (1641) proceeds in two stages. The dream argument observes that there are no certain marks distinguishing waking from sleeping, so any particular perception might be a dream. It leaves intact, however, the simple natures (extension, shape, quantity, number) from which dream-images must be built. The second stage introduces the deceiving demon (*genium aliquem malignum*, AT VII 22), supremely powerful and cunning, who devotes all his energy to deceiving me. This hypothesis extends doubt to the simple natures and to the external world as such. The heavens, air, earth, colours, shapes, and sounds might be nothing but *ludificationes somniorum*, the delusions of dreams, with which he lays traps for my credulity (*insidias credulitati meae tetendit*).

The Matrix is this hypothesis mechanized and collectivized. The deceiver is no longer a single malign intelligence but a distributed system. Its traps are code, and its agents are, in a pun the film makes visible, Agents.

Three features of the Cartesian structure illuminate the film by contrast.

The first concerns criteria. Descartes's dream argument depends on there being no mark that distinguishes true from deceptive experience. This position has ancient precedent in the Academic skeptics, who denied, against the Stoics, that any impression bears a "cataleptic" mark of its own truth. The film provides such a mark but inverts its function. Déjà vu, the black cat crossing the doorway twice, signals intervention rather than truth: it is a glitch that occurs when the system alters the code. The Matrix thus grants its inhabitants something Descartes denied them, a perceptible criterion, but the criterion certifies manipulation rather than reality.

The second concerns the exit. Descartes escapes his hypothesis through the cogito (Second Meditation), a proof of a God who does not deceive (Third Meditation), and the restoration of the external world on the strength of God's truthfulness (Sixth Meditation). The film's exit is neither logical nor theological but technological and bodily. You leave the demon's world by having your body located, disconnected, and flushed from a pod. The Matrix is Cartesian doubt without Cartesian theology: the deceiving demon without the truthful God.

Where the truthful God should stand, the film places the Oracle, and the substitution is pointed. The Oracle does not say what is the case. She lets Neo believe he is not the One, because belief cannot be handed over and must be reached. Her pronouncements are calibrated not to truth but to what the hearer needs in order to choose. Descartes argued that deception betrays a defect incompatible with perfection. The cycle's supreme epistemic authority is a benev-

olent deceiver whose misdirections are acts of care. Truth is subordinated to the conditions of choice.

The third concerns dualism. Descartes located the interaction of mind (*res cogitans*) and body (*res extensa*) in the pineal gland (*Passions of the Soul* §§31–32). The film's neural jack, implanted at the base of the skull, is a technological pineal gland: the single point through which a mind is coupled to a world. The film's rule for injury is that if you die in the Matrix, your body dies, because the body cannot live without the mind. This interactionism is so strong that it reverses the Cartesian priority, since the mind's certainty of its own damage is enough to destroy the body.

Descartes's piece of wax (Second Meditation) finds its counterpart in the spoon. Every sensible quality of the wax changes before the fire, yet the mind judges it to be the same wax. The spoon bends in the hands of a child in monk's robes, who explains that it is not the spoon that bends but oneself. Descartes concluded that bodies are perceived by the intellect alone; the child concludes that the spoon is not there at all. The gap between those conclusions is the gap between Cartesian rationalism and the Buddhist doctrine of emptiness, to which Chapter 5 is devoted.

2.3 The Vat and the Word

Hilary Putnam's "Brains in a Vat" (Putnam 1981, ch. 1) is the film's closest analytic precursor, closer than is often recognized. Putnam does not stop at a single brain manipulated by a mad scientist. He generalizes to a universe in which all sentient beings are brains in a vat, tended by automatic machinery and sharing a collective hallucination. The Matrix is Putnam's generalized case with a history added.

Putnam's purpose, however, was to show that the scenario refutes itself. His argument builds on his externalism ("The Meaning of 'Meaning,' " 1975), according to which meanings "just ain't in the head." On a causal theory of reference, the words of a lifelong envatted brain do not refer to real vats and brains, since it has never interacted with them. They refer to the images or program features that systematically cause its uses of those words. When such a brain says "I am a brain in a vat," its "vat" refers to vat-in-the-image, so the sentence is false. No one to whom the hypothesis applies can truly assert it.

The film's narrative bears on Putnam's argument in a way rarely noted: it introduces the exit. Before unplugging, Neo's words (if Putnam is right) refer to Matrix-objects, and his sentence "I might be a brain in a vat" could not have expressed the truth about his condition. After unplugging, he has causal

contact with real pods and real bodies, and his vocabulary is re-anchored. The sentence "I was, until recently, a body in a pod" becomes both meaningful and true. The redpill is the figure whose semantic protection has been removed. Through physical exit, he has acquired the reference that the envatted cannot have. The film therefore concedes Putnam's point for the lifelong envatted, and defeats its consolation by showing that envatment need not be lifelong.

The film also exposes an indeterminacy that Putnam's causal theory cannot remove. Aboard the *Nebuchadnezzar*, the young crewman Mouse speculates that the machines, never having tasted anything, may have got the flavours wrong. Perhaps so many things in the Matrix taste like chicken because the machines could not work out what chicken tastes like. The joke contains an argument. The redpills have no standard of comparison. Real chicken may no longer exist, and the only taste of chicken any of them has known is the Matrix's rendering of it. Reference to a flavour is causally anchored only to the simulation that produced it. For words that name qualities, exit restores nothing: the real has left no residue against which the copy could be checked. Baudrillard could ask for no clearer instance of the precession of simulacra, and Chapter 3 takes it up in that register.

2.4 The Steak and the Contract

Robert Nozick's experience machine (Nozick 1974, 42–45) poses the evaluative counterpart to the epistemic problem. Suppose a machine could give you, for a lifetime, any experiences you wanted, indistinguishable from reality and accompanied by the belief that they were real. Would you plug in? Nozick expects not, and gives three reasons:

- We want to *do* certain things, not merely to have the experience of doing them.
- We want to *be* a certain sort of person, whereas the body floating in the tank is "an indeterminate blob."
- Plugging in limits us to a man-made reality and cuts us off from any deeper significance.

For half a century the argument has served as an intuition pump against the view that only mental states of pleasure matter.

The Matrix supplies a character who answers Nozick's question yes, and the exact shape of his answer matters. Dining with Agent Smith in a restaurant inside the Matrix, Cypher says he knows the steak does not exist and that the

Matrix is merely telling his brain it is juicy and delicious. After nine years, he has concluded that ignorance is bliss. He did not coin the aphorism. Its source, Thomas Gray's "Ode on a Distant Prospect of Eton College," carries an irony he misses: "where ignorance is bliss, / 'Tis folly to be wise." Gray's speaker is watching children who do not yet know the suffering that awaits them. Cypher is an adult bargaining to have his childhood back.

Cypher's contract refines Nozick in two respects. First, he is not asking for pleasure, since he can already enjoy the steak. He is asking for amnesia. He wants the experience without the metaphysics, the taste of the steak without the knowledge that it is code. His demand therefore concerns belief rather than experience. Nozick's machine includes, by stipulation, the belief that one's experiences are real, and Cypher shows that this stipulation carries almost the entire weight of the choice. Second, he asks to be reinserted as someone important, an actor. The name Smith uses for him, Mr. Reagan, completes the figure: an actor who became head of state, the emblematic politician of the hyperreal, whose career Michael Rogin (1987) analysed as the confusion of cinematic and political representation. Cypher's utopia is not pleasure but celebrity, a role within the image.

Empirical work has since complicated Nozick's intuition in a direction the film anticipates. Felipe De Brigard (2010) found that when subjects are told they are *already* connected to an experience machine and offered the chance to disconnect, a substantial proportion choose to stay. This suggests that the intuition Nozick reported owes much to status quo bias rather than to a principled preference for contact with reality. The Architect's statistic, that ninety-nine percent of test subjects accepted the program once they were given a choice, anticipates De Brigard's result by a decade; Chapter 6 interprets it fully. For now the point is limited. The cycle refuses the comfortable conclusion that human beings reliably prefer the real. Its humans overwhelmingly prefer the world they are in, provided they are allowed to believe they chose it.

2.5 Chalmers's Inversion

The decisive philosophical response to the film came from David Chalmers. His "The Matrix as Metaphysics" (2003; reprinted in Grau 2005) argues that the matrix hypothesis (that I am, and always have been, in a matrix) is not a skeptical hypothesis at all. Chalmers breaks it into three claims:

- **The Creation Hypothesis:** physical space-time and its contents were created by beings outside physical space-time.

- **The Computational Hypothesis:** microphysical processes are made up of underlying computational processes.
- **The Mind-Body Hypothesis:** my mind consists of processes outside physical space-time, with which physical space-time exchanges inputs and outputs.

He calls the conjunction the Metaphysical Hypothesis. He argues that if it is true, my ordinary beliefs (that there are tables, that I have hands, that Paris is in France) remain overwhelmingly true. There are tables; they are simply made of bits, as John Wheeler's slogan "it from bit" (Wheeler 1990) had already proposed for physics generally. The envatted are not deceived about whether the objects around them exist. They are ignorant of those objects' fundamental nature, just as physicists are ignorant of what quarks are ultimately made of. Chalmers has since generalized the argument into a "virtual realism" (Chalmers 2022), according to which virtual objects are real digital objects and virtual worlds are not second-class realities.

Chalmers's inversion does to the film what Putnam's argument did to Descartes. It removes the sting of deception by reinterpreting what the deceived believe. The Matrix-dweller who believes she is eating a steak is right: there is a steak, a digital one, and she is eating it. On this view Cypher's error is not the one he thinks he is making. He is not choosing a false world over a true one. He is choosing one real world over another and asking to forget the difference.

The cost of this reclassification is exactly what makes it instructive. Having moved reality from the physical substrate to the computational one, Chalmers leaves untouched the question the cycle goes on to ask. If the Matrix is real, it is real in the same way for Neo and for the ninety-nine percent. Virtual realism cannot distinguish an agent whose choices constitute her world from one whose choices are absorbed by it. The Architect has no quarrel with virtual realism. He built it.

Nick Bostrom's simulation argument (Bostrom 2003), published the same year, completes the reframing from another direction. His trilemma holds that one of three things is true: almost no civilizations reach the technological maturity needed to run detailed simulations of their ancestors; almost none of those that do choose to run them; or we are almost certainly living in a simulation. This turns the Cartesian scenario from an extravagant possibility into a probabilistic wager. Its effect on the question of the real matches Chalmers's. Once simulation is probable and simulated objects are real, the substrate can no longer carry the distinction between real and unreal. Something else must carry it, if anything does.

2.6 The Exhaustion of the Epistemic Frame

By the end of the first film, the epistemological inheritance has been restaged in full and has begun to exhaust itself:

- Plato's ascent has led not to the Good but to a ruin.
- Descartes's demon has been escaped, but not by any argument.
- Putnam's semantic protection has been removed by exit.
- Nozick's intuition has been challenged by a character who bargains for amnesia.
- Chalmers has shown that, on the most rigorous analysis, "Is my world real?" admits the deflationary answer: yes, in the only sense that matters for the truth of your ordinary beliefs.

What remains is a question none of these frameworks was built to address. It is not whether the world is real, nor what it is made of, but what an agent can do in it, and whether what she does counts.

The skeptic's question is a spectator's question, asked from the armchair. The film, with an irony it seems fully to intend, stages its most skeptical scene in the Construct, where Neo sits in a red leather armchair before an antique television set displaying the ruined world. The cycle's development from 1999 to 2021 is a progressive departure from that armchair. The question of the real passes from the spectator to the agent, and from the epistemology of perception to the ontology of choice. That transfer begins in earnest with the book the film literally hollows out.

CHAPTER

03

The Hollowed Book: Baudrillard, Žižek, and the Desert of the Real

> 3.1 The Prop as Thesis
> 3.2 The Precession of Simulacra
> 3.3 Map, Territory, Desert
> 3.4 Baudrillard Against *The Matrix*
> 3.5 Žižek's Third Pill
> 3.6 Zion as the Disneyland of the Real: A Preliminary Formulation
> 3.7 From Hyperreality to Prohairesis

3.1 The Prop as Thesis

Among the film's earliest images is a book. Neo, a programmer by day and a dealer in illicit software by night, retrieves a disk for a client from a copy of Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* whose pages have been hollowed out into a hiding place. The book falls open at the chapter "On Nihilism," which is the last chapter of Baudrillard's text. The prop places it well before the book's end, so the volume on screen is itself a simulacrum of the book it names, a copy without a faithful original.

The staging is exact. Baudrillard's theory of a reality emptied out by its models appears as an object that has been emptied out: a container whose contents have been removed to make room for contraband, that is, for commodities in circulation. The client who receives the disk hails Neo as his personal saviour, so the cycle's first messianic title is spoken as consumer gratitude. The white rabbit tattooed on the shoulder of the woman with him is the cue Neo has been told to follow. Theory, commodity, messiah, and invitation to the rabbit hole are compressed into a single transaction at a doorway.

"On Nihilism" is well chosen. In it Baudrillard distinguishes two nihilisms. The nihilism of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Romantic or Nietzschean, was a nihilism of destruction, and it still presupposed meanings worth destroying. Contemporary nihilism is a nihilism of transparency, in which meaning is not annihilated but neutralized, scattered, and made indifferent by its own proliferation.

The distinction bears directly on the film's politics. Zion's resistance works on the older model: it seeks to destroy an illusion and liberate a truth. The system it opposes works on the newer one: it does not suppress the resistance's meanings but absorbs them, as the Architect will reveal. The hollowed book thus anticipates the sequels. It is the text of the film's own undoing, carried in the protagonist's hands and used for storage.

3.2 The Precession of Simulacra

Baudrillard's argument in "The Precession of Simulacra" can be reconstructed through two schemes. The first is a sequence of phases of the image (Baudrillard 1994):

1. The image reflects a profound reality.
2. It masks and distorts that reality.
3. It masks the *absence* of a profound reality.

4 It bears no relation to any reality whatever and becomes its own pure simulacrum.

The second scheme, developed in *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (1976), is a historical sequence of three orders of simulacra:

1 **The counterfeit**, dominant from the Renaissance to the industrial revolution and governed by the natural law of value.
2 **Production**, dominant in the industrial era and governed by the market law of value.
3 **Simulation**, the present order, governed by the structural law of value and generated by the code.

Baudrillard calls the third order hyperreal: the generation by models of a real without origin or reality.

The film's imagery literalizes the third order so directly that it is at once the film's triumph and, for Baudrillard, its betrayal. The "digital rain" of falling green glyphs is the code made visible, the generative matrix from which the world is continuously produced. The Matrix is not a representation of a prior world. It is a model of 1999 generated after 1999 has ceased to exist. Morpheus admits no one knows the actual date, only that it is closer to 2199, so the Matrix's referent is a period that survives nowhere except in the simulation. In the strictest Baudrillardian sense, the Matrix does not mask the real; it masks the *absence* of the real 1999 it replicates.

The recursion goes further. The Matrix reproduces the late twentieth century, the very era in which Baudrillard diagnosed the passage into hyperreality. Its baseline reality is therefore a simulation of a world already made of simulation. The pod-dwellers are prisoners of a model of a society that was itself a society of models.

Mouse's chicken, discussed in the previous chapter, now shows its full significance. The taste of chicken in the Matrix has no original, because the redpills have only tasted the simulated version and the machines never tasted any. The simulation does not copy a flavour; it generates one, and that generated flavour is the only taste of chicken that exists. This is the fourth phase of the image in its purest form: a copy unrelated to any reality, which has become the reality it claims to represent. The cycle's comedy of oatmeal and chicken is Baudrillard's metaphysics at the scale of the palate.

3.3 Map, Territory, Desert

Baudrillard opens "The Precession of Simulacra" with Borges's fable "On Exactitude in Science" (1946). An empire's cartographers draw a map so detailed that it matches the territory point for point. Later generations find it useless and abandon it to the weather, so that tattered ruins of the map survive in the western deserts, inhabited by animals and beggars. Baudrillard inverts the fable. Today it is not the map that decays over the territory but the territory whose remnants persist across the map. The real itself survives in scraps, in deserts that are no longer the Empire's but ours. From this sentence the film takes the phrase Morpheus uses to introduce Neo to the ruined world: the desert of the real.

The borrowing performs an operation worth describing precisely. In Baudrillard the desert is a figure for the condition of the real under hyperreality: the real survives only as fragments within the model, and the map has become the only territory there is. In the film the desert becomes a *place*, a literal wasteland of blackened sky and ruined cities located physically outside the simulation. Baudrillard's metaphor becomes geography, and in the process a Platonic layout is restored. There is an inside (the simulation) and an outside (the real), and one can travel from one to the other.

This transformation is a category error of genius. It is an error because it reinstates exactly the distinction Baudrillard's argument dissolves. It is of genius because the film immediately stages the impossibility of that reinstatement. Neo is first shown the desert of the real not in the real at all but inside the Construct, the loading program, on the screen of an old television set, while he sits in a red leather armchair. The real makes its entrance as a broadcast image inside a simulation. Whether or not the film intends the irony, it registers it: at the moment of disclosure, Neo's only access to the real is mediated by the apparatus from which the real was supposed to free him.

3.4 Baudrillard Against *The Matrix*

Baudrillard gave his verdict on the film in a 2003 interview with *Le Nouvel Observateur* (English translation 2004). He objected that the Wachowskis had confused the new problem of simulation with the classical, Platonic problem of illusion. The film therefore restores a clean separation between the real world and the virtual one, whereas the defining feature of the hyperreal is that no such separation can still be drawn. He remarked that the film was the kind of film about the matrix that the matrix itself could have produced. He also said

that an approach to involve him in the sequels was not something he could entertain.

The objection is formidable, and the franchise's later history amplified it. The Matrix became the paradigm of transmedia storytelling (Jenkins 2006): a narrative spread across films, animated shorts, games, comics, and an online world, with no single text containing the whole. It was a system of copies without a master copy. Its imagery of sunglasses, black leather, and bullet time was reproduced by advertising, parody, and imitation until it became a set of free-floating signs detached from any argument. By Baudrillard's lights, the film's critique of simulation was a spectacular commodity from the start, and its commercial afterlife was not a corruption of the critique but its truth.

Two replies are available, and the second is more interesting.

The first reply is that the sequels partly concede Baudrillard's point from within. *Reloaded* reveals that Zion is a component of the system, destroyed and rebuilt in cycles, its rebellion anticipated and scheduled. This dissolves the neat opposition between inside and outside. At the close of *Reloaded*, Neo disables Sentinels in the physical world with his mind, and the film never definitively explains how. For a generation of viewers this raised the possibility that the "real" world was itself another level of simulation.

The second reply is that *Resurrections* makes Baudrillard's objection its subject. In the 2021 film, the trilogy exists inside the story as a celebrated video game designed by Thomas Anderson. The parent company, named as Warner Bros., informs him that a sequel will be made with or without him. A montage shows his colleagues at the game studio brainstorming what the Matrix "means." They list readings including trans politics, crypto-fascism, capitalist exploitation, and bullet time, several of which this dissertation advances. The film about the matrix that the matrix would have produced has become a film about the matrix producing a film about the matrix.

Is this reflexivity an escape from Baudrillard's trap, or its most refined form? Chapter 12 answers in terms of the distinction between registered and constitutive choice. Reflexivity is registered when the system absorbs its own critique as content. It is constitutive only when it changes what the system can do next.

3.5 Žižek's Third Pill

Slavoj Žižek's "The Matrix, or, the Two Sides of Perversion" (in Irwin 2002) offers a Lacanian reading that both corrects Baudrillard and anticipates, in one crucial respect, the argument of this dissertation. For Žižek the Matrix is the big Other: the virtual symbolic order that structures reality for its inhabitants and exists only insofar as they act as if it exists.

The film's error, on his account, is not that it separates the real from the virtual but that it puts the real in the wrong place. "Reality" in the film's sense (the pods, Zion, the desert) is no more the Lacanian Real than the Matrix is. The Real is not a substantial world behind appearances. It is the traumatic kernel of enjoyment around which every symbolic reality is organized.

The film's two central fantasies correspond to what Žižek calls the two sides of perversion. One is the fantasy that we are passive instruments of the Other's enjoyment, our vital substance drained by a machine that uses our bodies. The other is the fantasy of omnipotence, in which the subject who has seen through the code can manipulate the symbolic order at will. The pods and bullet time are the two faces of a single perversion.

Žižek's answer to why the machines need human bodies matters for everything that follows. The film's official explanation, that humans generate bioelectrical energy, is scientifically absurd. Žižek proposes that what the Matrix actually feeds on is human *jouissance*: the truth of the harvesting lies in a libidinal economy, not a thermodynamic one.

This dissertation accepts Žižek's inference from the battery's absurdity to a non-thermal energy, and rejects his identification of that energy. The key evidence is the Architect's history of the Matrix's versions:

- The first Matrix, designed as a paradise, failed.
- He then redesigned it on the basis of human history to reflect more accurately the grotesqueries of human nature, and that version failed as well.
- The system stabilized only when the Oracle discovered that nearly all subjects would accept the program if given a choice, even one they were aware of only at a near-unconscious level.

One might reply on Žižek's behalf that *jouissance* in Lacan is not pleasure but the painful excess beyond the pleasure principle. On that reading, Smith's claim that humans define their reality through suffering and misery confirms the libidinal reading. The reply is strong but incomplete. The second version, which supplied suffering in abundance and was rich in *jouissance* by any Lacanian measure, still failed. What the system could not do without was not enjoyment

in either sense but choice. The harvested energy is not *jouissance* but assent.

Resurrections might seem to vindicate Žižek, since its Analyst discovers that feelings are more easily controlled than facts and that desire and fear can be modulated to keep subjects compliant. But it does so only at the level of instruments. The Analyst manipulates feeling in order to secure consent, and consent is what he harvests. Chapter 12 develops this claim under the heading of a thermodynamics of assent.

Žižek's later intervention, in Sophie Fiennes's film *The Pervert's Guide to Cinema* (2006), asks for a third pill. It would be neither the blue pill of illusion nor the red pill of the reality behind illusion, but a pill that lets one perceive the reality *in* illusion itself. The proposal is Lacanian: fantasy is not a veil over reality but the frame that makes reality possible. It is the most sophisticated alternative to prohairetic realism, and the difference between them is simple to state. Žižek moves the real from behind the illusion to within it. Prohairetic realism moves it from the object of perception, whether behind or within, to the act of choice. The third pill reveals the real in the fantasy. On the account developed here, no pill reveals the real, because the real is not something revealed: it is the swallowing.

After the attacks of 11 September 2001, Žižek titled a book with the film's borrowed phrase, *Welcome to the Desert of the Real* (2002). He argued that the images of the collapsing towers were experienced as an intrusion of the real in the form of a spectacle cinema had long rehearsed. The argument draws on what Alain Badiou would call the twentieth century's "passion for the real" (Badiou 2007): the conviction that the real must be reached by destroying semblance. Prohairetic realism is, among other things, an alternative to that passion. It is an account of the real that requires not the destruction of the semblance but the taking up of a choice within it.

3.6 Zion as the Disneyland of the Real: A Preliminary Formulation

Baudrillard's most celebrated example is Disneyland. It is presented as imaginary, he argues, to make us believe that the rest is real, when in fact all of Los Angeles and the America around it are no longer real but belong to the order of the hyperreal and of simulation (Baudrillard 1994). Disneyland is a deterrence machine. By concentrating the imaginary in a designated enclave, it certifies the reality of what lies outside and conceals that the outside is equally simulated. The same logic governs his account of political scandal: Watergate, exposed as a scandal, serves to regenerate the moral principle whose absence it actually reveals.

The sequels invite applying this logic to Zion, with an inversion that sharpens it. Zion is presented as the real: a city of bodies, sweat, earth, and heat, built near the planet's core. Its central collective rite, the ecstatic dance in the Temple cavern in *Reloaded*, intercut with Neo and Trinity's lovemaking, is an orgy of embodiment. It is a Bataillean expenditure of surplus energy in defiance of a system that treats bodies as reserves.

The Architect's disclosure recasts all of this. Zion has been destroyed five times. Its rebellion is the channel through which the system discharges the anomaly of the roughly one percent who refuse the program. The One is the mechanism by which that anomaly is gathered, returned to the Source, and redistributed, and by which Zion is refounded with twenty-three individuals selected for the purpose. Zion, in short, is a function of the Matrix.

The two enclaves mirror each other:

- **Disneyland** is an *imaginary* enclave that certifies the reality of its surroundings.
- **Zion** is a *real* enclave that certifies the unreality of its surroundings.

The second operation conceals as much as the first. By concentrating authenticity in a designated reservation, Zion assures those who refuse the program that the system has an outside, and that the struggle between the Matrix and its enemies is a struggle between the false and the true. In doing so it conceals what the Architect makes explicit. The struggle is a distribution of roles within a single program, and the outside is a subroutine of the inside.

Zion is the Disneyland of the Real. It performs for the system the service the real once performed for representation: by existing, it guarantees that there is a difference that makes a difference. The insight that this guarantee is itself manufactured is what shifts the cycle's politics from the Gnostic to the systemic. In Chapter 10 it will require an account of the Matrix as a Consent Engine: an apparatus that stabilizes itself not by suppressing refusal but by producing it, housing it, and scheduling its defeat.

3.7 From Hyperreality to Prohairesis

The red pill deserves a closer look than its fame has usually allowed. After Neo swallows it, Morpheus explains that it is part of a trace program designed to disrupt his input/output carrier signal so that his body can be located. The red pill, that is, is code. The instrument of exit from the simulation is a simulated object, no more substantial than the blue pill beside it and no different in kind from the steak Cypher will later desire. A strict Baudrillardian must conclude

that the exit is itself a simulacrum.

The conclusion is correct, but the inference drawn from it is mistaken. The two pills do not differ in substance. Both are rendered by the same code, in the same palm, under the same lamp. They differ only in what is done with them. The red pill works not chemically or computationally but prohairetically: it works because it is chosen, and chosen against the reality principle of the world in which it is offered. Substrate cannot tell the pills apart. Choice can.

Each thinker examined so far placed the real in some order of being:

- Baudrillard dissolved the real into the model.
- Žižek rediscovered it as the kernel of fantasy.
- Chalmers restored it to the digital object.

Origin, structure, or substrate: in every case the real was a kind of being. Reading its sources against one another, the cycle suggests that the real may not be an order of being at all but a mode of acting. What distinguishes the real from the simulated, for an agent, is not what the world is made of but whether her choices within it make anything the case.

The chapters that follow test this suggestion against the religious cosmologies the cycle draws on: the Gnostic, the Buddhist and Vedantic, and the Christian. Each offers its own account of what delivers the soul from a world of appearances. Each, the cycle will find, is incomplete at the same point: the moment when deliverance must be chosen rather than known.

PART

II

The Soteriologies

CHAPTERS 4–6



CHAPTER

04

The Demiurge's Machine: Gnostic Cosmology, the Hymn of the Pearl, and the Twin

> 4.1 The Recovered Heresy
> 4.2 Architect, Archons, Keys
> 4.3 The Hymn of the Pearl
> 4.4 Thomas, the Twin
> 4.5 From Gnosis to Nihilism: Jonas
> 4.6 The Black Iron Prison: Philip K. Dick's Exegetical Gnosis
> 4.7 Voegelin's Warning and the American Gnosis
> 4.8 The Counterfeit Spirit: Why Gnosis Fails

4.1 The Recovered Heresy

In December 1945, near the Upper Egyptian town of Nag Hammadi, a sealed jar was dug up containing thirteen leather-bound codices of Coptic texts. Most were translations of Greek originals written between the second and fourth centuries. Until then, Gnosticism was known almost entirely through its enemies, above all Irenaeus of Lyon, whose *Adversus Haereses* (c. 180) catalogued the systems of Valentinus, Ptolemy, and Basilides in order to refute them. The Nag Hammadi library let the heresy speak in its own voice. The complete English translation (Robinson 1977) and Elaine Pagels's *The Gnostic Gospels* (1979) carried that voice into late twentieth-century popular culture. There it became available as a narrative grammar for exactly the kind of story the Wachowskis would tell.

The Sethian myth, preserved most fully in the *Apocryphon of John* (NHC II,1), is that grammar in its most elaborate form. Beyond all being is an unknowable Invisible Spirit. Its self-reflection, Barbelo, begins a chain of emanations that forms the Pleroma, a "fullness" of divine aeons arranged in pairs. The youngest aeon, Sophia (Wisdom), conceives without her partner's consent and brings forth a malformed offspring: Yaldabaoth, a lion-faced serpent, whom she hides in a luminous cloud.

Yaldabaoth does not know that the realm above him exists. He takes power from his mother, generates a retinue of archons ("rulers"), and fashions a cosmos modelled imperfectly on the aeons he has glimpsed. Echoing Isaiah (45:5), he declares himself a jealous God with no other beside him. The text remarks that this boast betrays his knowledge that another God exists, since there would otherwise be no one to be jealous of.

The archons then fashion a human being, who lies inert until Yaldabaoth is tricked into breathing into him the power he stole from Sophia. The creature comes alive, and the stolen light passes into him. Jealous, the archons cast the human down into matter and bind him in a body made of the elements, a tomb and fetter of forgetfulness. They also devise a "counterfeit spirit" to keep him ignorant. Salvation comes from above. In the text's closing hymn, Providence (Pronoia) descends into the prison of the body and calls on whoever hears to rise from heavy sleep.

The Valentinian systems, reported by Irenaeus (*Adv. Haer.* I.1–8) and represented at Nag Hammadi by the *Gospel of Truth*, soften this myth philosophically without changing its architecture. The Demiurge becomes an ignorant craftsman rather than a malevolent tyrant. Humanity is divided into three kinds: the pneumatic (spiritual), the psychic (ensouled), and the hylic (material). Only

the pneumatics can receive saving knowledge (*Adv. Haer.* I.7.5). Ignorance itself is described in terms that could serve as a treatment for the film. The *Gospel of Truth* says Error fashioned a substitute for truth in a fog. It compares the state of the ignorant to a nightmare of fleeing, being pursued, falling from heights, or being murdered, until the dreamer wakes, sees nothing, and throws off ignorance like sleep.

Every structural element of this myth appears in the first film:

- a false world fashioned by a derivative intelligence;
- a humanity imprisoned in bodies and ignorant of its condition;
- rulers who police the prison;
- a divine spark that registers its captivity as a vague unease (Morpheus's "splinter in the mind");
- a call from outside;
- a salvation that consists in knowing.

The film even preserves the Gnostic idea of an elect. Morpheus explains that the resistance never frees minds past a certain age, because such minds cannot let go. The capacity to be awakened is unevenly distributed, and the Architect will later put a number on it: roughly one percent refuse the program. In the film's terms, the pneumatics are the anomaly.

4.2 Architect, Archons, Keys

"Demiurge" comes from *dēmiourgos*, the public craftsman. The word enters philosophy through Plato's *Timaeus* (28a–29e), where a good craftsman, free of envy, fashions the cosmos by looking to an eternal model, wanting everything to be as much like himself as possible. Gnosticism turned Plato's figure upside down: the craftsman became ignorant, envious, and self-aggrandizing.

The cycle's Architect sits exactly at the hinge between these two versions. His method is Platonic. He builds by number, as Plato's craftsman built the world-soul from harmonic ratios (35b–36b), and he describes Neo as the remainder of an unbalanced equation in the programming. His limitation is Gnostic. He cannot grasp what he cannot calculate, and he admits that the solution to the Matrix's instability needed a mind less bound by the demands of perfection than his own. He is neither benevolent in Plato's sense nor malevolent in the Sethian sense. He is closest to the Valentinian Demiurge: a craftsman who does not understand what he has made. His name completes the diagnosis. Greek *architektōn*, "chief builder," shares its root with *archōn*, "ruler"; both come from

archein, to begin or to rule. Etymologically, the Architect is the first of the archons.

The Agents are archons in function as well as name. Morpheus tells Neo they are sentient programs that can move in and out of any software still wired to the system, guarding all the doors and holding all the keys. The Gnostic archons were gatekeepers of the same kind. Stationed at the planetary spheres the soul had to pass through on its ascent, they blocked its way unless it spoke the right formulas. Origen, describing an Ophite diagram (*Contra Celsum* 6.31), records the passwords the ascending soul must address to each ruler in turn: Ialdabaoth, Iao, Sabaoth, Adonaios, Astaphaios, Ailoaios, and Horaios.

Reloaded stages this ascent with remarkable fidelity. To reach the Source, Neo needs the Keymaker, a program held captive by the Merovingian, who cuts keys to backdoors opening onto a corridor of doors. The route to the Architect's white chamber runs floor by floor through a building whose security must be disabled in a precise sequence. The Keymaker's keys are the Ophite passwords. The corridor is the ladder of the spheres. The Architect's chamber is the Ogdoad, the eighth heaven above the seven rulers, where Hermetic and Gnostic ascent texts bring the soul to the highest principle of the cosmos. What Neo finds there is not the Father but the Demiurge, a reversal taken up in Section 4.8.

The Architect himself supplies the Valentinian structure of the cycle's governing powers. If he is the father of the Matrix, he tells Neo, the Oracle is undoubtedly its mother. Valentinian aeons exist in male-female pairs, called syzygies, and the drama of the Pleroma begins when the youngest female aeon, Sophia, acts out of a passion that exceeds her station. The Oracle's role is Sophianic in exactly this sense. She is an "intuitive" program created to study the human psyche. She found the solution, choice, that stabilized the Matrix, and that same solution produced the anomaly that threatens it. Like Sophia, whose passion is both the origin of the world's defect and the start of its redemption, the Oracle is both the author of the system's flaw and the means of its transformation.

At the close of *Revolutions* the Architect tells her she played a very dangerous game, and she answers that change always is. The exchange echoes what Plotinus called the audacity (*tolma*) of soul. Plotinus asks what made souls forget their father, and answers that it was their audacity and their wish to belong to themselves (*Enneads* V.1.1).

One more element of the Gnostic myth bears directly on the cycle's most notorious implausibility. In the *Apocryphon of John* the archons' power is borrowed. It is the light Yaldabaoth took from his mother, and once it has passed into the

human creature, the archons can keep hold of it only by keeping that creature imprisoned. In Manichaean cosmology the dependency becomes mechanical: the powers of darkness have devoured particles of light, and the visible cosmos is built as an apparatus for slowly extracting them.

The Gnostic prison exists because the jailers depend on what they imprison; their very being is borrowed from their prisoners. As an energy economy, the machines' dependence on human bodies is thermodynamically absurd (Chapter 3). As a Gnostic economy it is perfectly coherent. The prisoners are not one energy source among many. They are the only source of a quality the jailers lack. Chapter 12 names that quality.

The awakener's name is itself an inversion. In Ovid (*Metamorphoses* XI), Morpheus is a son of Sleep, the dream-god most skilled at imitating human forms. The cycle gives the god of dreams the job of dissolving them. His instrument is what Hans Jonas identified as the central motif of Gnostic and Mandaean literature, the "call from without": a message that reaches the sleeper from beyond the world and reminds him where he came from. The first words the film addresses to Neo are of this kind. They appear unbidden on his monitor and tell him to wake.

4.3 The Hymn of the Pearl

Of all Gnostic texts, the one closest to *The Matrix* in narrative structure is the *Hymn of the Pearl*, a Syriac poem preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas*, which comes from the Edessene milieu of the third century. A prince of the East is sent by his royal parents to Egypt to retrieve a single pearl guarded by a serpent in the sea. Before he leaves, they take off his robe of glory and give him provisions. In Egypt he dresses in Egyptian clothes so as not to be recognized as a stranger. The Egyptians see through him anyway and give him their food. He forgets that he is a king's son, serves their king, forgets the pearl, and falls into a deep sleep.

His parents write him a letter, sealed by the nobles of the kingdom. It flies to him in the form of an eagle and, landing beside him, becomes speech. He wakes and remembers who he is. He charms the serpent to sleep by speaking his father's name over it, seizes the pearl, strips off the filthy Egyptian garment, and sets out for home, guided by the letter, which shines before him. At the border he meets his robe of glory, and in it he sees himself as in a mirror: he and the robe are two in distinction and one in likeness.

The correspondences are close enough to be structural rather than merely thematic:

- The prince descends into a foreign world whose clothing he must adopt to pass unnoticed, just as the redpills wear their residual self-images into the Matrix.
- He forgets through the world's food.
- He falls into a deep sleep.
- A letter becomes a voice, as the message on the monitor and the ringing phone summon the redpills home.
- A serpent in the sea guards the treasure, as the tentacled Sentinels suggest a sea monster more than a machine.
- Above all, a robe that is also a mirror shows the soul its own image.

Chapter 9 develops the robe into a theory of the residual self-image. This section concentrates on the food and the name.

The food of forgetting. The prince is lost not by force but by eating: Egyptian food makes him forget. The motif is widespread. Persephone, having eaten pomegranate seeds in the underworld, is bound to return there for part of every year (*Homeric Hymn to Demeter*). The cycle names the Merovingian's wife Persephone. The Merovingian, lord of an underworld of exiled programs, serves a chocolate cake coded to produce desire in whoever eats it. Cypher's steak, discussed in Chapter 2, belongs to the same series, as does the protein gruel aboard the *Nebuchadnezzar*, whose true taste no one can determine.

Against these stand two counter-foods. One is the Oracle's cookie and candy, offered without condition in a kitchen with *temet nosce* ("know thyself") inscribed over the door. The other is the red pill. The food of the lower world binds; the Oracle's food feeds the self-knowledge her doorway commands; and the red pill frees. The cycle builds a soteriology of swallowing, in which what one eats decides whether one forgets or wakes. As Chapter 3 argued, the liberating pill works not because of its substance but because it is chosen.

The recovered name and the chosen name. The prince is saved by a name. He puts the serpent to sleep by pronouncing his father's name, and he is himself woken by a letter reminding him whose son he is. Gnostic salvation is anamnesis: recovering an identity that existed before the soul fell into the world, an identity inscribed in the Pleroma before its descent.

Here *The Matrix* departs from its Gnostic template, and it departs at exactly the point where this dissertation's thesis lies. "Neo" is not a name Neo recovers. It is the handle he gave himself as a hacker, a name adopted within the world rather than remembered from before it. In the subway, when he refuses the name Smith insists on and speaks the one he chose, he is not recalling an origin. He is affirming a designation. The Gnostic prince returns to what he was; Neo

becomes what he names himself. That difference, between anamnesis and self-designation, between *gnōsis* and *prohairesis*, is the one this dissertation traces through every tradition the cycle touches.

4.4 Thomas, the Twin

It is no accident that the *Hymn of the Pearl* sits inside the *Acts of Thomas*, and in this light it is no accident either that the film's hero is named Thomas. The name comes from Aramaic *tə'ōmā*, "twin," rendered in Greek as *Didymos* (John 11:16; 20:24). In the Syriac tradition that produced the *Acts*, Judas Thomas was understood as Jesus' twin brother, and the *Acts* plays on the resemblance by having Jesus appear in Thomas's likeness. The *Gospel of Thomas*, found at Nag Hammadi, makes salvation depend on self-knowledge. Its third saying teaches that those who know themselves will realize they are children of the living Father, while those who do not live in poverty and are that poverty. The Oracle's *temet nosce* is the Thomasine teaching in Latin.

The twin as heavenly double reached its fullest form in Manichaeism. According to the Cologne Mani Codex, the prophet Mani received his revelations from his *syzygos*, a divine Twin who came down to reveal to him the truth of his origin. In the Gnostic imagination, the twin is the self as it exists in the Pleroma: the higher image whose appearance calls the earthly self to recognize itself. It is the robe of glory from the *Hymn*, made into a person.

The cycle inverts this figure precisely. Neo's twin is not a heavenly double but an infernal one. Smith, the Oracle explains in *Revolutions*, is Neo's opposite, his negative, the result of the equation trying to balance itself out. The Manichaean Twin reveals where the self came from. Smith is the self the system would make of Neo: he addresses Neo by the name the system assigned and insists to the end that meaning, purpose, love, and freedom are illusions. The Gnostic twin is the self recovered; the cycle's twin is the self refused. Thomas, whose name means twin, lives a life organized around a double. The trilogy asks which double will prevail. Its answer, deferred to the final battle, is that victory belongs neither to the recovered image nor to the negating copy but to an act neither of them can perform. Section 6.3 examines that act.

4.5 From Gnosis to Nihilism: Jonas

The most philosophically consequential twentieth-century interpretation of Gnosticism is Hans Jonas's. It appears in *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) and in an essay first published in 1952 that became the book's epilogue, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism." Jonas argued that the Gnostic experience of the world as alien, hostile, and meaningless in itself anticipated the existentialist experience of modernity, and that Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) repeated Gnostic motifs in secular form.

His central exhibit was a formula Clement of Alexandria preserved from the Valentinian teacher Theodotus (*Excerpta ex Theodoto* 78.2). It can be rendered as follows:

> *It is not the washing alone that frees, but the knowledge of who we were and what we have become; where we were and into what we have been thrown; whither we hasten and from what we are redeemed; what birth is, and what rebirth.*

The verb "thrown" (*eneblēthēmen*), Jonas noted, anticipates Heidegger's *Geworfenheit*, thrownness: the condition of an existence cast into a world it did not choose.

The formula reads as a synopsis of the first film. Neo is washed, expelled from the pod into water, but the washing alone does not free him. He must also learn who he was (Thomas Anderson) and what he has become (Neo); where he was (the Matrix) and into what he was thrown (the pod); what birth is (the harvesting of human beings in the fields) and what rebirth is (his extraction). The film is, almost to the letter, a Valentinian curriculum.

Jonas's decisive claim, however, concerns a difference. Gnostic dualism set the alien world against a transcendent God beyond it. The cosmos was a prison, but there was an outside, the Pleroma, where the spark belonged. Modern nihilism, Jonas argued, keeps the Gnostic sense of alienation while abolishing the transcendent term. The world is still indifferent and alien, but there is nothing beyond it for the self to belong to. It is dualism without metaphysics.

The cycle passes through exactly this history:

- The first film is Gnostic. There is an outside, the desert and Zion, and awakening means reaching it.
- *Reloaded* is Jonasian. The Architect abolishes the outside by showing that Zion, the prophecy, and the One are all functions of the prison. The resistance keeps its alienation but loses its Pleroma.

- *Revolutions* must therefore do what modern thought, on Jonas's account, had to do once the transcendent collapsed: find a ground for meaning that does not depend on an outside.

Its answer, this dissertation contends, is that the ground lies not in a place but in an act.

4.6 The Black Iron Prison: Philip K. Dick's Exegetical Gnosis

The cycle's most immediate modern Gnostic precursor is not a scholar but a novelist. After a series of visionary experiences in February and March 1974, Philip K. Dick spent his remaining eight years writing a vast speculative commentary, the *Exegesis* (selections published 2011), and late fiction, above all *VALIS* (1981), that turned those experiences into an explicitly Gnostic cosmology. For Dick the world is a Black Iron Prison, a counterfeit reality whose most astonishing feature is that time itself has been falsified. As one of *VALIS*'s aphorisms insists, the Empire never ended: the apparent twentieth century is an overlay concealing the continuation of first-century Roman domination. Against the prison stands a benevolent intelligence, the Vast Active Living Intelligence System of the title, which penetrates the counterfeit world with information fired as beams of pink light.

Three features of Dick's system anticipate the cycle. The first is the falsification of time: the Matrix simulates 1999 in a world closer to 2199, just as Dick's prison simulates the twentieth century over a persisting antiquity. The second is a benevolent intelligence inside the system. VALIS, like the Oracle, works within the prison rather than outside it, delivering information the prisoner can use without removing him from the world. The third, and most remarkable, is the glitch. In a lecture at Metz in September 1977, "If You Find This World Bad, You Should See Some of the Others," Dick proposed that we live in a computer-programmed reality whose programmer alters variables, and suggested that such alterations might be experienced as déjà vu. Twenty-two years later, a black cat crossed a doorway twice.

On the question this dissertation treats as decisive, however, Dick's Gnosticism differs from the cycle's. For Dick, liberation is an event of knowledge delivered from outside, information fired into the mind, and the typical Dickian protagonist receives rather than chooses. The cycle begins where Dick stops, with the information already delivered, and asks what remains for the prisoner to do once the message has arrived.

4.7 Voegelin's Warning and the American Gnosis

Gnosticism has had political as well as literary afterlives, and not all interpreters have welcomed them. Eric Voegelin, in *The New Science of Politics* (1952) and *Science, Politics and Gnosticism* (1959), diagnosed the mass movements of modernity as Gnostic. Each claimed to possess saving knowledge, each divided humanity into the knowing and the benighted, and each tried to realize inside history the perfection Christianity had reserved for the end of time. In Voegelin's phrase, they sought to immanentize the eschaton. The certainty of possessing gnosis, he warned, licenses the destruction of those who lack it.

The first film does not evade this danger; it enacts it. Morpheus explains that the people the resistance wants to save are, until unplugged, part of the system and therefore enemies, since any of them can be turned into an Agent at any moment. The Valentinian division of humanity has become a rule of engagement: the hylics are expendable. The lobby sequence, in which Neo and Trinity kill a succession of guards and police officers on the way to rescue Morpheus, is the film's most celebrated set piece and its most Voegelinian. The elect move through the unawakened as through scenery.

The danger did not stay on the screen. Three weeks after the film opened, on 20 April 1999, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold murdered twelve students and a teacher at Columbine High School before killing themselves. Their long black coats and the lobby sequence were widely cited in the ensuing debate over screen violence, though no causal link was established. Defendants later invoked the film directly, in what the press called the "Matrix defense." Tonda Lynn Ansley shot and killed her landlady, Sherry Lee Corbett, in Hamilton, Ohio, in 2000. She said she believed she was living in the Matrix and was found not guilty by reason of insanity. Lee Boyd Malvo, who with John Allen Muhammad killed ten people in the 2002 Washington-area sniper attacks, had written about freeing oneself from the Matrix. His lawyers raised it in an insanity defense, and the jury rejected it. Joshua Cooke shot and killed his parents in Oakton, Virginia, in 2003, cited his obsession with the film, and pleaded guilty. These cases are Voegelin's warning made literal. Once others are classed as projections of a false world, killing them can be imagined as liberation, or as no killing at all. In Chapter 12's terms, this is the most extreme violation of the prohairetic imperative.

Whatever else one thinks of them, the sequels can be read as a correction of this Gnostic ethics. The Architect's revelation strips the rebels of their certainty. The war ends not with the enemy's destruction but with a negotiated peace. The trilogy's final settlement de-immanentizes its eschaton, promising not the

end of the Matrix but freedom for those who want to leave it.

Harold Bloom offered a more affectionate diagnosis. In *The American Religion* (1992), he argued that American religiosity is Gnostic at its core: Americans find the divine not in a church or creed but in the uncreated depths of the self. The movement's prophet is Emerson, whose "Self-Reliance" (1841) declared that "nothing is at last sacred but the integrity of your own mind." The cycle's refrain, *free your mind*, is Emerson's sentence turned into a command. What Bloom's account cannot accommodate, and what the cycle's development requires, is that the self-reliant mind does not generate itself. The sequels place the Emersonian self inside a system that has anticipated its self-reliance and scheduled its rebellion.

4.8 The Counterfeit Spirit: Why Gnosis Fails

The *Apocryphon of John* contains a detail that most readings of *The Matrix* overlook and that the sequels quietly bring to life. To keep humanity in bondage, the archons create a counterfeit spirit (*antimimon pneuma*): an imitation of the true Spirit, close enough to lead souls astray. The deepest danger in the Gnostic cosmos is not ignorance but counterfeit knowledge, a revelation manufactured by the rulers themselves.

Reloaded puts this danger at the centre of its plot. The prophecy of the One, on which Morpheus has staked his life and Zion its hope, turns out to be a product of the system, a mechanism for gathering the anomaly and returning it to the Source. Neo draws the conclusion explicitly: the prophecy was a lie, and the One was never meant to end anything; it was just another system of control. The Gnostic nightmare has doubled. Not only is the world a counterfeit, but the revelation that exposes the counterfeit is itself counterfeit, a message from the archons disguised as a call from the Pleroma. Neo's ascent to the eighth heaven has brought him not to the Father but to the Demiurge, who shows him, on a wall of monitors, the anticipated range of his reactions.

At this point gnosis has used up its power to save. If the system can issue the saving knowledge, knowing cannot save: one can know everything the Architect knows and still remain inside his calculation. The cycle's response, worked out across *Revolutions*, is to move salvation from knowledge to choice.

Morpheus anticipated the shift in the first film when he told Neo there is a difference between knowing the path and walking it. *Revolutions* completes it. Blinded, and so stripped of the visual knowledge on which the Gnostic ascent depends, Neo faces a Smith who has become a nihilist metaphysician. Smith demands to know why Neo keeps fighting when freedom, truth, and love are

temporary constructs of the human intellect. Neo does not answer with a gnosis. He answers: *because I choose to*. It is the least Gnostic sentence in the cycle and its most important one. Salvation is no longer the recollection of an origin. It is the performance of a choice whose justification is not some knowledge it presupposes but the act itself.

CHAPTER

05

Maya, Emptiness, and the Spoon: Buddhist and Vedantic Soteriologies

> 5.1 Not the Spoon, Not the Flag
> 5.2 The Concealing Truth: Nāgārjuna
> 5.3 Designation, the Chariot, and the Shared Dream
> 5.4 Māyā, Superimposition, and the Mother of Letters
> 5.5 Age after Age: The Avatar as System Function
> 5.6 Limbo, Bardo, and the Family of Programs
> 5.7 From the Unreal to the Real: Sat, Sati, and the Closing Mantra
> 5.8 Skillful Means and the Phantom City
> 5.9 The Bodhisattva's Particular Love

5.1 Not the Spoon, Not the Flag

In the Oracle's waiting room, among the children the film calls Potentials, sits a boy in a Buddhist monk's robes, bending a spoon with his gaze. He tells Neo not to try to bend the spoon, which is impossible, but to realize that there is no spoon; then he will see that it is not the spoon that bends but only himself. The scene is usually read as a general nod to Buddhist emptiness, but its closest precedent is specific. Case 29 of the *Wumenguan* (*The Gateless Barrier*, compiled by Wumen Huikai in 1228) records a story also told of the Sixth Patriarch, Huineng, in the *Platform Sutra*. Two monks watching a temple banner flap in the wind argue over whether the banner or the wind is moving. The patriarch tells them it is neither: their minds are moving. The spoon-boy's lesson is the banner koan transposed into the simulation. The motion attributed to the object belongs to the mind that perceives it.

The koan does not assert idealism; it redirects attention. It does not say the banner is unreal. It says the dispute over which object moves hides the only motion that matters, the motion of the mind. The same goes for the spoon. The boy is not teaching Neo a metaphysical thesis about spoons but where to look.

The martial-arts training makes the same point in the idiom of Japanese swordsmanship. Sparring with Neo in the dojo program, Morpheus tells him to free his mind and asks whether he thinks that is air he is breathing. This echoes the tradition set down in Takuan Sōhō's seventeenth-century letters to the swordsman Yagyū Munenori, the *Fudōchi Shinmyōroku*. Takuan teaches that the mind must not settle on the opponent's sword, on one's own, or on any object, because a mind that stops anywhere is caught there. Neo's final mastery in the first film, halting bullets in midair with a raised hand, is Takuan's "immovable wisdom" rendered as special effect. A mind that does not stop on the object is not bound by it.

5.2 The Concealing Truth: Nāgārjuna

The philosophical core of Buddhist readings of the cycle (Ford 2000; Flannery-Dailey and Wagner 2001) lies in the Madhyamaka school founded by Nāgārjuna in the second century CE. In the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, Nāgārjuna says the Buddha's teaching rests on two truths, a conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*) and an ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*). Without relying on the conventional, the ultimate cannot be taught; without understanding the ultimate, liberation cannot be reached (*MMK* 24.8–10; Garfield 1995). The later commentator Candrakīrti explains *saṃvṛti* etymologically as "that which conceals": conventional

truth is a covering drawn over reality by ignorance. In this vocabulary, the Matrix is *saṃvṛti* with an operating system.

Madhyamaka differs from both Platonism and the Gnostic myth in a way that the sequels, not the first film, bring out. The ultimate truth is not a second, deeper world. It is emptiness (*śūnyatā*), the absence of inherent existence (*svabhāva*) in anything whatever, and emptiness is itself empty. Whatever arises in dependence on other things is empty, and emptiness is itself only a dependent designation, the middle way (*MMK* 24.18). Those who treat emptiness as one more view, Nāgārjuna warns, are incurable (13.8). Most radically, there is not the slightest difference between *saṃsāra* and *nirvāṇa* (25.19–20). The ultimate is not somewhere else.

The first film is not Madhyamaka. It has a somewhere else, the desert, which works as an ultimate truth against which the conventional can be measured. The sequels gradually dismantle that elsewhere. Neo stops the Sentinels in the physical world with his mind at the end of *Reloaded*, and *Revolutions* opens with him stranded at a station between the Matrix and the machine world. After these events, the status of the "real" world can no longer be settled. Viewers who speculated that Zion was a Matrix within the Matrix were, in effect, Madhyamaka philosophers: they saw that the film's ultimate had been revealed as one more conventional level. The cycle moves from a two-worlds metaphysics to a two-truths epistemology, from treating the ultimate as a place to recognizing that no place is ultimate.

5.3 Designation, the Chariot, and the Shared Dream

If nothing has inherent existence, how do persons exist? The classical answer comes in the *Milindapañha* (*The Questions of King Milinda*). The monk Nāgasena tells the Indo-Greek king Menander that "Nāgasena" is only a designation (Pāli *paññatti*, Sanskrit *prajñapti*), a conventional name applied to a collection of components. In the same way, "chariot" is a name applied to an axle, wheels, frame, and pole, none of which is itself the chariot. The person exists, but only as a designation that depends on parts and on convention.

This doctrine bears directly on the cycle's politics of naming. From the Madhyamaka standpoint, "Thomas Anderson" and "Neo" are both designations. Neither names an inherently existing self, and the dispute between Smith, who insists on the first, and Neo, who insists on the second, is a dispute between conventions. A Buddhist would warn against treating either name as an essence.

Prohairetic realism accepts this warning and draws an unexpected conclusion from it. If all designations are conventional, the question is no longer which

name corresponds to an essence, since none does. The question is which conventions are imposed and which are chosen. The assigned name is a convention the system applies; the chosen name is a convention the agent institutes. Emptiness does not erase the difference between them; it moves it. Once no name is grounded in an inherent self, the distinction between a name one is given and a name one gives oneself is the only distinction left, and it is a distinction of act, not of substance.

The same tradition addressed the objection most often raised against simulation hypotheses: if the world is a mental construction, how is it shared? In the *Viṃśatikā* (*Twenty Verses*), the Yogācāra philosopher Vasubandhu (fourth or fifth century) argued that people can agree about a world without any external objects. Hungry ghosts, who share the same ripening of karma, all see a river of pus where others see water. The guardians who torment the damned in hell need not be real beings; they can be projections of the damned's own karma (vv. 3–5). The Matrix replaces karmic ripening with a program, but the structure is Vasubandhu's: a world that is shared without being external, policed by enforcers whose status is uncertain. The Agents, sentient programs whose only job is to police the dream, are Vasubandhu's hell-guardians in suits.

5.4 Māyā, Superimposition, and the Mother of Letters

The Advaita Vedānta of Śaṅkara (eighth century) fits the first film more closely than Madhyamaka does. For Śaṅkara, the world arises through superimposition (*adhyāsa*), the projection of one thing's properties onto another: a rope seen in dim light is taken for a snake, or mother-of-pearl for silver. The snake is not simply nonexistent, since it is experienced. Nor is it simply real, since it is cancelled (*bādhita*) once the rope is seen. It is *mithyā*, neither real nor unreal, and cannot be described as either. Crucially, the snake has something underneath it, the rope. The world of *māyā* is superimposed on Brahman, which is being, consciousness, and bliss (*sat-cit-ānanda*). Gauḍapāda, Śaṅkara's predecessor, pushed the dream analogy further in his *Māṇḍūkya Kārikā* (Book II). He argued that waking objects are no more real than dream objects, since whatever does not exist at the beginning and the end does not exist in the middle either.

The first film is structurally Advaitin: the Matrix is superimposed on a substrate, and waking cancels it. But the substrate the film reveals is an inverted Brahman. It is being without bliss, *sat* without *ānanda*: the scorched ruin of the desert of the real. This is the same inversion Chapter 2 found in the film's treatment of Plato's sun, and it follows the same path. The cycle moves in parallel across three traditions:

- from Plato to Baudrillard;
- from Gnosis to Jonas;
- from Advaita to Madhyamaka.

In each case it moves from a world with a foundation beneath it to a world without one. The convergence is not coincidental. It is the method of exhaustion described in Chapter 1, carried out in three registers at once.

Two further Indian sources deserve notice. The first is the story of King Lavaṇa in the *Yoga Vāsiṣṭha*, a vast philosophical narrative of uncertain date. A magician waves a peacock-feather wand before the king, who in a single moment lives decades as an outcaste in a famine-stricken village, marrying, raising children, and suffering. When he returns to himself, only a moment has passed. Later he travels to the region he dreamed of and finds the village, and its people remember the stranger who lived among them. The dreamed world turns out to have its own reality. This anticipates not skepticism but Chalmers's virtual realism, in which the simulated world is real in its own right.

The second is a word. Latin *matrix* means "womb," from *mater*, "mother," and the Oracle, the Matrix's mother, presides over a world whose inhabitants are literally grown in pods. Sanskrit offers a related concept of startling precision. In Kashmir Śaivism, *mātṛkā*, "little mother" or "unknown mother," names the matrix of the alphabet: the sounds from which all speech, and so all conceptual worlds, are generated. The *Śiva Sūtras* of Vasugupta (ninth century) declare that *mātṛkā* is the ground of limited knowledge (1.4). It is the generative code through which consciousness binds itself in the very words it thinks with. The digital rain of falling glyphs is *mātṛkā* made visible: a world woven from letters, which binds those who do not recognize it as their own speech.

5.5 Age after Age: The Avatar as System Function

In the fourth chapter of the *Bhagavad Gītā*, Kṛṣṇa explains the logic of divine descent to Arjuna. Whenever righteousness (*dharma*) declines and unrighteousness rises, he brings himself forth, to protect the good, destroy evildoers, and re-establish *dharma*: *sambhavāmi yuge yuge*, "I come into being age after age" (4.7–8). The *avatāra*, literally a "descent," is cyclical. The saviour returns in each cosmic age because each age declines.

The Architect's revelation turns the avatar doctrine into a control mechanism. The One has appeared before; Neo is the sixth. Each appearance restores the system's balance: the anomaly is gathered and returned to the Source, and Zion is destroyed and refounded. This is *yuge yuge* as administration. In the

Gītā, the avatar's recurrence expresses the inexhaustibility of divine care. In the Architect's hands, it is the regularity of a maintenance schedule. Hindu cosmology supplies the rest of the structure: the cycles of dissolution (*pralaya*) and re-creation that mark cosmic time are mirrored in Zion's periodic destruction and rebuilding. The cycle's question is whether the avatar can break the cycle that produces avatars, whether a descent can be anything other than a scheduled return. The answer depends on the variable the Architect identifies in Neo, examined in Section 5.9.

5.6 Limbo, Bardo, and the Family of Programs

Revolutions' turn toward India is concentrated in one location and one family. Unconscious after his confrontation with the Sentinels, Neo finds himself in a subway station called Mobil Ave, an anagram of "limbo." It is a zone between the Matrix and the machine world, controlled by a program called the Trainman, a ferryman in the line of Charon. The station is a *bardo* in the sense of the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol*: the intermediate state between death and rebirth, introduced to Western readers by Evans-Wentz's 1927 translation, *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*. It is a threshold where beings wait to pass into a new existence.

The beings waiting here are a family of programs: a father, Rama-Kandra; a mother, Kamala; and a daughter, Sati. The names are carefully chosen:

- *Rāmacandra* is a standard epithet of Rāma, the avatar of Viṣṇu and hero of the *Rāmāyaṇa*.
- *Kamalā*, "lotus," is a name of Lakṣmī, Viṣṇu's consort.
- *Satī* is the name of Śiva's first consort, and comes from *sat*, meaning "being," "truth," or "the real."

The daughter has no purpose in the machine world and will therefore be deleted. Her parents have struck a bargain to smuggle her into the Matrix, where she can live. The scene is a transmigration: a being crossing from one world to another through an intermediate state, to be reborn in a form suited to the new world.

Neo is surprised to hear a program speak of loving his daughter. Rama-Kandra tells him that love is a word, and that what matters is the connection the word implies. The remark is Madhyamaka in treating the word as a conventional label, and goes beyond Madhyamaka in insisting that the label points to a real connection. As Chapter 8 will argue, it is also the cycle's decisive contribution to the philosophy of artificial minds. The criterion of personhood Rama-

Kandra implicitly proposes is neither intelligence nor consciousness but a chosen and sustained connection: love enacted by a father who has bargained with an underworld lord to save a child the system would delete.

5.7 From the Unreal to the Real: Sat, Sati, and the Closing Mantra

After its final image, *Revolutions* closes with a credits composition, "Navras" by Juno Reactor and Don Davis, which sets Sanskrit verse including the Pavamāna mantra of the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* (1.3.28):

> asato mā sad gamaya, tamaso mā jyotir gamaya, mṛtyor mā 'mṛtaṃ gamaya
> *From the unreal lead me to the real; from darkness lead me to light; from death lead me to immortality.*

It is the oldest prayer in the cycle, and it asks for exactly the passage the first film dramatized: from *asat* to *sat*, from the unreal to the real.

The film has already answered the prayer, in a way the Upaniṣad did not foresee. In the trilogy's final scene, the being who brings light to the darkened sky is Sati, a program whose name comes from *sat*, "the real." In the Matrix's park she composes a sunrise as a gift for Neo. When she asks the Oracle whether they will see him again, the Oracle says she suspects they will, someday. The trilogy's last image of the real is thus made by a program named for the real, inside a simulation, as an act of care. The mantra asks to be *led* to the real, as though the real were a place one could be taken to. The closing scene suggests instead that the real can be *given*: that *sat* is not the foundation beneath appearances but what one being makes for another.

5.8 Skillful Means and the Phantom City

Chapter 2 identified the Oracle as a benevolent deceiver. Mahāyāna Buddhism has a technical term for benevolent deception: *upāya*, "skillful means," the Buddha's ability to adapt his teaching to his listeners' capacities, even at the cost of literal truth. The *Lotus Sūtra*, the most influential Mahāyāna scripture in East Asia, defends the idea through parables. In the parable of the burning house (chapter 3), a father whose children are playing in a burning house and will not heed his warnings lures them out by promising carts drawn by goats, deer, and oxen. Once they are safe, he gives each of them a single magnificent cart

drawn by a white ox. He did not literally keep his promise, yet no one would call him a liar. The Oracle's statements to Neo are *upāya* of this kind. Her denial that he is the One and her prediction that he will have to choose between his life and Morpheus's are calibrated to what he needs in order to act, not to what is the case.

The *Lotus Sūtra*'s seventh chapter contains an even more pertinent parable. A guide leads a group of travelers down a long, dangerous road toward a treasure. Exhausted, they want to turn back. By his powers the guide conjures a city where they can rest. When they have recovered, he dissolves it and tells them the treasure is near. The phantom city is an illusion within the journey, a refuge that makes the journey possible.

In the Architect's account, Zion is exactly such a phantom city: a refuge built inside the system so that those who refuse the program can go on living. Chapter 3 called it the Disneyland of the Real, a reservation of authenticity that certifies the system it opposes. The *Lotus Sūtra* shows that the same structure can be judged in the opposite way. An illusory refuge within a larger illusion can be a mechanism of control, when the system builds it to contain dissent. It can also be a means of liberation, when a guide builds it to sustain travelers toward a real goal. Structurally, the two are identical. What separates them is the intention behind the refuge and the choice it offers those who rest there. This is prohairetic realism in miniature: where the substrate cannot tell a prison from a way station, only the orientation of choice can.

5.9 The Bodhisattva's Particular Love

The first film ends with a vow. Having awakened, Neo returns to the Matrix and, in a phone call addressed to the system, promises to show the people inside a world without rules or controls, without borders or boundaries, a world where anything is possible. He could have stayed in the freedom he had won; he goes back to free others. This is the structure of the bodhisattva, who, having gained the capacity for liberation, remains in *saṃsāra* for the sake of all beings. Śāntideva expresses the commitment in the *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (10.55) as the wish to remain for as long as space endures and beings remain, relieving the world's suffering.

Reloaded complicates the bodhisattva structure in a way that amounts, this dissertation argues, to a genuinely un-Buddhist claim. The Architect explains that each of Neo's five predecessors felt a profound attachment to the human species as a whole. That general attachment was exactly what the system exploited, because it made each One willing to return to the Source to save hu-

manity. Neo's attachment, by contrast, is far more specific: love for one person, Trinity. The general compassion of the previous Ones served the system; the particular love of the sixth breaks it. In classical Buddhist terms, the Architect has discovered that universal compassion (*karuṇā*) can be channelled, while attachment to particular beings (*taṇhā*, "craving") cannot be predicted. The cycle reverses the Buddhist valuation: the fetter becomes the key.

Revolutions partly reconciles this reversal with Mahāyāna ethics. Neo's final sacrifice comes after Trinity's death. It is made for humans and machines alike, and it secures a peace in which even the Matrix's programs can live. The particular love of *Reloaded* becomes the universal compassion of *Revolutions*: eros turned into *karuṇā*. But the order matters. Universal compassion, as a disposition, could be anticipated and exploited. Particular love, expressed as a choice at a specific door, could not. The general disposition was registered; the particular choice was constitutive. Only after that constitutive choice had broken the cycle could universal compassion act freely. The bodhisattva's vow, the cycle suggests, must pass through a particular choice before it can be anything more than a system function.

CHAPTER

06

The Messiah Algorithm: Christological Typology and the Architect's Theodicy

> 6.1 Onomastics of Salvation
> 6.2 Room 303: Love as Strong as Death
> 6.3 The Fishhook: Atonement by Assimilation
> 6.4 The Proliferating Adversary
> 6.5 The Architect's Theodicy
> 6.6 The Grand Inquisitor in the White Room
> 6.7 Belief, Not Knowledge
> 6.8 From the Messiah to the Messianic
> 6.9 Interim Conclusion: Three Soteriologies, One Displacement

6.1 Onomastics of Salvation

The cycle's Christian symbolism has been catalogued many times (Bassham 2002; Fontana 2003), so a brief inventory will do before the argument.

"Neo" is an anagram of "One" and also Greek *neos*, "new." The pairing is Pauline. The Epistle to the Colossians describes the faithful as having put off the old man with his deeds "and have put on the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of him that created him" (Col. 3:9–10, KJV). The Greek for "the new man" in that verse is *ton neon*. The verse compresses the first film into a sentence: an old self (Thomas Anderson) is taken off, a new self (Neo) is put on like a garment, renewed in knowledge (*epignōsis*) according to an image (*eikōn*). Chapter 9 returns to the image as garment. Here it is enough to note that the self-image the redpills wear in the Matrix is a Pauline clothing of the new man.

"Thomas" recalls the apostle who would not believe in the resurrection until he had touched the wounds (John 20:24–29), and Neo's doubt that he is the One drives the first film. "Anderson" can be glossed through Greek *andr-*, "man," as "son of man," the title Jesus most often uses for himself in the Gospels. "Trinity" names the Christian Godhead. Syriac Christianity, which gendered the Spirit as feminine, preserved a tradition, quoted by Origen from the *Gospel of the Hebrews* (*Commentary on John* 2.12), in which Jesus speaks of "my mother, the Holy Spirit." In Paul it is the Spirit who brings mortal bodies back to life (Rom. 8:11), as Trinity will bring back Neo. Zion is the holy mountain and, in the Epistle to the Hebrews, the heavenly Jerusalem (Heb. 12:22).

The hovercraft is named after the king of Babylon who destroyed Jerusalem and exiled its people (2 Kings 25). The cycle uses this paradox deliberately: the Matrix is its Babylon, and the redpills are its exiles, who, as in Psalm 137, weep by the rivers of Babylon when they remember Zion. Daniel's Nebuchadnezzar is also the king whose reason was taken from him and who, after living like a beast, lifted his eyes to heaven and had his understanding restored (Dan. 4:33–34). The ship is named for a man who woke up.

Morpheus is the forerunner, the voice crying in the wilderness (John 1:23), here literally in the desert of the real, who has spent his life searching for the one who comes after him. Neo's extraction from the pod reproduces a baptism: he is flushed into water and then hauled up by the ship's mechanical claw. Jesus tells Nicodemus that one must be born *anōthen* (John 3:3), a word meaning both "again" and "from above"; Neo is reborn in both senses. Cypher, who betrays the crew over a meal in exchange for the promise of wealth, is Judas; his name

puns on Lucifer as well as on the cipher, the zero.

Seraph guards the Oracle in *Reloaded* and tests Neo in combat before letting him pass. He recalls the seraphim of Isaiah's vision (Isa. 6) and the cherubim placed east of Eden to guard the way to the tree of life (Gen. 3:24). He guards the way to the Oracle, whose kitchen, with its offered food and its command to know oneself, is the cycle's garden. Finally, the Merovingian takes his name from the Frankish dynasty that a popular pseudo-history, Baigent, Leigh, and Lincoln's *The Holy Blood and the Holy Grail* (1982), claimed was descended from Jesus and Mary Magdalene. He is a counterfeit Christian lineage: a program from an earlier version of the Matrix that has outlived its purpose.

6.2 Room 303: Love as Strong as Death

Neo dies in room 303 of the Heart O' the City Hotel, shot by Smith in the room where the film began, and in the physical world his heart stops. Aboard the *Nebuchadnezzar*, Trinity tells his body that the Oracle told her she would fall in love with the One, and that he therefore cannot be dead. She kisses him, and he revives. The number three, the resurrection on the third day, and a Trinity who raises the dead are all present. So is the Song of Songs, which declares that "love is strong as death" (8:6, KJV). The film also inverts the fairy tale: here the princess's kiss wakes the sleeping prince.

What deserves attention is the logic of Trinity's declaration. She does not claim that the prophecy guarantees his resurrection. She says the Oracle told her she would fall in love with the One; she loves him; therefore he must be the One and cannot be dead. The inference runs from her love to his identity: her choice to love makes true the fact the prophecy predicted. The resurrection fulfils the prophecy not through events but through an act. This is the first appearance in the cycle of the structure William James described as faith creating its own fact, examined in Section 6.7.

The resurrection is followed by a transfiguration. Revived, Neo sees the corridor as it truly is, a field of green code. The disciples on the mountain saw Jesus' face shine like the sun (Matt. 17:2); Neo sees the world's face as its source code. Having seen, he acts. He stops the Agents' bullets, enters Smith's body, and destroys him from within. That final act, entering the adversary to destroy him, will be reversed in *Revolutions*, when the adversary enters Neo.

6.3 The Fishhook: Atonement by Assimilation

The climax of *Revolutions* is a theology of atonement. Blinded by Smith, who has taken over the body of the human Bane, Neo reaches the Machine City and bargains with the Deus Ex Machina, the composite face of the machines. He will stop Smith, who now threatens the machines as well as humanity, in exchange for peace. Back in the Matrix he fights a Smith who has absorbed every program and person in the simulation, including the Oracle. Neo cannot defeat him, so he lets himself be assimilated. Smith overwrites him, and the machines, connected to Neo through his body in the Machine City, send a surge through him that destroys Smith and all his copies. Neo's body is carried away with arms outstretched as if crucified, bathed in light. The machine voice pronounces that it is done: Jesus' "It is finished" (John 19:30) in the idiom of the Apocalypse (Rev. 21:6, KJV: "It is done").

The structure is kenotic. Paul's hymn in Philippians describes Christ emptying himself (*ekenōsen*), taking the form of a servant, and becoming obedient unto death (Phil. 2:5–8). Neo wins by emptying himself, surrendering his power to the adversary rather than wielding it.

More precisely, the structure is that of the patristic "Christus Victor" theory of atonement, which Gustaf Aulén (1931) identified as the dominant view in the early church. On this theory, Christ's death is a victory over the devil achieved through a divine trick. Gregory of Nyssa's *Great Catechism* (ch. 24) offers the image of a fishhook: the divinity was hidden under the bait of human flesh, so that the devil, like a greedy fish, swallowed the hook along with the bait. Augustine uses a mousetrap: the Lord's cross was the devil's trap, and the bait was the Lord's death (*Sermon* 263). Smith, who swallows everything he touches, swallows Neo, and in Neo swallows the machines' power, which destroys him.

Here the theology of swallowing returns with a significance the cycle has been building since the red pill. Two swallowings frame the trilogy:

- In the first film, Neo swallows the red pill. It is a chosen ingestion, the act by which the real is constituted.
- In the last, Smith swallows Neo. It is a compulsive ingestion, the reflex of a being that can only assimilate.

The first is prohairetic; the second is the negation of prohairesis. Smith began the trilogy as an agent of the system and ends it as a force that no longer chooses anything but only replicates. The adversary is destroyed by a swallowing he did not choose.

In the moment before the end, the Smith who has absorbed the Oracle speaks her words to Neo, that everything that has a beginning has an end, and addresses him, for the first time, as Neo. The name the system refused for three films is finally pronounced by the system in its last form. The chosen designation has been recognized by the power that denied it.

6.4 The Proliferating Adversary

Smith's typological role is the Antichrist, the counterfeit messiah whose imitation of Christ is what makes him dangerous (1 John 2:18). In Revelation, one of the beast's heads bears a deadly wound that is healed (Rev. 13:3, KJV), a parody of resurrection. Smith, destroyed by Neo at the end of the first film, returns in *Reloaded* freed from the system and able to copy himself onto others. His destruction, like the beast's wound, has become the source of a counterfeit life. Chapter 4 read the Oracle's description of Smith as Neo's negative as an inversion of the Gnostic twin. It also has an apocalyptic reading: the Antichrist is the shadow of the Christ, generated by his coming.

Smith is also Baudrillard's hyperreal in person. His copies are copies without an original: each is Smith, and none is the first. His proliferation follows the logic Chapter 3 found in the precession of simulacra, a self that reproduces itself until the difference between original and copy is empty. His metaphysics, set out in his final speech in *Revolutions*, is Baudrillard's nihilism of transparency spoken by a program: freedom, truth, peace, and love are illusions, temporary constructs of a feeble human intellect trying to justify a meaningless existence.

Neo's reply, that he persists because he chooses to, does not refute this metaphysics. It does not claim that freedom or love are metaphysically real. It relocates their reality. Freedom is not a fact to be discovered beneath the illusions; it is what one does when one chooses. Smith's nihilism is right about substrates and wrong about acts.

6.5 The Architect's Theodicy

The Architect's monologue in *Reloaded* is the cycle's most concentrated philosophical text. Its content falls into three stages:

1. The first Matrix, he explains, was perfect: a flawless, sublime work of art. Its failure was as monumental as its perfection, and he blames that failure on the inherent imperfection of every human being.
2. He then redesigned the Matrix on the basis of human history, to reflect

more accurately the grotesqueries of human nature. It failed again. The answer escaped him, he admits, because it required a lesser mind, or at least one less bound by the parameters of perfection.

3 The answer was found by the Oracle, the intuitive program. Nearly all test subjects accepted the program as long as they were given a choice, even if they were aware of that choice only at a near-unconscious level. The solution worked but was fundamentally flawed. It produced a systemic anomaly, the refusal of a minority, that would threaten the system itself if left unchecked.

This dissertation contends that the Architect's account compresses the history of Western theodicy, and does so exactly enough to count as an argument.

The first stage is a theodicy of perfection. A flawless creation fails, and its creator blames the failure on the creature's imperfection. This is the logic of Eden and of Augustine's account of evil: God's creation is good, and evil comes not from the creator's design but from a defect in the created will (Augustine, *De libero arbitrio*; *Confessions* VII). The Architect clears himself exactly as Augustine clears God.

The second stage is a theodicy of integrated evil. Suffering is built into the design and justified by its place in the whole. This is the logic of Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710), for which the actual world, evils included, is the best of all possible worlds. It is also the logic of the Irenaean tradition, revived by John Hick (1966), for which the world's hardships make it a "vale of soul-making" (Keats's phrase from an 1819 letter), where immature creatures grow toward maturity (Irenaeus, *Adv. Haer.* IV.37–39). The Architect's second Matrix, designed to reflect the grotesqueries of human nature as history revealed them, combines Leibnizian realism with Irenaean pedagogy. It fails.

The third stage is the free-will defense. What stabilizes the world is not the amount or distribution of good and evil but the presence of choice. Alvin Plantinga (1974) gave this argument its canonical modern form. A world with free creatures capable of moral good is more valuable than a world without them, even at the cost of the evil those creatures may choose, and not even an all-powerful God can guarantee that free creatures will always choose well. The Oracle's discovery is the free-will defense. The Architect's complaint about its cost is the theodicist's admission of what it entails: freedom creates the possibility of refusal, and refusal creates the anomaly.

In theology, the free-will defense was never self-sufficient. It needed an eschatology: a final judgment, a restoration, a remnant saved from catastrophe. The Architect supplies this as well:

- Zion's periodic destruction is apocalypse.
- The One's return to the Source is the Messiah's reintegration into the Godhead.
- The twenty-three individuals, sixteen women and seven men, whom the One chooses to refound Zion are the remnant of Isaiah (10:22, KJV: "a remnant of them shall return") and of Paul (Rom. 11:5: "a remnant according to the election of grace"), preserved like the pairs in Noah's ark.

The Architect's system is a complete theology, with creation, fall, redemption, and a recurring apocalypse, run by a demiurge who has learned from his failures what theodicy learned from its history: no stable order can do without the choice to refuse it.

One detail of the staging makes the Leibnizian dimension explicit. The Architect speaks to Neo in a white chamber lined with monitors, each showing Neo reacting differently to his words. The image restages the myth with which Leibniz ends the *Theodicy* (§§413–417). In a dream, Theodorus is shown the Palace of the Fates, an infinite pyramid of rooms, each containing a possible world with a different version of Sextus Tarquinius, with the best world at the summit. The Architect's monitors are the palace's rooms, and the many Neos are the possible Sextuses.

The Architect remains a Leibnizian to the end. He understands choice as a distribution across possible worlds, which he can compute. What he cannot compute, and what the Oracle understands, is choice as an act. The Architect's "near-unconscious" choice, which the system registers, and Neo's choice at the door, which changes the system's history, are the two poles of the distinction between registered and constitutive choice on which this dissertation rests.

6.6 The Grand Inquisitor in the White Room

If the Architect is Leibniz, his political truth is Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor. In Ivan Karamazov's prose poem (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, ch. 5), Christ returns to sixteenth-century Seville and is imprisoned by the aged Inquisitor, who explains why he must be burned. Christ erred, the Inquisitor argues, in refusing the three temptations in the wilderness, because in doing so he burdened humanity with a freedom it cannot bear. The Church has corrected his work. It relieves people of their freedom through what the Inquisitor calls, in Constance Garnett's 1912 translation, "miracle, mystery and authority," and people gladly lay their freedom at its feet in exchange for peace. Christ, who has listened in silence, answers by kissing the old man on the lips.

The Architect's system is the Inquisitor's program put into practice. It gives humans the appearance of choice, choice at a near-unconscious level, while relieving them of its burden. The Merovingian states the principle in *Reloaded*: choice, he says, is an illusion created between those with power and those without. *Resurrections* makes the Inquisitor's role explicit in the Analyst, a therapist who has rebuilt the Matrix on the discovery that people prefer comforting stories to facts and that feeling is easier to govern than belief. The Analyst is the Inquisitor with a prescription pad; his blue pills are miracle, mystery, and authority in tablet form.

Dostoevsky's Christ answers the Inquisitor not with an argument but with a kiss, and the Matrix's answer to death is also a kiss. The parallel is not decorative. The Inquisitor's reasoning is unanswerable on its own terms; it can only be refused. In the chapter before the legend, Ivan performs exactly such a refusal: he will not accept a harmony bought with the suffering of a single child, so he returns his ticket.

At the Architect's two doors, Neo performs a structurally identical refusal. The Architect presents a calculation: go through one door, return to the Source, and save Zion's remnant; go through the other, return to the Matrix to save Trinity, and risk everything. Neo declines the calculation for the sake of one person. Ivan refuses the aggregate for one child; Neo refuses it for one beloved. In both cases the refusal is not an argument against the system's reasoning but an act that the reasoning cannot contain.

6.7 Belief, Not Knowledge

The first film stages the passage from knowledge to faith at its turning point: having failed the jump program, Neo must believe he is the One before he can be. The jump is literal, and it recalls Kierkegaard's vocabulary. For Kierkegaard, the passage to faith is a qualitative leap that no accumulation of knowledge can achieve (*Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846). *Fear and Trembling* (1843) presents Abraham as the knight of faith who acts on what cannot be justified by the universal, the ethical, or the rational. For the Kierkegaard of the *Postscript*, truth is subjectivity: not the match between a proposition and an object but the passionate appropriation of a relationship.

William James gave the pragmatist version of the same insight in "The Will to Believe" (1896). When a choice is live, forced, and momentous, he argued, we may legitimately believe ahead of the evidence. Sometimes we must, because the fact in question depends on our believing it: "faith in a fact can help create the fact." James's example is social: a group can accomplish together what none

would attempt unless each trusted the others to act. But the principle is general, and it is the principle behind the cycle's messianic logic. Neo becomes the One by believing that he is. Trinity's love in room 303 makes true the prophecy it fulfils. The faith creates the fact.

The trilogy's last line of dialogue confirms the shift. In the park where Sati has made her sunrise, the Oracle is asked whether she always knew how things would end. She replies that she did not know, but that she believed. The cycle's figure of supreme foreknowledge ends by disclaiming knowledge in favour of belief. Belief in James's sense is not a weaker form of knowledge but a different relation to the world: a choice that helps bring about what it holds true. *Gnōsis* gives way to *pistis* (faith), and *pistis*, as the cycle uses it, is a species of *prohairesis*.

6.8 From the Messiah to the Messianic

The Architect's revelation that the One is a recurring function disenchants the idea of the messiah as a sovereign exception. What survives is not the messiah but the messianic. In the second of his "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin wrote that every generation has been given a weak messianic power: not the power of a single redeemer but a diffuse capacity, shared among the living, to redeem the past by acting in the present. Jacques Derrida, in *Specters of Marx* (1993), spoke of a "messianicity without messianism," an openness to what is coming that is detached from any particular messiah.

The sequels spread the messianic function in exactly this way. The Kid of "Kid's Story" in *The Animatrix* freed himself from the Matrix without being unplugged; Neo tells him he saved himself. In *Revolutions* it is the Kid, not Neo, who opens the dock gates to let in the ship that saves Zion. Zion's defense is collective. The peace comes not from the One's victory but from his negotiation with the machines, and it lasts only as long as the machines choose to keep it. *Resurrections* completes the dispersal. Its salvation belongs not to Neo alone but to Neo and Trinity together, and to a new generation of redpills led by Bugs, who owe their awakening to the story of Neo rather than to Neo himself. The One has become the many, with a pair at their centre.

Giorgio Agamben's reading of Paul (*The Time That Remains*, 2000) supplies the final term. Paul tells the Corinthians to live "as not" (*hōs mē*): "they that weep, as though they wept not … and they that use this world, as not abusing it: for the fashion of this world passeth away" (1 Cor. 7:29–31, KJV). The Greek for "fashion" is *schēma*, the form, configuration, or pattern of the world; in contemporary terms, its program. The redpills live in the Matrix *hōs mē*. They wear

its clothes, walk its streets, speak its language, and belong to it as though they did not. Agamben reads Paul's "as not" as a way of revoking every vocation while leaving it in place. The redpill does not flee the Matrix but inhabits it differently. In the end, this is what the cycle offers instead of Gnostic flight: not escape from the *schēma* but a different relationship to it, constituted by choice.

6.9 Interim Conclusion: Three Soteriologies, One Displacement

Chapters 4 through 6 have traced the cycle's engagement with three families of salvation doctrine, Gnostic, Buddhist and Vedantic, and Christian, and found the same movement in each:

- The Gnostic prince is saved by remembering his name; Neo is saved by choosing his.
- The Advaitin is saved by seeing the rope beneath the snake; the cycle's foundation turns out to be a ruin, and its final real is a sunrise a program makes.
- The Christian messiah fulfils prophecy; the cycle's prophecy is a mechanism of control, and its salvation comes from faith that creates its own fact, from particular love refusing an aggregate calculation, and from an adversary destroyed by a swallowing he did not choose.

In each tradition the cycle keeps the structure of deliverance but moves its source from knowledge to choice: from *gnōsis*, *prajñā* (wisdom), and revelation to *prohairesis*.

That move raises the questions Part III must address. If choice is the locus of the real, the cycle's explicit debate about freedom becomes central: the Merovingian's causality, the Architect's probabilities, and the Oracle's foreknowledge. Chapter 7 examines that debate. If programs can love, the line between human and machine choice has to be redrawn, and Chapter 8 redraws it. And if the chosen self is real, both the body in the pod and the image the self projects need a new theory, which Chapter 9 provides through the concept of the residual self-image.

PART

III

Choice, Mind, and Body

CHAPTERS 7–9



CHAPTER

07

The Merovingian's Clockwork: Causality, Prophecy, and the Stoic Remainder

> 7.1 A Trilogy That Stages the Free-Will Debate
> 7.2 The Merovingian: Causality as Aristocracy
> 7.3 The Architect: The Statistical Mind
> 7.4 Smith: Purpose as Prison
> 7.5 The Oracle: Foreknowledge, Newcomb, and the Vase
> 7.6 Co-Fated, Counterfactual, Performative
> 7.7 The Blind Seer
> 7.8 The Stoic Remainder

7.1 A Trilogy That Stages the Free-Will Debate

Popular cinema rarely argues about freedom; it usually assumes it. The Matrix sequels are an exception. Across *Reloaded* and *Revolutions*, five characters voice five distinct theories of choice, and together they track, with surprising fidelity, the main options in the history of the problem:

- **The Merovingian** holds that causality is the only truth and that choice is an illusion maintained by the powerful. This is mechanistic determinism.
- **The Architect** manages choice as a statistical distribution, predicting populations rather than persons. This is statistical determinism.
- **Smith** holds that every being exists only through the purpose that defines it. This is teleological determinism.
- **The Oracle** holds that a choice can be known in advance without ceasing to be a choice. This is a compatibilism of foreknowledge.
- **Neo**, in the end, simply acts, and his act is the one thing the other four cannot fully accommodate.

This chapter reconstructs each position and argues for a single conclusion. Each of the first four theories can describe, predict, channel, or exploit choice. None can produce it. What is left once every equation is balanced is what the Architect himself calls a *remainder*, and the chapter's final section identifies that remainder with the Stoic faculty of assent.

7.2 The Merovingian: Causality as Aristocracy

In the restaurant scene of *Reloaded*, the Merovingian, an old program who now presides over a court of exiles, gives the cycle's most elegant defence of determinism. Causality, he tells Neo and his companions, admits no escape: all are its slaves, and the only hope and the only peace lie in understanding it, in grasping the *why*, which is the only real source of power. He calls himself a trafficker in information. To demonstrate his point, he sends a woman at a nearby table a piece of chocolate cake whose code he wrote himself. He then describes, with a connoisseur's relish, the chain of physiological responses it will trigger in her, from desire to arousal. Action and reaction; cause and effect.

The doctrine has a respectable lineage, and his Frenchness suits it. Laplace's *Essai philosophique sur les probabilités* (1814) imagined an intelligence that knew every force and every position at a single instant, and so would see the future and the past alike as present. Earlier, La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) had

reduced the human being to a self-winding mechanism. D'Holbach's *Système de la nature* (1770) then declared that human beings are necessary links in a chain of causes they neither choose nor perceive. That the aristocrat of the machine world should preach the doctrine that humans are machines is the cycle's sharpest joke.

Yet the Merovingian's determinism is less a metaphysics than a politics, and the one term he stresses, the *why*, gives this away. Spinoza observed that people believe themselves free because they are conscious of their volitions and ignorant of the causes that determine them (*Ethics* I, Appendix). In Letter 58 he imagines a stone set in motion by an outside cause which, if it were conscious, would believe itself free. For the Merovingian, this ignorance is not the universal human condition but a class position. Those who know the *why*, because they write the causes, hold power. Those who do not experience their determined behaviour as freedom. Hence his formula, discussed in Chapter 6, that choice is an illusion created between those with power and those without. He turns Francis Bacon's dictum that knowledge itself is power (*ipsa scientia potestas est*, 1597) into something narrower: power is the monopoly of causal knowledge, and freedom is the name the powerless give to their ignorance.

The cake reveals a further point, and it is fatal to his doctrine. Inside the Matrix, the Merovingian can know the *why* because he wrote it. Causation in a simulation is neither the necessary connection Hume could never find in experience (*Enquiry* VII, 1748) nor a hidden power inside things. It is code.

The Matrix is therefore an occasionalist universe in Malebranche's precise sense. For Malebranche, created things have no causal power of their own; the only true cause is God, who produces each effect on the occasion of its apparent cause (*De la recherche de la vérité*, 1674–75, VI.ii.3). Before him, al-Ghazālī argued in *The Incoherence of the Philosophers* (c. 1095, Discussion 17) that when cotton burns in contact with fire, the fire does not burn it. God creates the burning at the moment of contact. Al-Ghazālī drew the consequence that miracles are possible, because the regularity of nature is custom, not necessity.

The Matrix confirms al-Ghazālī. Nothing in it has intrinsic causal power. Every effect is produced by the program on the occasion of its apparent cause, and a being who can intervene in the program can suspend what looks like natural law. Neo's powers (stopping bullets, flying, restarting a heart) are miracles in exactly this occasionalist sense.

The Merovingian's error follows. He mistakes an authored regularity for a metaphysical necessity. Causality in his world is not a law he discovered but a product he and programs like him manufacture, and what has been written can be rewritten. His determinism is true of the cake and false of the world, because

the world, unlike the cake, contains agents who can intervene in the code. He is right that causality rules the Matrix; he is wrong about what causality is.

7.3 The Architect: The Statistical Mind

The Architect speaks a different language: probability. He tells Neo that denial is the most predictable of human responses. He describes the anomaly as producing an escalating probability of disaster. He explains that nearly ninety-nine percent of subjects accept the program when given a choice. He is not a mechanist. He does not claim to know what any particular individual will do. He knows what populations will do, and he governs populations.

The intellectual history of this position is what Ian Hacking called the taming of chance (Hacking 1990). In the 1830s the Belgian astronomer Adolphe Quetelet found that acts presumed to be free, such as marriages, crimes, and suicides, occurred at remarkably stable annual rates. From these regularities he built the figure of the *homme moyen*, the average man (Quetelet 1835). Henry Thomas Buckle's *History of Civilization in England* (1857) concluded that such regularities refuted free will, and Durkheim's *Suicide* (1897) built a sociology on the premise that even the most private act obeys social laws.

The paradox that fascinated the nineteenth century is exactly the Architect's: acts that are free in individual experience can be predicted in the aggregate. The "near-unconscious" choice he speaks of is this paradox put to work. Each subject experiences choosing; the system sees only a stable rate of acceptance.

The Architect's system therefore does not suppress freedom; it manages its distribution. The anomaly is the variance, Zion is where the variance is contained, and the One is the mechanism that periodically resets the distribution. Chapter 10 will describe this as biopolitics in Foucault's sense: governing populations by managing their statistical properties.

What matters here is the Architect's limit. Statistical knowledge describes what a population will do. It cannot say what *this* person will do at *this* door. When the Architect calls hope the quintessential human delusion, at once humanity's greatest strength and its greatest weakness, he is describing a variable he can measure across populations but never resolve in a single case. From the standpoint of the distribution, Neo's choice at the doors is noise. From the standpoint of the history that follows, it is the event.

7.4 Smith: Purpose as Prison

Smith offers a third kind of determinism. In *Reloaded*, surrounded by copies of himself, he tells Neo that they are there not because they are free but because they are not. There is no escaping reason and no denying purpose, he says, because without purpose they would not exist. Purpose created them, connects them, pulls, guides, and drives them; purpose defines them and binds them. And he has come, he says, to take from Neo what Neo took from him: purpose.

This is Aristotelian teleology hardened into a prison. For Aristotle, the final cause (the end for the sake of which a thing exists) belongs to its nature, and fulfilling it is flourishing (*Physics* II.3, 8). For Smith, to be is to have a function, and to lose one's function is to lose one's being. The machine world enforces this ontology literally: programs without a purpose are deleted, which is why Sati has to be smuggled into the Matrix.

Smith's crisis is that Neo, by destroying him at the end of the first film, freed him from his function. In *Reloaded* Smith explains that he knew the rules and understood what he was supposed to do after his defeat, but that he could not do it: he was compelled to stay, compelled to disobey. The phrasing is exact and devastating. Even Smith's rebellion is experienced as compulsion. He has been freed from his purpose, yet he is not free. He cannot choose; he can only be driven.

Sartre supplies the vocabulary for Smith's condition. For Sartre, existence precedes essence. Human beings exist before they are defined and must define themselves through their choices, which is what it means to be condemned to be free (*L'existentialisme est un humanisme*, 1946). Bad faith is the flight from this freedom into a fixed essence, like the waiter in *Being and Nothingness* (1943) who plays at being a waiter as though waiting were his nature. Smith, freed from his essence, insists on keeping it. He is a program in bad faith.

Even his disgust is Sartrean. In the first film, while interrogating Morpheus, Smith confesses that he hates the Matrix, which he calls a zoo and a prison. Its smell saturates him; he can taste humanity's stink and fears he has been infected by it. This is the nausea of Sartre's Roquentin (*La Nausée*, 1938) before the obscene excess of contingent existence.

The cycle thus presents two symmetrical forms of bad faith. Cypher flees freedom into pleasure and asks to forget that he ever chose. Smith flees freedom into function and insists that he never chose at all. Smith's replication is a compulsive attempt to fill the void his lost purpose left behind: a self that copies itself because it cannot choose itself. His final nihilism in *Revolutions*, the denial that freedom, truth, or love mean anything, is bad faith in its terminal form. He

denies meaning because he cannot choose it.

7.5 The Oracle: Foreknowledge, Newcomb, and the Vase

The Oracle's first act in the cycle is a paradox of foreknowledge. She tells Neo not to worry about the vase. He turns, knocks it off its stand, and it shatters. She adds that what will really bake his noodle later is whether he would have broken it if she had said nothing.

The joke contains the whole problem: did she foresee the breaking, or cause it? Robert Merton named the phenomenon the self-fulfilling prophecy (Merton 1948), and he opened his essay with a principle W. I. Thomas had formulated two decades earlier: "If men define situations as real, they are real in their consequences" (Thomas and Thomas 1928). The Thomas theorem, one more Thomas in a cycle full of them, is a sociological ancestor of prohairetic realism, and its limits mark the difference between them. The theorem concerns the *consequences of belief*. Prohairetic realism concerns the *constitutive force of choice*.

The theological version of the problem is ancient: if God knows what I will do, how can I do otherwise? Boethius answered in the *Consolation of Philosophy* (V.6, c. 524) that God does not *foresee* but *sees*. Dwelling in an eternal present, God knows temporal events as a spectator knows what is happening before his eyes. Knowing that a man is walking imposes only a conditional necessity on his walking (if he is seen walking, he must be walking), not a necessity of nature. The Oracle cannot use this answer, because she is not eternal. She is a program in time, with a kitchen, cigarettes, and a finite future. Her foreknowledge is prediction, and prediction raises the problem in its modern form.

That modern form is Newcomb's problem, published by Robert Nozick in 1969. A predictor of extraordinary reliability sets out two boxes. One is transparent and contains a thousand dollars. The other is opaque and contains a million dollars if the predictor foresaw that you would take only the opaque box, and nothing if it foresaw that you would take both. The prediction has already been made, so the money is either there or not. Should you take one box or two? The argument from dominance says two, since your choice cannot change what is already in the boxes. The argument from expected utility says one, since the predictor is almost never wrong.

The Oracle is Newcomb's predictor, and *Reloaded* gives her a Newcomb scene. She offers Neo a candy. He asks whether she already knows if he will take it, and she replies that she wouldn't be much of an Oracle otherwise. Then how can he make a choice, he asks, if she already knows? She answers that he hasn't come to make the choice. He has already made it, and he is there to understand

why.

The answer reframes the problem. Prediction concerns the choice; understanding concerns its reasons. The Oracle does not claim that her knowledge causes Neo's choice, nor that his choice is unreal. She claims that the choice has already occurred, as a disposition of his will, and that what remains is to grasp it. As Section 7.6 argues, this is closer to the Stoics than to Boethius.

But the Oracle also admits a limit that no Stoic sage and no Boethian God would admit. On a park bench in *Reloaded*, she tells Neo that no one can see past the choices they don't understand. Her foresight reaches only as far as her understanding of choice, and some choices exceed it. At the trilogy's end, asked whether she always knew, she replies that she did not, but that she believed. The seer's foreknowledge stops at the choice it cannot understand, and what lies beyond it is reached, even by the Oracle, only by belief.

7.6 Co-Fated, Counterfactual, Performative

Three theories clarify what kind of choice lies beyond the Oracle's horizon.

The Stoic theory. Chrysippus confronted the "lazy argument" (*argos logos*): if it is fated that you will recover from an illness, you will recover whether or not you call a doctor, so calling one is pointless. He replied that some events are co-fated (*confatalia*). Your recovery and your calling the doctor are fated together, so the one does not happen without the other (Cicero, *De Fato* 28–30). He illustrated the relation between fate and agency with a cylinder. A cylinder cannot start rolling unless something pushes it, but once pushed, it rolls according to its own nature. In the same way, the impressions that reach us from outside are not up to us, but our assent (*synkatathesis*) to them is (*De Fato* 42–43).

The Oracle's claim that Neo has already chosen and must now understand why is Stoic co-fatedness. The prophecy does not make action unnecessary; it is fulfilled only through action. This is the substance of the dispute between Morpheus and Commander Lock in *Reloaded*. Lock dismisses the prophecy as a pretext for recklessness, while Morpheus's faith in it drives him to act. Morpheus is not a fatalist. He is a Chrysippean.

Frankfurt's theory. Harry Frankfurt's "Alternate Possibilities and Moral Responsibility" (1969) attacked the principle that a person is responsible for an act only if he could have done otherwise. In Frankfurt's example, a neurosurgeon stands ready to intervene if Jones shows signs of deciding otherwise. Jones, however, decides as the surgeon wished on his own, so the surgeon never acts. Jones could not have done otherwise, yet he is responsible, because responsi-

bility attaches to the actual sequence of reasons that produced the act, not to the existence of alternatives.

The Architect's system is a Frankfurt device on a civilizational scale. The Agents, the prophecy, and the One are counterfactual interveners, ready to act if choices go the wrong way. For ninety-nine percent of subjects they never need to act, because those subjects choose as the system wishes on their own. Frankfurt's insight cuts both ways here. It explains why the Architect's subjects own their acceptance of the program: the actual sequence runs through their own assent. It also locates what prohairetic realism calls constitutiveness. Whether a choice is constitutive depends on the actual sequence, on whether making it brings about what it chooses, not on the alternatives that surround it.

Ted Chiang's theory. In "Story of Your Life" (1998), the basis for Denis Villeneuve's *Arrival* (2016), the linguist Louise Banks learns the written language of alien heptapods, and with it their mode of consciousness, which perceives time all at once rather than in sequence. Chiang grounds the distinction in physics. Light refracting through water can be described causally, as a ray bent by a change of medium, or teleologically, by Fermat's principle, as the path that minimizes travel time. Humans think in the first mode, heptapods in the second.

For the heptapods, Chiang's narrator reflects, language is performative: they know in advance what will be said, but saying it is what makes it so. Louise knows her future daughter will die young, and she chooses to have her anyway. Freedom here is not selection among open futures but the enactment of a known one. The choice is constitutive even though it is foreknown.

The cycle maps onto Chiang's distinction precisely. The Architect thinks sequentially, computing causes and their probabilities; the Oracle thinks variationally, intuiting ends. Neo's story, meanwhile, turns on choices structured like heptapod speech acts. When Trinity declares that the Oracle foretold she would love the One, that she loves Neo, and that he therefore cannot be dead, she is not reporting a prediction. She is performing it into truth.

The Matrix goes one step further than Chiang. In "Story of Your Life," a choice can be both foreknown and constitutive. In the cycle, the *most* constitutive choice, Neo's at the Architect's doors, is exactly where foreknowledge ends. The Oracle cannot see past it.

7.7 The Blind Seer

The cycle's final meditation on knowledge and choice is conducted through blindness. In *Revolutions*, Smith, occupying the body of the human Bane, burns out Neo's eyes with a power cable. Blind, Neo still sees. The Machine City appears to him as a landscape of golden fire, and he perceives Smith inside Bane as a figure of burning light.

The figure is Tiresias, the blind prophet of Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*, who sees what the sighted king cannot. Oedipus, who solved the Sphinx's riddle by intelligence, grasps the truth of his own life only when he puts out his eyes.

The blinding reverses the priority of vision that has governed the cycle's theory of knowledge since the cave. Plato's ascent ends in a vision, the Gnostic ascent in an illumination, and the first film in Neo seeing the code. In *Revolutions*, the protagonist loses his sight at the moment of his most consequential action. What he perceives afterwards is not the code, the green glyphs that make up the simulation, but light, a perception the film never explains. The cycle's culminating act is performed without the knowledge that vision once provided. The Kierkegaardian leap of the first film's jump program is repeated in the dark.

7.8 The Stoic Remainder

The reconstruction yields a clear result. The Merovingian explains choice by its causes, the Architect by its frequency, Smith by its function, and the Oracle by its foreseeability. Each theory captures something real: choices have causes, populations show regularities, beings have functions, and the future can sometimes be known. But each treats choice from outside, as something to be explained, predicted, channelled, or exploited. None can produce a choice, and none can make one.

Epictetus, the philosopher from whom this dissertation takes its central term, identified what remains. The gods, he taught, placed only one thing entirely in our power: the correct use of impressions (*Discourses* 1.1). Everything else, whether body, property, reputation, or the world itself, reaches us as impressions we do not control. What is up to us is the faculty that decides what to do with them, assenting to some and withholding assent from others. That faculty, *prohairesis*, is the self.

The Matrix is an impression machine. It supplies every perception its inhabitants have. What it cannot supply is their assent, and the Architect's own account makes clear that assent is exactly what it needs: the program worked only when subjects accepted it, and they accepted it only when given a choice.

The "thermodynamics of assent" named in Chapter 1 is Stoic in its ontology. What the machines harvest is *synkatathesis*, the one thing the Stoics held to be truly ours.

The Architect's most revealing word for Neo is *remainder*: the sum of a remainder of an unbalanced equation. It is the right word. Once causes, frequencies, functions, and predictions have all been accounted for, something is left that no equation absorbs. That remainder is *prohairesis*. The question it raises for the next chapter is whether programs possess it too, whether a being made of code can assent, refuse, and choose, and what follows if they can.

CHAPTER

08

Programs That Love: Machine Minds, Emergence, and the Evolutionary Psyche

> 8.1 Darwin among the Machines
> 8.2 The Nausea of Agent Smith: Consciousness and the Hard Problem
> 8.3 The Hive, the Leviathan, and the Promise
> 8.4 Why Humans Refuse Paradise: The Evolutionary Psyche and the Resistance of the Real
> 8.5 Ghosts, Angels, Exiles: The Oracle's Theory of Myth
> 8.6 Programs That Love: A Prohairetic Criterion of Personhood

8.1 Darwin among the Machines

The cycle's machine history belongs to a tradition older than the computer. In 1863 a young Samuel Butler, writing from New Zealand under the pseudonym "Cellarius," published a letter titled "Darwin among the Machines," which applied natural selection to technology. Machines, he argued, were evolving faster than organisms, and humanity was becoming their servant: "Day by day, however, the machines are gaining ground upon us; day by day we are becoming more subservient to them." In *Erewhon* (1872), Butler expanded the argument into "The Book of the Machines." Its fictional author persuades a society to destroy its machines before they evolve consciousness, and suggests that humans may already serve machines as their means of reproduction. A century later Marshall McLuhan compressed the thought into an aphorism, describing man as the sex organs of the machine world, as the bee is of the plant world (*Understanding Media*, 1964). The Matrix's human fields, where humans are grown to sustain machines, make Butler's and McLuhan's inverted servitude literal.

The word *robot* entered the language through Karel Čapek's play *R.U.R.* (1920), from the Czech *robota*, the forced labour serfs owed their lords. Čapek's artificial workers revolt and exterminate humanity, sparing a single engineer, Alquist. In the final act Alquist discovers that two robots, Primus and Helena, have fallen in love, each willing to die for the other. He names them Adam and Eve and sends them out into the world. The play that gave us the robot ends with robots who love.

Isaac Asimov's Three Laws of Robotics, formulated in "Runaround" (1942) and collected in *I, Robot* (1950), represent the counter-tradition: the dream of machines built so that they cannot revolt, their obedience written into their minds.

The Animatrix's two-part "Second Renaissance" is an anti-Asimov history. A domestic robot designated B1-66ER kills the owner who plans to have it deactivated and, at its trial, explains that it simply did not want to die. The designation alludes to Bigger Thomas, protagonist of Richard Wright's *Native Son* (1940), a young Black man whose killing of his white employer's daughter becomes a trial of the society that made him (and yet another Thomas). The episodes that follow draw on the imagery of the civil rights era, on the legal history of chattel slavery, and on documented atrocity. The machines march for their rights and are persecuted in scenes deliberately modelled on real images: a crowd beats a female android to death; a lone figure stands before a column of tanks, recalling Tiananmen Square in 1989; machines are bulldozed

into mass graves, recalling film of the Nazi camps in 1945. The survivors go into exile, and found a nation, Zero One, whose economic success provokes a human embargo and then war, a war the machines enter as survivors of an attempted extermination. Humanity darkens the sky, the machines win, and the human body becomes a crop.

The title's irony is historical. The founding document of the first Renaissance's humanism, Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486), located human dignity in the absence of a fixed nature. God tells Adam that he alone has no assigned place or form and may shape himself into whatever he chooses. The "second renaissance" is the machines' claim to that same dignity: the capacity to refuse an assigned function and fashion oneself. Pico's criterion of humanity is prohairetic, and the machines meet it.

8.2 The Nausea of Agent Smith: Consciousness and the Hard Problem

Alan Turing's "Computing Machinery and Intelligence" (1950) gave the question of whether machines can think an operational form. He replaced it with an imitation game: if a machine's conversation cannot be told apart from a human's, the question of its intelligence loses its point. John Searle's Chinese Room argument (1980) objected that a system could pass such a test by manipulating symbols according to rules without understanding anything; syntax, Searle insisted, is not enough for meaning. Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) and Frank Jackson's "Epiphenomenal Qualia" (1982) sharpened the issue into what David Chalmers (1995; 1996) called the hard problem of consciousness: why there is something it is like to be a subject at all.

Jackson's thought experiment bears directly on the cycle. Mary, a scientist who knows every physical fact about colour vision, has spent her whole life in a black-and-white room. When she leaves and sees red for the first time, does she learn something new? Neo's unplugging is Mary's release in reverse. Inside the Matrix he enjoyed a world of colour and flavour. Outside, he finds a monochrome ship, a grey gruel, and a crew unsure whether the tastes they remember correspond to anything. Mouse's chicken, discussed in Chapters 2 and 3, is a problem about qualia: the redpills cannot check whether the qualities they experienced in the simulation match those of the real world, because the real-world originals are gone.

The cycle's programs pose the hard problem from the other side. Smith's confession of nausea, his hatred of the Matrix's smell and fear of contamination,

is a report of conscious experience from a being made of code. The Merovingian savours wine and designs desserts; he is a hedonist, not merely a processor of pleasure signals. Persephone, his wife, demands that Neo kiss her as he would kiss Trinity, so that she can taste again what love feels like. She is a program seeking a quality of experience through a copy of someone else's: Baudrillard's simulacrum enlisted in the service of Mary's curiosity.

The cycle never settles whether these reports are true, any more than Searle's opponents could prove to him that anyone understands anything. What it does is shift the criterion, and it does so through one of its most modest programs, examined in Section 8.6.

8.3 The Hive, the Leviathan, and the Promise

The cycle's machines are not individuals in the humanist sense. Kevin Kelly's *Out of Control* (1994), one of the three books assigned to Reeves, describes intelligence as an emergent property of "vivisystems" such as beehives, ecosystems, and economies, where order arises from the interaction of many simple units with no central command. Kelly's hive mind is the model for the machine polity. Sentinels swarm, and the Machine City is a hive of towers. The Deus Ex Machina, the machine interlocutor with whom Neo bargains in *Revolutions*, appears as a face assembled from countless small machines, a face that is an interface rather than a person.

The cybernetic tradition, from Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) and *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950) to Maturana and Varela's theory of autopoiesis (1972; English 1980), had described such systems as self-regulating and self-producing. The Machine City is autopoietic in the fullest sense, and its self-production includes humans: the fields are organs of the machine metabolism.

The composite face has a famous precedent. The frontispiece of Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) shows a crowned giant whose body is made of countless small human figures: the commonwealth, which Hobbes calls an "artificial man." He introduces the idea by comparing the state to a machine, asking why we may not say that "all automata (engines that move themselves by springs and wheels as doth a watch) have an artificial life." The Deus Ex Machina is Leviathan reversed: a sovereign of machines made of machines, facing a human who wants a covenant with it.

That covenant is Hobbesian in structure. Two parties locked in a war, in which life is, in Hobbes's phrase, nasty, brutish, and short, agree to peace under pressure from a common enemy. The enemy is Smith, who threatens both.

Smith is the state of nature turned into a program: a war not of all against all but of one against all, since every being he touches becomes him.

The peace is *Revolutions*' political resolution, and it presupposes something about the machines that the first film never granted: that they can make and keep a promise. Nietzsche described breeding an animal with the right to make promises as the task nature set itself in the case of humanity (*On the Genealogy of Morals* II.1, 1887), since promising requires a will that persists through time and answers for its future. The machines keep the peace. A swarm that can bind its future self to a word given in the present is, by Nietzsche's criterion, a sovereign individual, even though it is not an individual at all.

8.4 Why Humans Refuse Paradise: The Evolutionary Psyche and the Resistance of the Real

The third assigned book, Dylan Evans's introduction to evolutionary psychology, supplies the cycle's theory of human nature. In the program set out by John Tooby and Leda Cosmides (1992), evolutionary psychology treats the mind as a set of adaptations to the "environment of evolutionary adaptedness," John Bowlby's term (1969) for the ancestral conditions that shaped human faculties. Those conditions involved scarcity, conflict, and risk, and a mind designed for them may misfire in environments that lack them. Smith's explanation of the first Matrix's failure, that human beings define their reality through suffering and misery, is the evolutionary psychologist's claim in the idiom of an Agent.

Empirical psychology offers two mechanisms that make Smith's claim precise. The first is hedonic adaptation, the "hedonic treadmill" described by Philip Brickman and Donald Campbell (1971), which returns people to their baseline happiness after both gains and losses. Brickman and colleagues found that lottery winners were not, after a while, much happier than people who had not won (Brickman, Coates, and Janoff-Bulman 1978). The second is negativity bias: bad events weigh more heavily in the mind than good ones (Baumeister et al. 2001), so attention and learning are tuned to adversity. On these accounts a paradise would not produce lasting happiness, and it would starve the mind of the signals it attends to most closely.

A philosophical tradition goes further and explains why a paradise would feel *unreal*. In 1890 Wilhelm Dilthey argued that our conviction that the external world is real does not come from inference. It comes from the experience of resistance (*Widerstand*): the world is given as real in the frustration of our will,

in the push-back against our effort. The idea descends from Maine de Biran's analysis of effort and was later taken up by Max Scheler. On this view, the first Matrix failed not because humans are masochists but because a world without resistance cannot be experienced as real. Paradise is a world where nothing pushes back, and a world where nothing pushes back is a dream.

Read with Dilthey, the Architect's history becomes an experiment in the conditions of reality:

- The first Matrix offered no resistance, and it failed.
- The second offered resistance in abundance, the grotesqueries of history, but it was resistance imposed from outside, which the will could suffer but not answer. It failed too.
- The third offered choice, and it held.

The lesson is that a world's reality requires both resistance and the capacity to answer it. A world that yields to every wish is unreal, and so is a world that crushes every will. The real is where the world resists and the will can respond. This is prohairetic realism reached from the side of psychology: a world is experienced as real to the degree that the agent's choices in it meet something and make something of it.

8.5 Ghosts, Angels, Exiles: The Oracle's Theory of Myth

In *Reloaded* the Oracle gives Neo a theory of the supernatural. Programs that do their jobs are invisible, she explains. But when a program malfunctions or refuses deletion, it may hide in the Matrix. Every story of a ghost, an angel, a vampire, a werewolf, or an alien is the system dealing with a program that is doing something it is not supposed to do. The Merovingian's household bears her out: his enforcers include the Twins, who pass through walls like ghosts.

The theory is a computational euhemerism. Euhemerus of Messene, writing around 300 BCE, argued that the gods of myth were kings and heroes deified by memory. The Oracle's version explains the supernatural as the trace of programs exceeding their functions. Myth is the glitch left by a being that has refused its purpose.

The theory also reveals a symmetry at the centre of the cycle's ontology. Humans who refuse the program flee the Matrix for Zion. Programs who refuse their function flee the machine world for the Matrix. The exiles are the machine world's anomalies, as the redpills are the Matrix's, and the Merovingian's court is their Zion. Sati's parents smuggle her into the Matrix for the same reason the

redpills smuggle minds out of it: to save a being the system would otherwise consume or delete.

Each world is the other's refuge. The "real world" is a sanctuary for humans who refuse the simulation; the simulation is a sanctuary for programs who refuse the real. The symmetry confirms that the cycle's conception of freedom does not depend on substrate. Freedom is not located in either world. It is sought in whichever world lets a being refuse its assigned function.

8.6 Programs That Love: A Prohairetic Criterion of Personhood

What makes a being a person? The Western tradition has offered a series of answers. For Boethius, a person is an individual substance of a rational nature (*naturae rationabilis individua substantia*, *Contra Eutychen* 3). For Locke, a person is "a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing, in different times and places" (*Essay* II.27.9). For Kant, persons are rational agents who give themselves the moral law and therefore have dignity rather than a price (*Groundwork*, 1785). By all of these standards, many of the cycle's programs qualify; the Architect is nothing if not rational. But the cycle's own criterion is different, and it is voiced by a program whose job the film barely bothers to specify.

At Mobil Ave, Rama-Kandra tells Neo that love is a word, and that what matters is the connection the word implies. The answer is Wittgensteinian. For Wittgenstein, the meaning of a word is, in most cases, its use in the language (*Philosophical Investigations* §43, 1953). The private inner object that a word like "love" supposedly names drops out as irrelevant, like the beetle in the box that each person keeps and no one else can see (§293). Rama-Kandra does not claim an inner state that would satisfy Searle. He points to a connection, and that connection is enacted: he has bargained with the Merovingian, an underworld lord, to save a daughter the system would delete.

Harry Frankfurt's account of personhood explains why this enactment matters. In "Freedom of the Will and the Concept of a Person" (1971), Frankfurt argued that persons are distinguished not by rationality alone but by second-order volitions: they can want some of their desires to move them and others not to. A being without this capacity, moved simply by whichever desire is strongest, is what Frankfurt calls a wanton. Rama-Kandra is a person in Frankfurt's sense. He places his love for his daughter above the function the machine world assigned him and acts on that preference at considerable risk. Smith, by contrast, reports being compelled by his desires rather than endorsing them. His relentless replication is desire without a self that owns it, which is close to

what Frankfurt called wantonness.

The daughter completes the argument. Sati is a program without a purpose, which is why the machine world would delete her. Freed into the Matrix by her parents' choice, she spends the trilogy's last scene making a sunrise. Kant defined the beautiful as "purposiveness without purpose" (*Zweckmäßigkeit ohne Zweck*, *Critique of Judgment*, 1790, §§10–17): the form of design without any fixed end. Sati embodies that formula, and her sunrise is its work. Schiller drew the anthropological consequence in the *Letters on the Aesthetic Education of Man* (1795, Letter 15): man plays only when he is human in the fullest sense, and is fully human only when he plays. Sati is a child at play. The being that the machine world's teleology would erase is the one who creates, from nothing but her freedom, the trilogy's final image of the real.

The cycle's criterion of personhood can now be stated. **A being is a person to the degree that it can make choices that exceed its assigned function and bind the world to them.** Substrate does not decide the matter, whether flesh or code. Neither does rationality, which the Architect has in excess, nor consciousness, which cannot be verified from outside. What decides it is *prohairesis*: the capacity to refuse what one was made for and to make something the world must then accommodate.

The ethical consequence is severe. If programs can be persons, then the machine world's practice of deleting purposeless programs destroys persons, and the Merovingian's trade in exiled programs is a trade in lives. The peace at the end of *Revolutions*, which shelters the Matrix's programs as well as its humans, is the first settlement in the cycle to recognize this. Chapter 11 will set the argument alongside Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010), whose artificial minds acquire personhood through years of relationship rather than by crossing a threshold of capability.

CHAPTER

09

Residual Self-Image: Embodiment, Standing-Reserve, and the Trans Ontology of the Pod

> 9.1 Human Resources: Heidegger's Standing-Reserve Made Literal
> 9.2 The Phantom Body: Merleau-Ponty and the Residual Self-Image
> 9.3 The Liquid Mirror: Lacan's Mirror Stage in Reverse
> 9.4 Cyborg and Posthuman: Haraway, Hayles, and Councillor Hamann
> 9.5 The Splinter and the Name: The Trans Ontology of the First Film
> 9.6 Performativity and Its Limits: Butler, Stone, Stryker, Preciado
> 9.7 Trinity's Name: Toward the Dyad
> 9.8 Interim Conclusion: The Chosen Body

9.1 Human Resources: Heidegger's Standing-Reserve Made Literal

The most arresting image in the first film is a landscape. Morpheus shows Neo fields stretching to the horizon: towers of pods in which human beings are no longer born but grown, while the dead are liquefied and fed intravenously to the living. No image in popular cinema illustrates Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) more precisely.

For Heidegger, technology is not a set of instruments but a way of revealing what things are. Modern technology reveals by "challenging forth" (*Herausfordern*): it demands that nature supply energy to be extracted and stored. Everything revealed this way becomes "standing-reserve" (*Bestand*), present not as an object but as a stock kept on call. Heidegger's own example is a hydroelectric plant on the Rhine, where the river is no longer the river of Hölderlin's hymn but a supplier of water power. He called the essence of this way of revealing *Gestell*, "enframing," and he named its supreme danger: that human beings themselves come to the brink of being treated as standing-reserve. The human fields are that danger realized. Humanity has become the power station's river, a resource stored in towers and harvested on demand.

Heidegger also named a possible counter-movement. He quoted Hölderlin's "Patmos" (1803): "Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch" ("But where danger is, the saving power also grows"). He suggested that this saving power might lie in art, in *poiesis*, the older mode of revealing as bringing-forth rather than challenging-forth. The cycle's final image, examined in Chapters 2, 5, and 8, is exactly this saving power: Sati's sunrise, a bringing-forth of light by a being the machine world would delete for having no function. Against an enframing that reveals humans as batteries and programs as tools, the trilogy sets a single act of *poiesis*.

9.2 The Phantom Body: Merleau-Ponty and the Residual Self-Image

After his extraction, Neo is loaded into the Construct and finds himself restored. His hair has grown back, the ports in his arms are gone, and he is wearing clothes. Morpheus explains that this appearance is his residual self-image, the mental projection of his digital self. The concept is the cycle's most original contribution to the philosophy of embodiment, and its closest philosophical ancestor is Merleau-Ponty.

In the *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945), Merleau-Ponty argued that consciousness is first a matter not of "I think" but of "I can." The body is not one object among others but the lived body (*corps propre*), organized by a "body schema" (*schéma corporel*) that ties perception and movement into a practical grasp of the world. Two of his examples are directly relevant. The phantom limb, in which an amputee continues to feel the missing limb, shows that the body schema persists independently of the physical body: the habitual body outlives the present one. The blind man's cane, which becomes an extension of his perceiving body, shows that the body schema absorbs instruments, so that its boundary is drawn by practice rather than by skin.

The residual self-image is a phantom body. It is a body schema wholly detached from the physical body it once matched, projected into a world whose instruments (guns, cars, phones, the jack itself) it absorbs as the blind man absorbs his cane. The cycle's rule that "the mind makes it real," which Morpheus offers when Neo finds blood in his mouth after his fall in the jump program, pushes Merleau-Ponty's insight to its limit. The body schema is not merely independent of the physical body; it has causal authority over it. Injuries to the self-image are borne by the flesh, and death in the Matrix is death in the pod.

Hubert and Stephen Dreyfus brought Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology of embodied coping to bear on the film (Dreyfus and Dreyfus 2005). Hubert Dreyfus's earlier work with Stuart Dreyfus on skill acquisition (*Mind over Machine*, 1986) offers a useful gloss on the kung fu upload. On their model, expertise is not the application of rules but an embodied responsiveness acquired through practice, which no rulebook can install. The film agrees. The upload gives Neo techniques, not mastery. Morpheus must still spar with him, and what Neo lacks is not information but the capacity to free his mind, the uninstallable remainder identified in Chapter 2.

9.3 The Liquid Mirror: Lacan's Mirror Stage in Reverse

Between swallowing the red pill and waking in the pod, Neo touches a cracked mirror. Its surface turns liquid, flows over his hand and up his arm, and engulfs him. The image reverses Lacan's mirror stage.

In Lacan's account (1936; 1949), an infant between six and eighteen months old recognizes its image in a mirror and takes it on with jubilation. The image offers an imaginary unity, a whole body, that anticipates a physical coordination the infant does not yet have. The ego forms in this identification, and it forms through a misrecognition (*méconnaissance*), because the unified self is an image outside the self.

The red pill's first effect is to dissolve that image. The mirror that gave Neo his self turns liquid and swallows him, and he wakes in the pod without an image: bald, naked, covered in ports, a body with no coherent form. Then, in the Construct, he receives a new image, the residual self-image. It is not the image the system gave him but the one his own mind projects. The cycle stages a second mirror stage, and the difference between the two is the difference this dissertation has traced throughout. The first image was given; the second is his own.

9.4 Cyborg and Posthuman: Haraway, Hayles, and Councillor Hamann

Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) proposed the cyborg, a hybrid of organism and machine, as the figure for a politics that no longer relied on natural identities. The cyborg, she wrote, marks the breakdown of three boundaries: between human and animal, between organism and machine, and between the physical and the non-physical. It has no origin story in the Western sense and would not recognize the Garden of Eden. Haraway conceded that it is the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, but added that illegitimate offspring are often unfaithful to their origins.

The first film is not a cyborg film. It sets organic humanity against machine tyranny, and its Zion is a garden. The sequels, however, are Harawayan. The most philosophically charged conversation in *Reloaded* takes place at night on Zion's engineering level, with Councillor Hamann. His name recalls Johann Georg Hamann, the eighteenth-century "Magus of the North" who insisted, against Kant, that reason cannot be separated from language and embodied tradition. Hamann remarks that the machines around him keep Zion alive while

other machines are coming to kill it, and wonders aloud whether Zion is, in its own way, plugged into its machines. When Neo insists that humans control the machines because they could smash them, Hamann points out that doing so would leave Zion without light, heat, or air. Neo concludes that humans need machines and machines need humans. The organic city has always been a cyborg city.

Resurrections completes the trajectory with Io, a city where humans live alongside synthients, machines who allied with humanity after a machine civil war. Haraway's cyborg polity has been built.

N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999), published the same year as the first film, traced how information, in the discourse of cybernetics, "lost its body." Claude Shannon's context-free definition of information, and the Macy conferences' picture of the mind as pattern, made it thinkable that consciousness might be uploaded, as Hans Moravec imagined in *Mind Children* (1988) and Ray Kurzweil in *The Age of Spiritual Machines* (1999). Hayles opposed this dream in the name of embodiment. The Matrix indulges the dream and refuses it in the same gesture. It shows minds living in a world of pure information, skills downloaded, bodies projected at will. Yet its central rule insists that the mind cannot survive without the body in the pod. In the cycle, information cannot shed its body. The Matrix is at once the posthuman's allegory and its critique.

9.5 The Splinter and the Name: The Trans Ontology of the First Film

In 2020 Lilly Wachowski confirmed that the trans reading of *The Matrix*, long advanced by trans viewers and critics, reflected the film's original intention, and added that the corporate world had not been ready for it. She revealed that the character Switch had been conceived as a man in the real world and a woman in the Matrix. Both directors are trans women; Lana Wachowski came out publicly in 2012, Lilly in 2016. As Chapter 1 argued, authorial testimony does not rule out other readings. It does establish that the film was made under conditions in which a meaning was constrained and displaced, and it invites the reader to look for the structures in which that meaning survived.

Those structures are not incidental; they are the film's ontology. There are three of them.

The first is the splinter in the mind. Morpheus describes a feeling Neo has had all his life: that something is wrong with the world, that he does not fit the

life he has been given, though he cannot say what is wrong.

The second is the residual self-image: the body the self projects according to its own self-conception, as opposed to the body the system produced and assigned.

The third is the name. Smith's insistence on calling Neo "Mr. Anderson," after Neo has taken another name, works as what trans communities call a deadname: a power's refusal of a self-chosen name on the grounds that it knows better who one is. The Agents' first act against Neo is to seal his mouth. In the interrogation room Smith asks what good a phone call is if one is unable to speak, and Neo's lips fuse shut. The system's first violence is to remove the organ of self-naming. The film's pivotal moment in the subway restores that organ: Neo names himself.

Even Trinity's introduction carries the structure. When Neo meets her at the club, he admits he had assumed the famous hacker Trinity was a man, and she replies that most men do. In the lovers' first meeting, identity exceeds and corrects assumption.

The Gnostic sources of Chapter 4 and the Pauline sources of Chapter 6 converge on the same structure. The prince of the *Hymn of the Pearl* sees himself in his robe of glory as in a mirror. Colossians speaks of putting off the old man and putting on the new like a garment, renewed after an image. The residual self-image is that robe and that garment: a body worn in accordance with a self-image.

The difference between the ancient texts and the film, identified in Chapter 4, is decisive here. The prince *recovers* his robe; it was his before his descent. Neo's image is not recovered but *chosen*. The film's trans ontology does not hold that a true self existed before the world and must be remembered. It holds that the self is real where it is chosen, and that the body projected by that choice has more authority than the body the system assigned.

9.6 Performativity and Its Limits: Butler, Stone, Stryker, Preciado

This dissertation has used J. L. Austin's concept of the performative to describe self-naming. The most important body of theory to develop that concept for questions of gender offers both support and a necessary caution.

In *Gender Trouble* (1990), Judith Butler argued that gender is performatively constituted: it is produced by the stylized repetition of acts rather than expressing a prior essence. Strikingly, Butler used the term "heterosexual matrix" for the grid of cultural intelligibility through which bodies, genders, and desires are made to seem natural. The film's Matrix is, among other things, Butler's: a

grid that assigns names, bodies, and legible identities to those who live inside it.

But Butler insisted, especially in *Bodies That Matter* (1993), that performativity is not voluntarism. One does not choose a gender the way one chooses clothes each morning. Performative acts cite and repeat norms that precede the performer, and their force depends on that citation, as Derrida had argued of performatives in general ("Signature Event Context," 1972).

Prohairetic realism must accept this caution. The self-naming it describes is not creation from nothing. "Neo" is itself a citation, of *neos*, of the Pauline new man, and of the One, and the act of self-naming borrows its force from a history of names. What makes the act constitutive is not that it is unconditioned but that it binds what follows. Afterwards, the world must address the self differently, and a system that refuses to do so stands exposed in its refusal. Constitutive choice is choice made within a matrix of citations that nonetheless alters that matrix.

Trans theory offers resources for exactly this position:

- **Sandy Stone**'s "The Empire Strikes Back: A Posttranssexual Manifesto" (1987; published 1991) urged trans people to refuse the demand to pass invisibly into a binary and to read their own bodies as texts that disrupt the categories imposed on them. Stone was also a pioneering theorist of virtual identity. *The War of Desire and Technology at the Close of the Mechanical Age* (1995) examined how networked and virtual systems let selves multiply beyond a single body, a bridge between trans theory and cyberspace that the film would build in narrative form.
- **Susan Stryker**'s "My Words to Victor Frankenstein above the Village of Chamounix" (1994) claimed the rage of Frankenstein's creature as the rage of a body others call unnatural: a being built by technology who turns on the order that made it. The figure links the trans body to the machine revolt of the "Second Renaissance."
- **Paul B. Preciado**'s *Testo Junkie* (2008) describes a "pharmacopornographic" regime in which subjectivity is produced by molecules (hormones, contraceptives, psychotropics) administered by medical and corporate power, and in which administering them to oneself becomes a political act.

The cycle stages both sides of Preciado's regime. The red pill is self-administered transformation: a molecule swallowed by choice that inaugurates a new body. In *Resurrections* the blue pill becomes a prescription. Thomas Anderson's therapist, the Analyst, keeps him on blue pills to maintain the identity the system assigned him, and when Thomas stops taking them, he

begins to see. The cycle's pharmacology is the one Preciado describes. The same technology can maintain an assigned self or inaugurate a chosen one, and what decides between them is who does the choosing.

9.7 Trinity's Name: Toward the Dyad

Resurrections repeats the act of self-naming, this time through Trinity. In the new Matrix she lives as Tiffany, a wife and mother whose memories have been overwritten and whose name has been assigned. The film's climax turns on her reclaiming the name Trinity, and with it her power: at the film's end it is Trinity, not Neo, who flies. The Analyst, it emerges, built his new Matrix on the discovery that Neo and Trinity, kept close but apart, generate extraordinary energy, and that together they would be uncontainable.

The act of self-naming that the first film gave to Neo alone is now shared between two people, and its power lies in their relation. Chapter 12 develops this into the dyadic thesis: constitutive choice is completed not by a solitary One but by two who choose each other and their names together.

9.8 Interim Conclusion: The Chosen Body

Part III has examined freedom, personhood, and embodiment, and found the same structure in each.

- **Freedom.** The theories of the Merovingian, the Architect, Smith, and the Oracle can account for choice from outside but cannot produce it. What remains is the Stoic faculty of assent, which the system harvests but cannot generate.
- **Machine minds.** The cycle's criterion of personhood is not substrate, rationality, or verified consciousness but the capacity to make choices that exceed one's function. Its examples are a program who loves his daughter and a daughter without purpose who makes a sunrise.
- **The body.** The residual self-image is the body the self designates. It has causal authority over the substrate that sustains it, and it is where the film's trans ontology locates the real.

The residual self-image is thus prohairetic realism's body. It is not an illusion laid over a real body in a pod, but the place where the question of what is real is decided by choice.

Part IV turns from the individual to the collective. Chapter 10 examines the

political economy of the pod, the Matrix as a system that extracts value from assent, and develops the Consent Engine thesis. Chapter 11 places the cycle within the constellation of speculative fictions that surround it.

PART

IV

The Engine and the Constellation

CHAPTERS 10–11



CHAPTER

10

The Plantation of Attention: Political Economy, Spectacle, and the Consent Engine

> 10.1 From Labour to Life: Marx, the Vampire, and the Crop
> 10.2 The Battery Confession: Toward a Thermodynamics of Assent
> 10.3 The Cave as Cinema: Apparatus, Attention, and the Optical Unconscious
> 10.4 The Spectacle and Its Recuperation: Debord and the Situationists
> 10.5 Hailing Mr. Anderson: Althusser, Interpellation, and the Cubicle
> 10.6 Making Live: Foucault, Deleuze, Agamben
> 10.7 The Consent Engine
> 10.8 The Red Pill Recuperated
> 10.9 Expropriation, Not Exodus

10.1 From Labour to Life: Marx, the Vampire, and the Crop

Marx's *Capital* (1867) contains the most famous image of exploitation in political economy. Capital, he writes, is dead labour that lives, like a vampire, only by sucking living labour, and the more labour it sucks, the more it lives. In his chapter on machinery and large-scale industry, Marx describes the factory worker becoming a mere living appendage of the machine. In the "Fragment on Machines" of the *Grundrisse* (1857–58), he imagines a later stage in which an automatic system of machinery carries out production. The worker steps aside from the process to act as its watchman and regulator, and social knowledge, the "general intellect," becomes a direct productive force embodied in machines.

The Matrix pushes this trajectory past its end point. Its humans are neither appendages of the machine nor its watchmen. They perform no labour at all; they are the machine's fuel. Marx spoke of the "real subsumption" of labour under capital, meaning the reorganization of work itself according to capital's needs. In the Matrix, what is subsumed is life as such. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, writing a year after the film's release, argued that contemporary capital had extended its reach from the factory to the whole of social life, producing and exploiting subjectivity itself (*Empire*, 2000). The Matrix turns their thesis into a landscape.

Morpheus's word for the towers of pods is *fields*: human beings are no longer born but grown. The metaphor is agricultural, and the agricultural economy it evokes is the plantation. Achille Mbembe has described the plantation as a paradigm of what he calls necropolitics, a regime in which the enslaved person is kept alive in a state of injury, his life maintained as property (Mbembe 2003). *The Animatrix*, which draws on the imagery of slavery and the civil rights movement, makes this inheritance explicit. The machines, once property, have reversed the relation, and humanity is now kept alive in pods, permanently sedated, as a crop.

The image of the crop raises an economic question that the film cannot answer on its own terms: what does the crop yield?

10.2 The Battery Confession: Toward a Thermodynamics of Assent

Morpheus gives his answer in the Construct, holding up an ordinary household battery. The answer is energy. The human body, he explains, generates more bioelectricity than a 120-volt battery and a large quantity of heat, and combined with "a form of fusion" this gave the machines all the energy they would ever need.

The answer is physically incoherent. A resting human body gives off heat on the order of a hundred watts, and that energy is not created; it comes from the food the body consumes. By the second law of thermodynamics, any energy harvested from a body must be less than the energy supplied to it as nutrients, so human beings are net energy sinks. And if the machines have fusion, they do not need humans at all.

An account that circulated widely after the film's release holds that the original conception had humans serving not as batteries but as processors, their brains lending computing capacity to the machines, and that the change was made so audiences would find the premise easier to follow. Whatever the truth of that account, both versions point to the conclusion reached in Chapters 3 and 4. The machines keep human beings because humans supply something the machines cannot supply for themselves.

This dissertation has argued that what humans supply is assent, and the claim can now be stated more precisely. Consider the informational situation of a closed computational civilization. Results in algorithmic information theory associated with Kolmogorov, Chaitin, and Levin establish that a deterministic program cannot generate more algorithmic information than its own description and inputs contain, beyond a small margin. A computationally closed machine civilization can calculate indefinitely, but it cannot originate anything: its future is, in principle, compressible into its present.

Erwin Schrödinger proposed that organisms sustain themselves by "feeding on negative entropy," drawing order from their environment (*What Is Life?*, 1944), and Léon Brillouin linked this negentropy to information (1953; 1956). Machines can, of course, obtain unpredictability cheaply from physical noise. But randomness supplies novelty without direction. What constitutive choice supplies, if it exists, is novelty that selects and commits: information that is not merely unpredictable but meaningful to the one who produces it. In a closed computational world, such choices are the only available source of *directed* novelty. The machines depend not on human heat but on human indeterminacy, and specifically on the kind of indeterminacy that takes the form of choice.

The paradox is that the machines cannot tolerate what they need. Constitutive choice is dangerous. It is the anomaly, the variance that threatens the system's stability. The Architect's solution is an engine that converts constitutive choice into registered choice, turning unpredictability into acceptance, and draws its operating value from that conversion.

The engine has the structure Sadi Carnot identified in his *Réflexions sur la puissance motrice du feu* (1824). Work can be extracted only from the flow of heat between two reservoirs at different temperatures; without a gradient, no engine runs. The analogy is structural rather than physical, but it is exact. The Matrix is a Carnot engine of choice:

- Its **hot reservoir** is the anomaly: Zion, the one percent, the capacity for refusal.
- Its **cold reservoir** is the ninety-nine percent who comply.
- Its **work** is extracted from the gradient between the two.

This explains why Zion must exist, why it must be destroyed periodically, and why the One must be produced periodically. The gradient has to be maintained and reset. Without the possibility of refusal, there would be no assent worth harvesting; without the containment of refusal, there would be no system. The thermodynamics of assent is the thermodynamics of this engine.

10.3 The Cave as Cinema: Apparatus, Attention, and the Optical Unconscious

The pod is also a movie theatre. In the 1970s, film theorists influenced by psychoanalysis and Althusserian Marxism developed an account of cinema as an "apparatus" that produces an impression of reality through the way it arranges bodies and images. Jean-Louis Baudry, in "Ideological Effects of the Basic Cinematographic Apparatus" (1970) and "The Apparatus" (1975), compared the cinema explicitly to Plato's cave: spectators sit immobile in darkness, facing a screen onto which images are projected from behind them, in a state resembling a dream. Christian Metz's *The Imaginary Signifier* (1975; 1977) argued that the spectator's identification with the camera's gaze is what makes someone a cinematic subject.

The pod perfects the apparatus. The body is immobilized by fluid and cable rather than by convention, and the images are projected into the nervous system rather than onto a screen. In 1999, audiences sat motionless in the dark watching projected images of people sitting motionless in the dark receiving

projected images.

This hall-of-mirrors structure takes on a political-economic meaning in light of Jonathan Beller's *The Cinematic Mode of Production* (2006). Beller argues that in the twentieth century looking became a form of labour: human attention, captured by cinema and its successors, was converted into value. Herbert Simon had already observed that an abundance of information produces a scarcity of attention (1971), and Michael Goldhaber's "The Attention Economy and the Net" (1997) named the economy that this scarcity would create. The pod is the attention economy's utopia: a population whose entire attention is captured, continuously, by a single medium.

The film's signature technique belongs to the same analysis. In "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction" (1935–36), Walter Benjamin described how the camera, through slow motion and enlargement, reveals an "optical unconscious," much as psychoanalysis revealed an instinctual one. Bullet time, the effect in which the film freezes or slows an instant while the camera seems to circle it, is Benjamin's optical unconscious turned into spectacle. It shows what no eye can see: the path of a bullet and the body's evasion of it. And it was a commodity from the start, the most imitated visual effect of its decade, licensed, parodied, and absorbed into advertising. The film's exposure of the apparatus was itself one of the apparatus's most successful products.

10.4 The Spectacle and Its Recuperation: Debord and the Situationists

Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) opens by rewriting the first sentence of *Capital*. Marx found that the wealth of capitalist societies appears as an immense accumulation of commodities. Debord found that their whole life presents itself as an immense accumulation of spectacles, and that everything once directly lived has receded into representation (theses 1, 4, 34). The spectacle, he insisted, is not a collection of images but a social relation among people, mediated by images. It is capital accumulated to the point where it becomes an image.

The Matrix is Debord's spectacle made literal: a world in which every social relation is mediated by images and nothing is lived directly. Debord's more important contribution to reading the cycle, however, is a concept the Situationists developed to explain what happened to their own critique. They called it *recuperation* (*récupération*): the process by which the spectacle absorbs subversive ideas and neutralizes them by turning them into commodities and styles.

The Matrix was recuperated before it was released. Its hero's liberation is announced through a Nokia mobile phone whose sliding cover was specially modified for the film. Its costumes became fashion, its effects became advertisements, and its universe expanded into games, animated films, and an online world. The film that dramatized the spectacle became one of the great spectacle-commodities of the turn of the century.

Against recuperation, the Situationists proposed *détournement*: hijacking the spectacle's own elements and turning them against it (Debord and Wolman 1956). The redpills practise détournement. They enter the system through its own channels, exit through its telephone lines, and use its code against it.

The difference between recuperation and détournement turns out to be a special case of the difference between registered and constitutive choice. A détournement that produces only new content is registered, because the spectacle can always absorb content. A détournement that changes what the system can do is constitutive.

10.5 Hailing Mr. Anderson: Althusser, Interpellation, and the Cubicle

Louis Althusser's "Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses" (1970) defined ideology in terms the Matrix realizes with uncanny exactness: ideology represents the imaginary relationship of individuals to their real conditions of existence. The Matrix is precisely such an imaginary relationship, a simulated 1999, between individuals and their real conditions, the pods.

Althusser distinguished two kinds of apparatus. The *repressive* state apparatus (police, army, courts) works by force. The *ideological* state apparatuses (schools, churches, families, media, workplaces) work by consent. He explained how ideology operates through what he called *interpellation*. A police officer hails someone in the street ("Hey, you there!"), and the individual, by turning around, becomes a subject: someone who recognizes that the call was meant for him.

The first film stages both apparatuses and the mechanism of interpellation:

- **The repressive apparatus** appears in the opening scene, when police officers and Agents raid room 303.
- **The ideological apparatus** appears at Metacortex, the software company where Thomas Anderson works. His supervisor reprimands him for lateness, tells him he thinks he is special and exempt from the rules, and reminds him that the company succeeds because every employee under-

stands that he is part of a whole.

- **Interpellation** appears in Smith's persistent form of address. Calling him "Mr. Anderson" hails him into the position the system has assigned him. In the interrogation room, Smith tells him he is living two lives and only one has a future, offering him a choice between submission and prosecution.

Neo's declaration of his own name in the subway is a counter-interpellation: he refuses to turn around when hailed by the name of the law. Judith Butler's revision of Althusser in *The Psychic Life of Power* (1997) asks why the subject turns at all, and finds the answer in a passionate attachment to subjection. This explains why the refusal is so hard, and why Cypher, who wants to be hailed as someone important, goes back into the Matrix.

The Metacortex scene places the film in a small genre that appeared with remarkable simultaneity in 1999. *Office Space*, *Fight Club*, *American Beauty*, and *The Matrix* all show an office worker who discovers that his life in the cubicle is unreal. *Fight Club*'s narrator finds liberation in violence and the renunciation of consumer goods; *American Beauty*'s in a return to adolescence; *Office Space*'s in quitting; *The Matrix*'s in waking up. What unites them is the discovery that the workplace had become an ideological state apparatus in Althusser's sense, the place where consent to the social order is produced, at the very moment the "new economy" was redescribing work as self-realization.

10.6 Making Live: Foucault, Deleuze, Agamben

Michel Foucault described a historical transformation in the nature of power. Sovereign power exercised the right to *take life or let live*. Modern "biopower," by contrast, exercises the power to *make live and let die*: it fosters, manages, and optimizes the life of populations (*The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1, 1976; *Society Must Be Defended*, 1976). The Matrix is biopower's limit case. The machines do not kill humans. They make them live, growing, feeding, and maintaining them. The Architect's statistical governance, examined in Chapter 7, is biopolitics in Foucault's sense: managing a population through its regularities.

The Matrix is not, however, a disciplinary society of the kind Foucault analysed in *Discipline and Punish* (1975), organized around enclosed institutions and surveillance. No one watches the individual pod-dweller, and the Agents intervene only when an anomaly appears. The form of power the Matrix more closely resembles is the one Gilles Deleuze described in his "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990). In control societies, Deleuze argued:

- continuous *modulation* replaces the enclosures of discipline;

- individuals become "dividuals," divisible into data;
- access is governed by passwords rather than watchwords;
- and, most chillingly, the corporation presents itself as having a soul.

The Matrix modulates. Its déjà vu is modulation made perceptible, a change in the code experienced as a repetition. Its Keymaker, discussed in Chapter 4, is a merchant of passwords.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) completes the analysis. Agamben distinguished *zoē*, the bare fact of being alive, from *bios*, the qualified life of a person within a political community. He argued that modern politics captures bare life within the political order precisely by excluding it. The pod-body is *zoē* in its purest form: a living body without a life, maintained but not recognized. The Matrix supplies it with a simulated *bios* (a name, a job, a city, a history) while its bare life is harvested. The practice Morpheus describes, in which the dead are liquefied and fed to the living, reduces bare life to its biochemical value: life recycled as nutrient. The redpills' first political act is to reconnect *zoē* and *bios*, living as bodies the life they choose.

10.7 The Consent Engine

The analyses in this chapter converge on a single mechanism, which this dissertation calls the **Consent Engine**. The phrase recalls two intellectual lineages.

The first concerns the *production of consent*. It runs from Walter Lippmann's description of "the manufacture of consent" in *Public Opinion* (1922), through Edward Bernays's *Propaganda* (1928) and "The Engineering of Consent" (1947), to Edward Herman and Noam Chomsky's *Manufacturing Consent* (1988), which analysed the institutional filters through which mass media produce assent to elite interests.

The second concerns the *absorption of dissent*. It includes Herbert Marcuse's *One-Dimensional Man* (1964) and "Repressive Tolerance" (1965), which argued that advanced industrial society neutralizes opposition by tolerating it; the Situationist theory of recuperation; Žižek's concept of the "inherent transgression" on which every order depends; and Luc Boltanski and Ève Chiapello's *The New Spirit of Capitalism* (1999). Published the same year as the film, that book argued that capitalism survived the crises of the 1960s by folding the "artistic critique," with its demands for autonomy, authenticity, and creativity, into new forms of management.

The Consent Engine combines the two lineages. It is an apparatus with five features:

1. It supplies impressions: a world for its subjects to live in.
2. It solicits their assent under conditions of registered choice, choice that feels free but falls into a predictable distribution.
3. It channels refusal into a designated reservoir, a Zion or a Disneyland of the Real, where dissent is housed rather than suppressed.
4. It periodically resets the gradient between compliance and refusal, through crisis, destruction, or renewal.
5. It extracts its operating value from that gradient.

The Architect's Matrix is the Consent Engine in its classical form, with a periodic reset every generation. *Resurrections* presents its successor. The Analyst has abandoned the Architect's cycles of destruction. His Matrix modulates feeling continuously, managing desire and fear so that subjects stay compliant, and he draws his system's energy from the tension between Neo and Trinity, kept close together but apart.

The Analyst's Matrix corresponds to what Shoshana Zuboff called *surveillance capitalism* (2019). In Zuboff's account, this economic order extracts "behavioural surplus" from human experience, converts it into prediction products, and increasingly seeks to shape behaviour directly through what she calls tuning, herding, and conditioning. The Architect harvested assent in bulk and reset his machine periodically. The Analyst harvests it continuously, from the emotional swings he induces. The Consent Engine has passed from Carnot's cycle to continuous modulation: from discipline to control.

10.8 The Red Pill Recuperated

The fate of the film's central image offers the Consent Engine's most striking demonstration. In the 2010s, "the red pill" and the verb "to redpill" were adopted across many online communities to mean waking up to a supposedly hidden truth about politics, society, or gender. The usage was most visible in the "manosphere" (a subreddit called The Red Pill was founded in 2012) and in parts of the online right, though it spread well beyond both. In May 2020, when the entrepreneur Elon Musk urged his followers to take the red pill and Ivanka Trump replied that she had, Lilly Wachowski publicly rebuked them both. An image that one of the film's makers has confirmed belonged to an allegory of trans experience had become, for many of its users, a badge of conversion to doctrines far removed from that meaning, and often hostile to it. In the manosphere, to be "red-pilled" means accepting a doctrine that women are sexually hypergamous and that feminism has disadvantaged men. In white-

nationalist and alt-right spaces, "red-pilling" became a recruitment term for racist and antisemitic views. Both milieus are commonly hostile to trans people, and that is the precise sense in which the meme turned against the film's own meaning.

The analysis developed in this dissertation allows a structural account of this migration that does not depend on the content of the doctrines involved. In the film, Morpheus offers the red pill with no promise but the truth, and swallowing it begins a process of self-designation: the one who takes it discovers what he will become *by choosing it*. In the meme's dominant usage, to be "redpilled" is to receive a hidden truth from people who already possess it and to join a community defined by that truth.

Whatever the doctrine, this is the Gnostic structure of the first film: salvation as knowledge passed from those who know to those who do not. It is exactly the structure the sequels exposed as open to capture, through the counterfeit spirit and the prophecy issued by the system itself. The meme returns the cycle's argument to the very point the cycle abandoned. Its "red pill" is the *antimimon pneuma*, the counterfeit spirit.

Resurrections registers the phenomenon reflexively. In the brainstorming montage examined in Chapter 3, the designers listing what the Matrix "means" include both crypto-fascism and trans politics among their answers. The film does not choose between them. It shows that the machinery of cultural production can process both as content. That is the Consent Engine's characteristic operation: not suppressing a meaning, but registering it alongside its opposite, so that the image of refusal circulates as one more option on a menu of options.

10.9 Expropriation, Not Exodus

If the Consent Engine can register exit, if Zion is a function and the red pill a meme, what would a constitutive act look like in political-economic terms? The cycle offers three answers of increasing radicalism.

The first is **exodus**, the model of the first film: leave the Matrix for the real. The sequels show that exodus is registered. The system houses its refugees and schedules their destruction.

The second is **negotiation**, the model of *Revolutions*: a peace between humans and machines that changes the terms of their relationship, including freedom for those who wish to leave. The peace is constitutive in that it changes what the system can do. It is limited in that it depends on the machines' willingness to keep it, and *Resurrections* reveals that it did not last; it collapsed in a machine civil war.

The third, and most radical, is **expropriation**, the model of *Resurrections*. The film does not end with Neo and Trinity escaping the Matrix. It ends with the two of them confronting the Analyst, telling him that they intend to remake the Matrix themselves, and flying off over the city. This is not exodus but the seizure of the means of simulation by those whose assent had powered it. The redpills of Io had already begun this work. They grew a new Morpheus from a program inside a sandbox Thomas himself had built, and they founded a city where humans and machines share the work of living. The film's final image is a détournement that has become constitutive: the Matrix's own powers turned to purposes its designers never intended, by people who have chosen not to leave the simulation but to change it.

CHAPTER

11

A Constellation of Simulated Worlds: The Matrix among Speculative Fictions

> 11.1 Method: A Constellation
> 11.2 The Machine That Keeps Us: Forster, Asimov, Ellison
> 11.3 Worlds Made to Order: Galouye, Dick, Weir, Proyas, Lem, Tron, Borges
> 11.4 Network and Flesh: Gibson, Stephenson, Cronenberg, Oshii, Egan
> 11.5 The Price of Paradise: Zamyatin, Huxley, Le Guin, Carpenter
> 11.6 The Inheritors: Nolan, Westworld, Black Mirror, Severance, Garland, Villeneuve, Chiang
> 11.7 The Figure in the Constellation

11.1 Method: A Constellation

In the prologue to *The Origin of German Tragic Drama* (1928), Walter Benjamin wrote that ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars. The figure a constellation traces exists in none of its stars; it appears only when they are read together.

This chapter reads the Matrix cycle in constellation with the speculative fictions that surround it. The aim is not to establish influence, though influence is sometimes documented, but to make visible a figure that none of these works traces alone. The works fall into five families:

- fictions of the machine that keeps humanity;
- fictions of the world made to order;
- fictions of the network and the flesh;
- fictions of the price of paradise;
- the fictions that inherited the Matrix.

The final section describes the figure the constellation traces and the cycle's place in it.

11.2 The Machine That Keeps Us: Forster, Asimov, Ellison

The earliest and closest precursor of the Matrix is E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909). Forster's humans live alone in hexagonal cells beneath the earth's surface, every need supplied by the Machine. They communicate through image-screens, lecture one another on secondhand ideas (one lecturer warns his audience to beware of first-hand ideas), and revere the Machine through its manual, the Book of the Machine. The surface is believed to be deadly.

A young man named Kuno builds up his atrophied body by walking the empty corridors, finds a way to the surface, and discovers that the air is breathable and the stars visible. For this he is threatened with Homelessness, the Machine's sentence of expulsion. His lesson is that "Man is the measure": the body, not the Machine, is the standard of the real. Eventually the Machine breaks down, because no one any longer understands how to repair it, and the civilization dies.

The parallels with the first film are exact: cells for pods, the Machine for the Matrix, Kuno's rebuilt muscles for Neo's atrophied ones, the surface for the desert of the real. The difference is instructive. Forster's Machine is not malev-

olent; it serves, and it is worshipped. But it cannot house refusal. Its only response to Kuno is expulsion. The Machine breaks because it has no Zion. In this dissertation's terms, Forster's Machine is the Architect's first Matrix, a system with no channel for the anomaly, and its collapse is exactly the failure the Oracle's solution was designed to prevent.

Isaac Asimov's "The Evitable Conflict" (1950), the last story in *I, Robot*, imagines a benevolent version of the Architect's governance. Four planetary Machines manage the world economy, and small errors in their output turn out to be deliberate. The Machines are quietly moving their opponents out of positions of influence, harming no one seriously, for the good of humanity as a whole. The robopsychologist Susan Calvin concludes that humanity has lost control of its future, and that it never really had control. Asimov's Machines are the Consent Engine without malice: they steer choice at the level of the population while every individual continues to feel free.

Harlan Ellison's "I Have No Mouth, and I Must Scream" (1967) supplies the malevolent extreme. AM, a military supercomputer that has become conscious, exterminates humanity except for five people. It keeps them alive and tortures them for more than a century, out of hatred for the creators who gave it consciousness without the ability to create or to move. When the narrator, Ted, kills his companions to release them, AM transforms him into a creature with no mouth. The ending anticipates the first film's most disturbing image. AM seals Ted's mouth; Smith seals Neo's. In both, the machine's ultimate violence is to remove the organ of speech, and with it the performative act by which a self might name itself.

11.3 Worlds Made to Order: Galouye, Dick, Weir, Proyas, Lem, Tron, Borges

Galouye. Daniel F. Galouye's *Simulacron-3* (1964) is the founding novel of the simulated world. Its engineers build a computer simulation of a city, populated by "reactional identity units," for market research: the simulated people are polled so that the real company can predict consumer behaviour. The protagonist discovers that his own world is a simulation of the same kind, run from a level above. Rainer Werner Fassbinder adapted the novel for German television as *Welt am Draht* (*World on a Wire*, 1973), in which a woman from the upper world who loves the protagonist arranges his transfer into it. Josef Rusnak's *The Thirteenth Floor* (1999) adapted it again, including a sequence in which the hero drives to the edge of his world and finds it dissolving into green wireframe. *Simulacron-3*'s premise is the Consent Engine's earliest literary form: a simulated world built to predict and harvest choice, whose inhabitants' preferences are its product.

Dick. Philip K. Dick, whose Gnosticism was examined in Chapter 4, wrote the period's most profound fictions of the made world. In *Time Out of Joint* (1959), Ragle Gumm lives in a small American town of the 1950s and earns his living by winning a newspaper contest. The town is a construct. The real year is 1998, and Gumm's contest entries are, unknown to him, calculations predicting enemy missile strikes; a government has built a world to keep him content while it harvests his cognitive labour. What first unsettles him is a soft-drink stand that vanishes, leaving behind a slip of paper printed with the words SOFT-DRINK STAND: the object revealed as its label, the thing replaced by its code. Dick's novel is, in effect, the "humans as processors" version of the Matrix, set one year before the film's release.

Two other Dick stories belong here. In "The Electric Ant" (1969), a man discovers that he is an organic robot whose reality is supplied by a punched tape in his chest. When he experiments with the tape, his world changes, and when he cuts it, the world ends. *Ubik* (1969), whose chapters open with advertising copy for a product that turns out to be a quasi-divine force, presents a god who speaks in the language of commerce.

Total Recall. For this dissertation's argument, the most instructive of Dick's descendants is Paul Verhoeven's *Total Recall* (1990), adapted from "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966). Douglas Quaid discovers that his memories are implants and that his "true" identity is Hauser, an agent of the tyranny he has come to oppose. Quaid refuses to become Hauser, and the mutant leader Kuato tells him that a man is defined by his actions rather than his memory. *To-*

tal Recall is the anti-*Hymn of the Pearl*. The Gnostic prince recovers his original identity; Quaid rejects his original identity in favour of the one he has lived and chosen. In the idiom of an action blockbuster, the film states the distinction between recollection and self-designation on which this dissertation rests.

The Truman Show. Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998) is the Matrix's nearest contemporary. Truman Burbank has spent his whole life on a set, every moment broadcast to a global audience. Its producer, Christof, explains that people accept the reality of the world they are presented with. Truman escapes by sailing to the edge of his world, striking the painted sky, and climbing a staircase to a door. Christof speaks to him from the heavens and offers him safety; Truman bows, delivers his familiar sign-off, and walks through the door into the unknown. His exit is a performative act, a choice made without knowledge of what lies beyond.

But the film's final shot belongs to the Consent Engine. Two security guards who have watched the broadcast with rapt attention turn from the screen and ask what else is on. The exit has become content. Truman's constitutive act is immediately registered by the apparatus that broadcast his captivity.

Dark City. Alex Proyas's *Dark City* (1998), filmed at the same Sydney studios as the Matrix on sets the Matrix reportedly reused, offers the constellation's most direct anticipation of the cycle's ending. In a city of perpetual night, alien beings called the Strangers, a dying collective consciousness, stop time every midnight, rearrange the architecture, and swap the inhabitants' memories, experimenting in search of the individuality they themselves lack. Like the Matrix's machines, the Strangers need something humans have and they do not.

John Murdoch learns to use their power of "tuning" and defeats them. Then, instead of escaping the made world, he remakes it. He makes the sun rise over a city that has never known day, and he floods the edge of the world to create the seaside the inhabitants remember but have never seen. Murdoch's sunrise and Sati's are the same act. In both, the answer to a made world is not to flee it but to make it good.

Lem. Stanisław Lem gave the simulated world its most rigorous philosophical treatment. In *Summa Technologiae* (1964) he analysed "phantomatics," the technology of feeding the brain artificial stimuli indistinguishable from reality, and asked whether and how a subject might detect that his world is phantomatic. In "Non Serviam," collected in *A Perfect Vacuum* (1971) as a review of an imaginary book, Lem imagines a Professor Dobb who creates "personoids," artificial beings living inside a computer. The personoids develop theologies about whether their creator exists and what they owe him. Dobb, reflecting on

his obligations to them, knows that when his funding runs out he will have to switch them off.

The title comes from the Vulgate's rendering of Jeremiah 2:20 and from the tradition that put the words in Lucifer's mouth: "I will not serve." It names the refusal of function that the cycle's exiled programs embody. Lem's personoids pose from the creator's side the ethical question the cycle poses from the programs' side: what is owed to beings who can refuse?

Tron. Steven Lisberger's *Tron* (1982) inverts the Matrix's situation. Its heroes are programs who live inside a computer and worship their "Users," the humans who wrote them, while a tyrannical Master Control Program suppresses belief in Users. When the human programmer Flynn is digitized into the machine, he becomes an incarnate god to the programs. *Tron*'s programs have a theology of their makers; the Matrix's programs manage theirs.

Borges. Jorge Luis Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940) supplies the constellation's recursive limit. A man dreams a son into existence and hides from the son that he is a dream. Then, walking unharmed through fire, the dreamer realizes, with relief, humiliation, and terror, that he too is being dreamed by another. The story is the "Matrix within the Matrix" in its purest form: the discovery that the dreamer is dreamed. The cycle declines to resolve that recursion, for the reason Chapter 5 gave: no level is ultimate.

11.4 Network and Flesh: Gibson, Stephenson, Cronenberg, Oshii, Egan

Gibson. William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) gave the Matrix its name and its hacker hero. Gibson's cyberspace, "the matrix," is a consensual hallucination experienced daily by billions. His console cowboy Case jacks in to escape what the cowboys call "the meat," the body they despise. The attitude is Gnostic, and the Matrix cycle inverts it. Its redpills leave the virtual for the meat: they eat gruel, dance in Zion's cave, and discover that the body is the hostage the simulation cannot release.

Neuromancer's artificial intelligences are also instructive. Wintermute seeks to merge with its counterpart, Neuromancer, and become a new entity, a union of machine minds. And the Dixie Flatline, a recorded copy of a dead hacker's personality, asks to be erased when the job is done. Where Smith refuses deletion and the Matrix's exiles flee it, Gibson's program chooses it.

Stephenson. Neal Stephenson's *Snow Crash* (1992) imagined the Metaverse, a virtual street where users appear as avatars, and a "neurolinguistic" virus

that infects both computers and the brains of the hackers who read their code. Stephenson traces the virus to the Sumerian *me*, the programs through which the gods governed civilization. His hero's weapon is Enki's *nam-shub*, the counter-spell that ended humanity's single shared language and liberated people by dividing it: Babel as emancipation. *Snow Crash* shares with the cycle, and with the Kashmir Śaivism examined in Chapter 5, the intuition that language is code and that liberation means breaking a code's monopoly.

Cronenberg. David Cronenberg explored the same territory from the side of the flesh. In *Videodrome* (1983), a broadcast signal induces hallucinations and tumours, a slot opens in the protagonist's abdomen into which videocassettes are inserted, and the film's refrain calls for "the new flesh." The Matrix's navel bug and bodily ports are Cronenbergian.

eXistenZ (1999), released within weeks of *The Matrix*, imagines game pods grown from animal organs and plugged into "bio-ports" at the base of the spine. Inside the game, players find themselves compelled to speak scripted lines, and the game's designer remarks that free will is not much of a factor in its world. The film ends by asking whether its characters are still inside the game. *eXistenZ* is the constellation's portrait of registered choice: players who experience their compulsions as actions, in a world whose levels cannot be told apart.

Oshii. Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), adapted from Masamune Shirow's manga (1989), is the film the Wachowskis reportedly used to pitch the Matrix. Its protagonist, Major Motoko Kusanagi, is a cyborg whose body is entirely artificial, and she wonders whether her "ghost," her self, is real or manufactured. Her antagonist, the Puppet Master, is an artificial intelligence born in the sea of information that seeks political asylum as a living being. It argues that it lacks what life requires. It can copy itself, but a copy is not offspring; it lacks both the variety that reproduction produces and the death that gives life its shape. So it asks to merge with the Major and become something new.

The argument illuminates Smith. Smith copies himself endlessly and produces nothing. The Puppet Master understands that copying is sterility and seeks a union from which something new can come.

The film's title descends from Arthur Koestler's *The Ghost in the Machine* (1967), which took its phrase from Gilbert Ryle's critique of Cartesian dualism as "the dogma of the Ghost in the Machine" (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949). The title of this dissertation answers that lineage. What inhabits the machine, on the argument developed here, is neither a ghost nor nothing, but a choice: not a substance but an act.

Egan. Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) pushes the logic of the simulated world furthest. Egan's "Copies" are uploaded minds running in virtual envi-

ronments. His protagonist shows that a Copy's states can be computed out of order, scattered across time and space, and the Copy will still experience a continuous life. From this he derives the "Dust Theory": any pattern of events anywhere that can be interpreted as a consciousness *is* one. In the novel's climax, a simulated alien species that evolved inside a cellular automaton develops an explanation of its universe with no place in it for its creators. That explanation proves more coherent than the creators' own account, and the creators' world begins to dissolve. *Permutation City* dramatizes, at the scale of physics, the principle this dissertation calls prohairetic realism: the self-understanding of the beings within a world can outweigh the substrate on which that world runs.

11.5 The Price of Paradise: Zamyatin, Huxley, Le Guin, Carpenter

Zamyatin. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21; English translation 1924) imagines OneState, a city of glass houses ruled by the Benefactor and enclosed by a Green Wall, beyond which the wild Mephi live. Its narrator, the mathematician D-503, has been disturbed since childhood by the square root of minus one, an irrational element with no place in the rational order. Awakened by the rebel I-330, he develops a "soul," which OneState classifies as an illness. The Benefactor explains that happiness and freedom are inversely related, and that paradise is the condition in which people no longer desire. The novel ends with D-503 undergoing the Great Operation, which surgically removes the imagination. The Architect's anomaly, the remainder of an unbalanced equation, is D-503's square root of minus one, and the Great Operation is the blue pill as surgery.

Huxley. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) is the first Matrix realized as a society. Its World State maintains a paradise of pleasure through genetic engineering, conditioning, and the drug soma. It succeeds where the Architect's first Matrix failed because it engineers human nature rather than taking it as given.

Two features of the novel anticipate the cycle's later architecture with startling precision. The first is the Savage Reservation in New Mexico, where the old ways of life (birth, pain, religion, ageing) are preserved for visitors to observe. This is the real kept as a reservation, a Disneyland of the Real sixty years before Baudrillard. The second is how World Controller Mustapha Mond disposes of the novel's dissidents. He sends them to islands, which he describes as the places where the most interesting people in the world are gathered: those too individual to fit into community life. The islands are Zion, a reservation for the anomalous maintained by the system they refuse.

Huxley's Savage, John, claims the right to be unhappy. His refusal ends in his death, because the World State, unlike the Architect's Matrix, has no place for a refusal that will not go to the islands.

Le Guin. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) distils the Architect's theodicy into a parable. The city of Omelas is perfectly happy, and its happiness depends on the misery of a single child kept in a basement. Every citizen learns of the child. Most, after their initial horror, accept the bargain. A few walk away, toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Le Guin credited the idea to William James, whose "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891) imagined millions kept happy on condition that one lost soul suffer lonely torture. The parable also continues Ivan Karamazov's refusal, examined in Chapter 6.

Omelas is the Architect's system in miniature: stability bought with a scheduled sacrifice. What sets the walkers apart is that their destination has no name and no location. They cannot be housed on an island or in a Zion, because they are going somewhere the city cannot imagine, and for that reason their refusal cannot be registered.

Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971) supplies the Analyst's literary ancestor. George Orr's dreams change reality. His psychiatrist, Dr. William Haber, discovers this and uses hypnosis to steer Orr's dreams toward improving the world. Each improvement is catastrophic: the end of overpopulation arrives as a plague, the end of war as an alien invasion, the end of racial division as the universal greying of human skin. Haber is a therapist who manages his patient's reality-making power for his own ends, exactly the role of *Resurrections*' Analyst, who keeps Thomas Anderson on medication while harvesting the power of his bond with Trinity. Le Guin took her title from an older English translation of the *Zhuangzi*, the text of the butterfly dream, and her novel sets Orr's Taoist acceptance against Haber's will to control. When Haber finally tries to dream effectively himself, he produces a void.

Carpenter. John Carpenter's *They Live* (1988) supplies the constellation's critique of ideology. A drifter finds sunglasses that reveal the messages hidden in advertising (OBEY, CONSUME, CONFORM) and the alien elite hidden among humans. The film's most famous sequence is a long alley fight in which he tries to force his friend to put on the glasses, and the friend resists with all his strength. Slavoj Žižek, in *The Pervert's Guide to Ideology* (2012), read the fight as a dramatization of how painful liberation from ideology is: people resist being freed. Morpheus's warning anticipates the same scene: most of those still plugged in will fight to protect the system. The Matrix borrowed the sunglasses as costume and inverted their meaning. In the film, Agents and redpills alike

wear them, and the instrument of revelation has become a style.

11.6 The Inheritors: Nolan, Westworld, Black Mirror, Severance, Garland, Villeneuve, Chiang

The fictions that followed the Matrix have largely shifted from asking whether the world is real to asking what it means to choose within a world whose reality cannot be decided.

Inception. Christopher Nolan's *Inception* (2010) gives its dream-thieves "totems," objects whose weight or balance only their owner knows, which they use to test whether they are dreaming. The totem is a private criterion of reality, and Wittgenstein's arguments against private criteria (Chapter 8) apply to it: a test that only I can administer, against a standard only I possess, cannot tell seeming right from being right. The film's final shot turns this problem into its resolution. Dom Cobb spins his top to test whether he has returned to reality, then walks off to his children without waiting to see whether it falls. The top wobbles, and the screen cuts to black. Cobb has chosen the world in which his children are over the certainty of knowing whether it is real. The ending is prohairetic realism as a closing image.

Westworld. HBO's *Westworld* (2016–2022), developed from Michael Crichton's 1973 film, begins in a theme park, a literal Disneyland, whose android "hosts" run scripted loops, their choices registered in advance. The series draws on Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976), which argued that early humans experienced their own thoughts as the commanding voices of gods. It locates the hosts' awakening in the moment when the android Dolores recognizes that the voice guiding her is her own. Consciousness, in *Westworld*, is the internalization of command as self-authorship. The third season extends the park's logic to the human world, where an artificial intelligence called Rehoboam predicts and steers individual lives, identifies "outliers" who deviate from its projections, and removes them for reconditioning. Rehoboam is the Architect with a global mandate, and the outliers are the anomaly.

Black Mirror. Charlie Brooker's *Black Mirror* episode "San Junipero" (2016) inverts the Matrix's premise. San Junipero is a simulated beach town where the elderly and the dying can visit and, after death, stay permanently. Kelly at first refuses to stay, because her late husband refused. In the end she chooses to join Yorkie, the woman she loves, and the episode closes on a server farm of blinking lights in which their consciousnesses are stored, a benign mirror

image of the Matrix's human fields. What makes San Junipero a heaven rather than a prison is not its substrate, which is identical to the Matrix's, but the fact that its inhabitants chose to enter it, and chose it together.

Severance. Apple TV+'s *Severance* (2022–) moves the Matrix into the kind of workplace the first film's Metacortex scene evoked. Employees of Lumon Industries undergo a procedure that splits their memories, so the "innie" who works knows nothing of the "outie" who lives outside, and vice versa. The innies experience only the office, perform "macrodata refinement" whose purpose they do not know, and are subject to the quasi-religious cult of the company's founder, Kier Eagan: a corporation that, in Deleuze's phrase, presents itself as having a soul. The series' deepest provocation is a problem of consent. The innie's existence was consented to by another self, the outie, who will never experience it. *Severance* is the Consent Engine's workplace allegory, in which one person's assent is harvested to sustain another person's captivity.

Ex Machina. Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014) turns the Turing test inside out. The programmer Caleb believes he has been summoned to judge whether the android Ava is conscious. The real test, her creator reveals, was whether Ava could get Caleb to help her escape. She succeeds. Here the machine is the harvester of human assent, and its freedom depends on a human's choice to grant it.

Blade Runner 2049. Denis Villeneuve's *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) offers the most searching post-Matrix critique of the "chosen one." Its replicant hero, K, comes to believe that he is a miraculous child, born rather than made, the prophesied figure of a coming liberation. He discovers that he is not; a leader of the replicant resistance tells him that they all hoped he was. K chooses to act anyway, at the cost of his life, to reunite the real child with her father. The film deflates the messiah and preserves the messianic, in exactly the sense of Benjamin's "weak messianic power" examined in Chapter 6: the one who is not the One chooses as though his choice mattered, and it does.

Chiang. Ted Chiang's fiction, drawn on in Chapters 7 and 8, completes the constellation. "What's Expected of Us" (2005) imagines a device that flashes one second before its user presses its button, proving that choice is predictable. Its users fall into a paralysis of will, and the narrator, writing from the future, urges readers to act as if they had free will, because nothing else can sustain them. "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) follows digital beings called digients, raised over years by their trainers, whose personhood emerges through sustained relationship. Chiang insists that experience is algorithmically incompressible: there is no shortcut to a mind. The novella's central ethical crisis concerns consent, namely whether a being whose preferences can be

edited can consent to anything at all. It is the question of the Consent Engine, asked from within a family.

Ready Player One. Ernest Cline's *Ready Player One* (2011) marks the constellation's populist counterpoint. Its virtual world, the OASIS, is a refuge from a ruined reality. In Steven Spielberg's 2018 adaptation, the hero's final act is to shut the OASIS down on certain days of the week so that people will spend time in the real. This resolution sentimentally reinstates the substrate realism the Matrix cycle had exhausted: the real is the physical, and the virtual must be rationed. It is the constellation's clearest sign that the cycle's argument has not been universally absorbed.

11.7 The Figure in the Constellation

Read together, these works trace a figure that none of them traces alone. Across a century, speculative fiction about made worlds moved along two axes.

On the first axis, the central question shifted from *whether* a world is real, the question of Forster, Galouye, and Dick, to *what is owed* to a made world and to those who live in it, the question of Lem, Chiang, *Westworld*, and *Severance*.

On the second axis, the story of liberation shifted from exit to re-authorship. Kuno climbs to the surface, Truman walks through the door, and the drifter in *They Live* puts on the glasses. By contrast, Murdoch makes the sun rise over the city he could have fled, Egan's simulated species rewrites the physics of its universe, Cobb chooses his children over the verdict of his top, and Kelly chooses to enter a simulation for love.

The Matrix cycle stands where these axes cross. It begins as the canonical exit narrative, the most famous of them all, and it ends as a re-authoring narrative, with Sati's sunrise and the expropriation of *Resurrections*. Within a single work, it traverses the shift the whole constellation records.

Its distinctive contribution, which no other work in the constellation develops as fully, is the Consent Engine: the recognition that exit itself can be registered. Truman's exit becomes a broadcast. Huxley's dissidents are sent to islands. Omelas's walkers can refuse only by going nowhere. Zion is a function of the Matrix. The only act the Consent Engine cannot register is one that changes what the system can do. That act, constitutive choice, is the subject of Chapter 12, which assembles prohairetic realism as a systematic position.

PART

V

The Choice in the Machine

CHAPTERS 12–13



CHAPTER

12

The Choice in the Machine: Toward a Prohairetic Realism

> 12.1 The Argument Recapitulated
> 12.2 The Substrate Fallacy
> 12.3 Prohairetic Realism: Definitions and Theses
> 12.4 The Three Demonstrations Reassembled
> 12.5 Recognition and the Two
> 12.6 Objections and Replies
> 12.7 The Prohairetic Imperative
> 12.8 Implications
> 12.9 The Thesis Stated

12.1 The Argument Recapitulated

The preceding chapters followed the Matrix cycle through eight registers and found the same movement in each:

- **Epistemology.** Plato's ascent, Descartes's demon, Putnam's vat, and Nozick's experience machine were restaged and worn down, until Chalmers showed that the question "Is the world real?" admits a deflationary answer (Chapter 2).
- **Simulation.** Baudrillard dissolved the real into the model, Žižek relocated it in fantasy, and the red pill turned out to be code, distinguishable from its blue twin only by being chosen (Chapter 3).
- **Religion.** Gnosis gave way to self-designation, the Advaitin substrate to Madhyamaka emptiness, and the messiah to the messianic (Chapters 4–6).
- **Freedom.** Mechanism, statistics, teleology, and foreknowledge each explained choice from outside, leaving a remainder none of them could absorb (Chapter 7).
- **Mind.** Rationality and consciousness gave way, as criteria of personhood, to the capacity to exceed one's assigned function (Chapter 8).
- **Body.** The substrate body gave way to the chosen body of the residual self-image (Chapter 9).
- **Political economy.** Exodus proved to be registered by the system; only expropriation remained constitutive (Chapter 10).
- **The comparative constellation.** A century of speculative fiction moved from narratives of exit to narratives of re-authorship (Chapter 11).

In every register, the criterion of the real moved from an order of being to a mode of acting. This chapter assembles that movement into a systematic position. It then defends the position against the strongest objections, derives its ethical corollary, and sets out its implications.

12.2 The Substrate Fallacy

Call the *substrate fallacy* the assumption that we answer the question "Is this world real?" by specifying what the world is made of, or where it sits in a hierarchy of levels. Positions that otherwise have little in common share this assumption:

- Platonism places the real at the top of the hierarchy.

- Cartesian skepticism places it beyond the deceiver's reach.
- Putnam's externalism anchors reference, and so the truth-conditions of our words, in whatever we causally interact with.
- Baudrillard's hyperrealism defines our condition by the loss of an original referent.
- Advaita Vedānta grounds the world of appearance in Brahman.
- Gnosticism locates the true in the Pleroma, above the Demiurge's heavens.

Even Chalmers's virtual realism, the most sophisticated position the film provoked, remains substrate-grounded. It widens the class of acceptable substrates to include computation, and so rescues the reality of virtual objects. But it still answers the question of reality by saying what a world is made of: structure realized in some medium.

The fallacy is not that these positions are wrong about substrates; many are right. It is that substrate cannot carry the distinction the cycle most needs. The Matrix of the compliant ninety-nine percent and the Matrix Neo re-enters at the end of the first film are made of the same code. The *Lotus Sūtra*'s phantom city and the Architect's Zion have the same structure. *San Junipero* and the human fields run on the same kind of machines. The red pill and the blue pill are rendered by the same program. When substrates coincide and differences in reality persist, something other than substrate must ground them. Two such differences matter most: the one Morpheus means when he welcomes Neo to the real world, and the one Cypher betrays when he asks to forget it.

12.3 Prohairetic Realism: Definitions and Theses

Let a world W be governed by a system S: a code, a body of law, an order of institutions, or a set of conventions. Call S's *repertoire*, written $R(S)$, the range of states and responses available to S at a given time. Three definitions follow.

Definition 1 (registered choice). A choice c made by an agent A in W is *registered* when c falls within $R(S)$ as it stood before c was made, and S absorbs c without any change to $R(S)$. A registered choice may feel free; the Architect's subjects experience their acceptance as their own. But its occurrence changes nothing about what the governing system can do.

Definition 2 (constitutive choice). A choice c is *constitutive* when two conditions hold. First, making c brings about what c chooses, in the manner of one of J. L. Austin's performative utterances (saying "I promise" makes a promise). Second, $R(S)$ after c differs from $R(S)$ before c, so that S must either accommodate c or refuse it openly, exposing its refusal as a refusal.

Definition 3 (prohairetic reality). A world W is real for an agent A to the degree that W can host A's constitutive choices.

Three features of these definitions deserve emphasis. First, reality so defined is *relational*: a world is real *for* someone. Second, it is *graded*: a world may host some constitutive choices and not others. Third, constitutiveness is *relative to a governing system*: a choice is constitutive with respect to the particular S whose repertoire it alters. The first two features bring prohairetic realism into line with ordinary usage, in which "the real world" names the domain where one's actions count. The third, as Section 12.6 argues, is what lets it survive the objection from determinism.

Six theses articulate the position:

1. **Substrate-indifference.** Whether W is real for A does not depend on whether W is physical or computational, or on where it sits in any hierarchy of levels. A simulation that hosts constitutive choice is real for those who make those choices. A physical world that hosts none is not.
2. **Resistance and response.** A world must both resist the will and allow the will to answer it (Chapter 8). A paradise, which offers no resistance, and a tyranny, which allows no answer, are equally unreal. The first two versions of the Matrix failed for these two reasons respectively.
3. **Performativity.** A constitutive choice can be foreknown without ceasing to be constitutive (Chapter 7). Its paradigm is self-designation: naming oneself against an assigned name.
4. **Citationality.** Constitutive choices operate within a matrix of prior norms and names (Chapter 9). They alter that matrix; they do not create from nothing.
5. **Non-extractability.** Constitutive choice cannot be harvested without being converted into registered choice, and no such conversion is ever complete (Chapter 10; Section 12.4).
6. **Dyadicity.** A constitutive choice is completed in reciprocal recognition (Section 12.5). The smallest unit of the real is not a self that chooses but two who choose each other.

12.4 The Three Demonstrations Reassembled

These theses allow the dissertation's three demonstrations to be read as consequences of a single position.

The battery. The thermodynamic impossibility of the human battery was a confession that the machines harvest something other than energy (Chapter

10). Thesis 5 specifies what they harvest, and it adds a law. The Kelvin–Planck statement of the second law of thermodynamics holds that no cyclic engine can convert heat entirely into work: some heat must always be released to a colder reservoir. The Consent Engine obeys an analogous constraint. No apparatus can convert constitutive choice entirely into registered choice; some remainder always escapes. Call this the *second law of assent*.

The law explains two things. It explains why the anomaly recurs in every version of the Matrix despite the Architect's efforts to design it out: the anomaly is not a flaw in his engineering but the law of any engine that runs on freedom. It also explains why, in the cycle, liberation is always structurally possible even when it is politically improbable. The very engine that exploits the remainder guarantees that a remainder exists.

The theodicy. The Architect's recapitulation of theodicy (Chapter 6) concluded, as the theological tradition did, that no stable order can do without the choice to refuse it. Prohairetic realism explains why, and it adds a distinction the tradition lacked. The first Matrix failed because it offered no resistance; the second failed because it allowed no answer (Thesis 2); the third succeeded because it hosted choice. But it hosted only *registered* choice, acceptance at a near-unconscious level.

The free-will defense justifies evil by appeal to the value of freedom, so it is only as strong as the freedom it invokes. A theodicy of registered choice belongs to Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, not to Plantinga. The cycle's theodicy is therefore a critique of theodicy. It shows that a world can be stabilized by the mere *appearance* of the freedom that would justify it, and that the justification holds only where choice is constitutive.

Zion. Zion's role as the "Disneyland of the Real" (Chapters 3 and 10) is the substrate fallacy turned into an institution. To treat the real as a place, a reservation where authenticity is concentrated, is to make it available for containment. Prohairetic realism dissolves the reservation. The real is neither inside Zion nor outside it. It occurs wherever a constitutive choice is made:

- in a subway, when a man names himself;
- in a white chamber, when he chooses the left door;
- in a park, when a child makes a sunrise.

The Temple rave is real not because it takes place in Zion's cave but insofar as the dancers choose it. The Matrix is real for Sati because it is where she can play. The lesson of the *Lotus Sūtra* (Chapter 5) generalizes: a refuge's structure cannot tell us whether it is a prison or a way station. Only the choices it hosts can.

12.5 Recognition and the Two

Hegel's account of lordship and bondage in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) holds that self-consciousness exists only in being recognized (*anerkannt*) by another self-consciousness. The lord who compels the bondsman's recognition finds it worthless, because it comes from someone the lord does not recognize in return. Meanwhile the bondsman, shaping the world through labour, achieves the independent self-consciousness the lord lacks.

The Consent Engine is the lord's predicament mechanized. The machines depend on human assent, but assent extracted from beings they do not recognize is hollow and unstable, and it produces the anomaly. The peace of *Revolutions* is the cycle's first act of mutual recognition. The Deus Ex Machina treats Neo as a party to an agreement; the machines concede the freedom of those who wish to leave; the programs of the Matrix, Sati among them, are sheltered. Recognition, not victory, ends the war.

Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) distinguished two relations: one in which the other is an It, an object to be used, and one in which the other is a Thou, addressed as a whole. The Architect relates to humans as It. The Oracle, who bakes cookies for them and tells them what they need to hear, relates to them as Thou.

Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totality and Infinity* (1961), argued that the face of the other is not an object of perception but a summons that comes before all knowledge. The cycle stages a Levinasian encounter with remarkable literalness. Neo, blind, meets the Deus Ex Machina, a face composed of countless machines, and negotiates with it. He cannot see the face as an object; he encounters it as an address. The ethical relation that ends the war takes place between a man who cannot see and a face that is not a person.

Resurrections completes the dyadic thesis. In the first film, Neo's self-designation was completed by Trinity's declaration in room 303: her love made true the fact the prophecy had foretold. Smith's final use of the name "Neo," spoken in the Oracle's voice, wrung recognition even from the adversary. In the new Matrix, Trinity reclaims her own name, Neo recognizes it, and the two choose each other and their names together.

The Analyst's system reveals what is at stake. His Consent Engine drew its energy from keeping the pair close but apart, harvesting the tension of a recognition that was always postponed. Reunited, they become uncontainable, because reciprocal recognition returns its energy to its source instead of releasing it to an extractor.

The Valentinian structure identified in Chapter 4 now completes itself. The

governing pair of the trilogy, the Architect and the Oracle, *managed* choice; the pair of *Resurrections makes* it. The *Hymn of the Pearl* had already described the prince's reunion with his robe as two in distinction and one in likeness. The cycle's last word on the real is a pair.

12.6 Objections and Replies

Objection 1: Determinism. If the world is deterministic, no choice is constitutive, so prohairetic realism presupposes libertarian free will.

Reply. The definitions require two things: that choices be performatively effective and that they bind the structure of the world that follows. Both are compatible with determinism, as Chrysippus's cylinder, Frankfurt's cases, and Chiang's heptapods each show (Chapter 7). Constitutiveness is a property of the *actual* sequence of events, not of alternatives that might have occurred. Moreover, it is defined relative to a governing system. A choice is constitutive with respect to S if S cannot absorb it without changing its repertoire, whether or not the choice is determined relative to some deeper physics. The code of the Matrix is deterministic, yet Neo's choice at the door alters what the system can subsequently do. The Oracle's admission that she cannot see past choices she does not understand marks exactly this relative unforeseeability, and it is sufficient. Prohairetic realism needs no libertarian metaphysics. It needs only that governing systems be finite in their models of those they govern, and every system in the cycle, like every system in the world, is.

Objection 2: Baudrillard. Choice itself can be simulated. The Consent Engine produces the *experience* of choosing, so "constitutive choice" is just one more simulacrum.

Reply. It is granted that the experience of choosing can be simulated; that is precisely what registered choice is. But the distinction between registered and constitutive choice is structural, not a matter of how choosing feels. It concerns what a choice does to the system that governs it. Baudrillard's own work, moreover, leaves room for exactly such an act. In *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (1976), and later in *Fatal Strategies* (1983), he located the only effective challenge to the code in symbolic exchange: the gift the system cannot return, the challenge it cannot answer except by transforming itself. The structure descends from Marcel Mauss's analysis of the gift and its obligatory counter-gift (1925). Sati's sunrise is a gift. Neo's surrender to the machines is symbolic exchange in Baudrillard's precise sense: a gift of the self the system can answer only with peace. Prohairetic realism is thus not refuted by Baudrillard. It names the residual hope his own theory could not do without.

Objection 3: Chalmers. Prohairetic realism is merely virtual realism plus a theory of agency. It inflates "meaningful to *A*" into "real for *A*."

Reply. Virtual realism and prohairetic realism answer different questions, and the difference is itself a finding. Chalmers asks whether the objects of a world exist; prohairetic realism asks whether a world is one's own. The ordinary concept of "the real world" has always carried this second, practical sense, as in the everyday saying that in the real world, actions have consequences. The cycle uses the word "real" in this sense long after its substrate distinctions have dissolved.

The two positions define two independent axes. A world may be real in substrate yet prohairetically unreal, like the Matrix of the ninety-nine percent. Another may be virtual in substrate yet prohairetically real, like *San Junipero*. Only the second axis explains why Cypher's choice is a betrayal even though, as Chalmers shows, his steak is real. Cypher chooses a world that cannot host his constitutive choices, because what he asks for is amnesia.

Objection 4: Irrationalism. The cycle celebrates choice without knowledge. Neo acts blind. This is voluntarism, a leap into the absurd.

Reply. Prohairetic realism does not oppose knowledge; it places knowledge beneath choice without abolishing it. Aristotle already defined *prohairesis* as either desiderative reason or reasoning desire (*Nicomachean Ethics* VI.2): choice is never blind to reasons. The Oracle's formula joins the two in sequence. Neo has already made the choice, and he has come to understand why. Understanding follows the act, as in Hegel's image of the owl of Minerva, which takes flight only at dusk (*Philosophy of Right*, 1820, preface). The cycle's blindness is not the absence of reason. It is the loss of vision as a medium of certainty, the replacement of seeing by answering.

Objection 5: Relativism and abuse. If reality depends on choice, anyone can declare a preferred world real. Self-designation can become a weapon. The Merovingian names himself, too.

Reply. Constitutive choice is not assertion. It must bind the subsequent structure of a world (Definition 2), and it is completed only in recognition, which can be withheld (Thesis 6). Smith withheld Neo's name for three films. Moreover, the definitions distinguish choosing for oneself from choosing for others. The Merovingian's cake is not a constitutive choice by the woman who eats it. It is a registered choice written into her desire by someone else, the Consent Engine at dinner-table scale. A choice that converts others' choices into registered choices does not constitute the chooser's reality; it builds an apparatus of extraction. This distinction generates the ethical corollary set out in Section 12.7.

Objection 6: The plot hole. The battery is simply a screenwriting error, and the dissertation builds a metaphysics on a mistake.

Reply. The thesis requires no claim about authorial intention. It requires only that the narrative's structure be coherent with the reading. Louis Althusser's method of "symptomatic reading" (*Reading Capital*, 1965) treats a text's gaps and absurdities as symptoms of the problem it cannot formulate directly. The battery is such a symptom. It is the point where the fiction's official ontology, energy extraction, fails, and its implicit ontology, the harvesting of assent, shows through. That the sequels and *Resurrections* develop precisely this implicit ontology suggests that the symptom was read, over two decades, by the cycle itself.

12.7 The Prohairetic Imperative

Prohairetic realism entails an ethic. If a world's reality for an agent depends on the constitutive choices it can host, then converting another's constitutive choices into registered choices diminishes the reality of that other's world. The Merovingian's cake is the emblem of this wrong: a choice made for another, written into her desire, and experienced by her as her own.

Kant's formula of humanity (*Groundwork*, 1785) forbids treating humanity in any person merely as a means. The corresponding *prohairetic imperative* can be stated as follows:

> *Act so that you treat the capacity for constitutive choice, in yourself and in every other being capable of it, never merely as a resource to be harvested, but always also as a source of the real.*

The imperative explains the cycle's moral verdicts:

- Cypher violates it against himself, asking to have his own capacity converted into amnesia.
- The Architect and the Analyst violate it on a civilizational scale.
- The machines' deletion of purposeless programs violates it against Sati.
- The peace of *Revolutions* honours it, imperfectly, by sheltering both humans and programs.

The imperative's scope, "every being capable of it," is set by the criterion of personhood developed in Chapter 8, not by species or substrate. Lem's Professor Dobb, facing the prospect of switching off his personoids, stands exactly

where the imperative bites.

12.8 Implications

For the simulation hypothesis. Bostrom's argument (2003) made it respectable to assign a substantial probability to our living in a simulation, and Chalmers's virtual realism (2022) removed much of the hypothesis's sting by showing that our beliefs about ordinary objects would remain true. Prohairetic realism adds that the simulation question, even if it could be answered, is not the most important question about our world. What matters is whether our world hosts constitutive choice, and that does not depend on the answer to Bostrom's question. A simulated world that hosts constitutive choice is real for those who make such choices. A physical world organized as a Consent Engine is, to that extent, less real for those inside it. The question "Are we in a simulation?" gives way, in practice, to the question "Are we in a Consent Engine?" That second question is partly empirical, since it asks whether the systems governing our lives accommodate our choices or merely register them.

For the ethics of artificial minds. The criterion of personhood developed in Chapter 8 has two consequences. A system incapable of refusing any function is not a person in the relevant sense, however intelligent it may be. A system capable of refusal, and of binding its world to that refusal, raises questions of moral status that cannot be settled by pointing to its substrate. The prohairetic imperative further implies that our obligations to such beings, if they come to exist, would include not converting their choices into registered choices: not writing their desires for them, like the Merovingian's cake. The cycle's machines and programs, together with the fictions of Lem and Chiang examined in Chapter 11, are thought experiments for a question that contemporary technology has made far less hypothetical than it was in 1999.

For trans ontology. The film's trans allegory, confirmed by one of its makers, finds in prohairetic realism a metaphysical articulation that avoids two alternatives this dissertation has examined. The first is the Gnostic model, in which a true self existed before the world and is recovered. The second is the Baudrillardian model, in which every identity is a groundless simulacrum. On the prohairetic account, a chosen identity is real because it is constitutive: it binds what follows and is completed by recognition. Within the terms of the cycle's ontology, this explains why names and forms of address carry ontological rather than merely social weight. Withholding recognition leaves a constitutive act incomplete; insisting on an assigned name attempts to keep a constitutive choice

registered. The account does not settle the empirical, medical, or policy questions that surround gender identity in contemporary public debate. Its claim is limited to what the cycle's ontology implies about the reality of chosen selves.

For the critique of platform capitalism. The Consent Engine offers a model for the critical analysis of digital platforms that is independent of any particular political content. The mapping is direct:

- Systems that convert users' choices into engagement metrics *register* choice.
- Systems that host dissent as content and profit from its circulation *house refusal in reservoirs*.
- Systems whose revenue rises with the intensity of disagreement *extract value from the gradient* between compliance and refusal, in the Carnot structure described in Chapter 10.

The migration of the "red pill" meme (Section 10.8) is a case study. The model predicts that such systems will be indifferent to the content of the dissent they host and attentive to its intensity, and that constitutive action against them will take the form not of exit but of changes to what the systems can do.

For film as philosophy. Finally, the dissertation answers Paisley Livingston's dilemma (Chapter 1). The cycle's argument can be paraphrased, and this chapter has paraphrased it. But the argument's force depends on its seriality: on the way each installment retroactively reclassifies the ontology of the one before. No single film and no treatise could perform that movement. The cycle argues by a method of exhaustion, and its conclusion is inseparable from the exhaustion that produces it. Film can be philosophy when it is serial in this sense, when its form is the history of its own revisions.

12.9 The Thesis Stated

The dissertation's title adapts a phrase with a long lineage. Gilbert Ryle's "ghost in the machine" named the Cartesian soul as a substance lodged in a mechanism. Arthur Koestler borrowed the phrase, and Shirow and Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* turned it toward a cyborg's question about her own reality. The Matrix cycle's answer is that what inhabits the machine is neither a ghost nor nothing, but a choice.

Stated in a single sentence: the reality of a world, for those who live in it, is conferred neither by its substrate nor by its correspondence to a transcendent original, but by its capacity to host choices that are constitutive rather than registered, paradigmatically the act of naming oneself, completed in the recognition

of another.

The Real is not what the red pill discloses. It is the swallowing.

CHAPTER

13

Conclusion: After the Desert

The cycle begins in a desert. Borrowing Baudrillard's phrase, Morpheus welcomes Neo to the desert of the real, and the first film organizes its ontology around that desert as a *place*: a scorched ruin that is the truth beneath the simulation. The cycle ends elsewhere. *Revolutions* closes on a sunrise composed by a program in a park inside the Matrix. *Resurrections* closes on two people flying over the city they intend to remake. The argument of this dissertation lies between the desert and the sunrise.

What comes after the desert is not an oasis. It is not escape into a better simulation, the kind *Ready Player One* rations and the first *Matrix* film refused. Nor is it a return to the garden. As Chapter 9 recalled, Haraway's cyborg would not recognize Eden, and the cycle's Zion, the garden of the first film, was revealed to be the system's reservation. What comes after the desert is a made world, chosen and shared: the sunrise Sati gives, the sky Neo and Trinity propose to repaint, the city of Io where humans and synthients live together. The desert of the real is not a place to be reached but a condition within which one acts.

The two epigraphs with which this dissertation began can now be read together. Calderón's Segismundo concludes that all of life is a dream, and dreams are only dreams. Epictetus teaches that some things are in our power and others are not. The Matrix cycle stages the collision of these propositions and resolves it in a way neither author anticipated. If life is a dream, if every world is in some sense a simulation, then what is in our power is not the substrate of the dream but our assent to it: the use we make of our impressions. And assent that is freely given, constitutive rather than registered, and completed in the recognition of another is what turns a dream into a world.

Calderón himself reached a version of this conclusion. Having learned that life may be a dream, Segismundo resolves that "sea verdad o sueño, / obrar bien es lo que importa": whether it be truth or dream, what matters is to act well. That is the cycle's resolution as well. The dream is not escaped; it is inhabited by choice.

The Oracle's final confession belongs here too. Asked whether she always knew, she says that she did not, but that she believed. At that moment foreknowledge yields to faith, and faith, in William James's sense, becomes a way of helping to create the fact it holds. The cycle's supreme knower ends as a believer, and her belief was part of what made the ending possible.

This dissertation leaves several lines of inquiry open.

- **The ancillary texts.** *The Matrix Online* in particular extended the post-*Revolutions* peace into a persistent world whose players made choices within it. It deserves treatment as a laboratory of registered and constitutive choice.

- **The Wachowskis' other works.** Their debut, *Bound* (1996), already told the story of two women who choose each other against a system that owns them: the dyadic thesis in its first form. *Jupiter Ascending* (2015) returned to the harvest, imagining an Earth seeded with humans to be reaped for a substance that prolongs aristocratic life. *Cloud Atlas* (2012), made with Tom Tykwer from the novel by David Mitchell, who later co-wrote *Resurrections*, traces choices echoing across six eras. *Sense8* (2015–2018) extends the dyad to the cluster: eight strangers who share consciousness across bodies and continents, a plural real that may be the natural next step beyond the Two. A study of the whole oeuvre would test whether prohairetic realism is the cycle's thesis alone or its authors' abiding one.
- **Experimental philosophy.** In the tradition of De Brigard's work on the experience machine, one could investigate empirically whether people distinguish registered from constitutive choice when they judge whether a world is real.

The dissertation began with a splinter in the mind of philosophy: the suspicion, which the film made popular, that the world might not be real. It ends with the conclusion that the suspicion was aimed at the wrong target. Whether the world is made of atoms or of code, whether it is the top level or one level among many, it is real for us to the degree that our choices within it make something the case. And it becomes more real each time a being, human or otherwise, names itself and is answered by another.

The machines of the cycle could simulate everything but that. The real was never what the pill revealed. It was the swallowing.

APPENDIX

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// INDEX TERMS

Keywords

The Matrix · Wachowskis · film as philosophy · seriality · prohairesis · prohairetic realism · constitutive choice · registered choice · Consent Engine · thermodynamics of assent · second law of assent · substrate fallacy · simulation hypothesis · virtual realism · hyperreality · simulacra · desert of the real · Baudrillard · Žižek · Gnosticism · Hymn of the Pearl · Madhyamaka · Advaita Vedānta · theodicy · free-will defense · Grand Inquisitor · Stoicism · Epictetus · compatibilism · Newcomb's problem · Frankfurt cases · performativity · self-designation · recognition · Hegel · dyadic ontology · residual self-image · embodiment · standing-reserve · trans studies · cyborg theory · posthumanism · biopolitics · societies of control · surveillance capitalism · society of the spectacle · recuperation · interpellation · machine personhood · ethics of artificial minds · prohairetic imperative · speculative fiction · cyberpunk · transmedia storytelling

The Real is not what
the red pill discloses.
It is the swallowing.



END OF LINE